

Lucy Tweed

Every. Night. Of. The. Week.

MEAT
FREE
BEYOND
Monday



*A zero-
tolerance
APPROACH
TO BLAND*

VEG

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It's a daily slog to get veg into the mouths of every member of the household. Welcome to your sanity solution: delicious meals that vegetarians and meat-eaters will love in equal measure, served with a generous dollop of Lucy Tweed's trademark wit.

Choose your own daily adventure!

Monday Cowboy Pasta Dreams

Pasta every which way, because there's nothing as truly weeknight

Toned-down Tuesdays

Big, bold flavours with a laid-back attitude; one-pan where possible

Saucy Wet Wednesdays

Soups and curries and slurries and spice

Carbs-filled-with-things Thursdays

From loaded buns and spuds to lovely things squashed into dough, this is comfort central

Phat Snack Fridays

Throw-it-together munchies with two criteria: 1. Use it up and 2. Make it irresistible

The Bold and the Beautiful Saturday Salads

Show-off salads that take the spotlight come BBQ day

Sunday Oeufs

If you say it in French, it's sexier. All your egg needs for Sunday

Sweet Anytime Treats

Just because!

**Every. Night. Of.
The. Week.
VEG**

This book is for my kids:
James, Beau & Winter.

One day you will do, say or eat something just like
me and I hope when you do the joy:cringe ratio is
even.

I love you.



Every. Night. Of.
The. Week.
VEG

Meat-free beyond Monday.
A zero-tolerance approach to bland.

Lucy Tweed

murdoch books
Sydney | London

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Introduction

**I need to start with a confession.
I'm not a vegetarian.**

Am I allowed to write a vegetarian book? Am I qualified?

A friend asked me if this book was going to be cheese heavy ... I felt defensive. They didn't ask me that when I wrote a book with meat included.

I said 'No.'

I lied. Of course I use cheese. Sh*tloads.

Plus, a ton of eggs. And butter. Carbs – in all their glory. And – don't freak out – but this book includes VEGETABLES. LOADS.

What if we called it meat-free – that's probably more appropriate.

The object of this book is not to reduce fat, remove flavour or limit happiness. I'm not asking you to join a cult or commit to this every day.

It's about exploring variations. The possibilities. The fun.

It's about turning to the fridge crisper before the freezer.

My husband – a Kiwi raised on meat and veg – is known to respond to my food with 'This is so delicious! I can't believe there's no meat in it.'

And that's what makes this book essential.

Not what's lacking, but everything it has: flavour, texture and playfulness.

I love food. Most of it. I feel left out if I don't like something.

I went on a love crusade for mushrooms when I was young, and dear choko, I'm not there yet, but I admire you. Thank you, guac, for luring me into an avo-passion that hasn't ended. (I just don't think some foods are my people: natto, this is you, babe, sorry.)

Lifting veg from token to hero in a 'you-won't-notice-it's-meat-free' way is easy when you're pumped up about it. The upsell – or perhaps side-sell – comes naturally.

But there's a potential spanner in the (dinner) works: family. We must feed and nourish them while respecting their immature, undistinguished, sometimes revolting desires. Up to a point.

Growing up, my mum would take any opportunity to stuff a sun-warmed, slightly hairy baby bean picked straight from the vine into my gob. 'Taste this!' she'd exclaim.

My dad would normalise cuisines. 'This is San Chow Bow!', he'd announce proudly about yesterday's reheated bolognese with added peas and lettuce cups.

It's the excitement that matters most. And it's catching.

Getting food in mouths midweek is the destination, but the journey should be exploration, indulgence and laughter.

The chapters in this book are arranged as the days of the week.

Monday: quick-fix spaghetti bliss.

Tuesday: the day when we all lose a sock (HTF!?) – it's best to put everything into one pan/pot or tray.

Wednesday: saucy wet Wednesday, of course. All the stuff that needs spooning and mopping.

Thursday: carbs, stuffed with all the things.

Friday: stuffed/crumbed/fried snacks all round. Make more, call the neighbours.

Saturday: big, beautiful and body proud salads. These babies take the spotlight come BBQ day.

Sunday: all day oeuf. Breakfast, lunch and dinner eggs.

Extra play day: sweets. Quick-fix and bold adventures. Did you even know vegetarians eat sweets!!!!?

Every recipe's deliciousness is subjective (not just here, but EVERYWHERE!), and I urge you to tweak them to suit yourself and your family.

If in doubt, just crumb it and add tomato sauce. Most kids will eat a small section of cow dung if served that way*. And I still add token veg to everything because it confuses them, and I like mind games like that.

Always play with your food,

Lucy x

*not tested yet



Dominating

TIPS & TRICKS OF THE TRADE

Being the alpha in the kitchen is crucial. These are the things I do to make the most of ingredients.

Leafy guys

- Straight up think about the journey produce has been on to get to your fridge. We all need a soak and a big drink after a long trip and veg is no different.
- Storing your herbs properly can mean the difference between 3 and 8 days of freshness. Rinse and wrap them in paper towel, put them in a snap-lock bag or airtight container and toss them back in the fridge.
- Trimming and washing lettuce before you pack it away is both a time-saver and an extender.
- Icing salad herbs is a stylist trick to keep things perky on set, and worth doing at home too. At the start of making a big salad, pick all your herbs and put them in a large bowl of icy water for about 20 minutes. They will drink and spring up.

Cold queen

- When herbs do start to lose their vibrancy, pick the leaves and discard any that have decayed. Blend the rest with olive oil and

store in a jar in the fridge, or freeze in ice-cube trays. What you have now is the perfect flavour hit for pastas and soups, or to stir through mayo for a great sambo condiment.

- Make enough salad dressing for a week, store it in a jar and splash it liberally when needed.
- Don't discard pickle juice and olive brine!!! Just top them up with veg offcuts, or add them to a martini.
- For ultra-crisp carrots, celery and radish, store them in a container in the fridge with a puddle of water.

Freezer hacks

- When ordering takeaway, buy a second container of steamed rice for the freezer. That's half a meal done on time-poor nights.
- Save your stale bread. Trim off the dry crusts, tear the bread into chunks and freeze it. When you need a crispy crouton, just toss with oil and salt and bake until golden.
- Make double of anything that you can freeze. Ragu, soup, gnocchi, dumplings.
- Don't be a freezer elitist. Having back-up frozen veg can change a last-minute dinner from boring and beige to a jazzy little festival of food.

Longer leftovers

- If you've made more filling for wontons or dumplings than you can deal with, any excess makes a great midweek stir-fry – it's

already seasoned and full of great things.

- A stale loaf of bread can be revived by wetting it thoroughly under cool running water, then placing it into a preheated oven at 200°C (400°F) for 15 minutes, or until crispy, fresh and bouncy. It's like magic.
- You can also use up stale bread by breaking it into chunks then blending it in a food processor to form fine crumbs – perfect to use later in pangrattato, as a lasagne topping, or for general breadcrumbing.
- Blend left-over roast vegetables with tinned tomatoes for the ultimate pizza sauce or with stock and cream for a velvety soup.

Pantry party

- Use round sticky dots or a black marker to label the top of your spice jars. I store mine in a big Tupperware container and this saves me from the intensely irritating lift-and-search method.
- Storing dry goods in jars keeps them fresh, plus it means basics like flour, sugar and rice all get topped up before they run out because you can see them.
- Cool, dark and dry – the pantry is the favoured place for onions, garlic and spuds. Remove any packaging and pop them in a cloth bag or basket.
- Extreme trigger warning: throughout this book I regularly call for chicken- and beef-style stock. These readily available veg-

based stocks are so good (in flavour and ingredients), I used them for years BEFORE I realised they were vegetarian.





Monday Cowboy Pasta Dreams

There is nothing as truly weeknight as a pot of pasta.

Eight minutes to al dente felt like an hour when I was a kid. Hungry from mucking about with ponies, pretending to be a cowboy and running up and down hills, a bowl of long or short was the ultimate inside hug of comfort before bed. It still is, though the ponies are now my kids, and the hills are laundry piles in the hallway.

I like pasta in every size, shape and colour – salty, chewy, crispy, saucy, soft, slippery.



One-Pot Business

Internal dialogue appreciation post.

I can't help it; I think about roast chicken when I think about this dish – I don't know why!

Can you be vegetarian and still think about meat, or is that a complete faux pas? Not being one myself, I don't know all the finer points ... all I know is this is a very delicious dish. And if your thoughts are going to offend, you should probably keep them to yourself.

Although that could be boring.

Due to the size of the pasta I've used here, this only serves 2. You could certainly double everything to serve 4, but choose a smaller pasta like ditalini, or use a bigger pot (keep stirring though so everyone gets a go being on the bottom with all the saucy juice).

Serves 2

1 tablespoon dijon mustard
¼ cup (60 ml) lemon juice
2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil
1 brown onion, thinly sliced
½ cup (110 g) marinated artichokes, chopped
½ cup (110 g) pitted green olives
1 tablespoon capers
2 garlic cloves, sliced
¼ cup (60 ml) white wine

¼ cup (60 g) salted butter
250 g (9 oz) rigatoni
10 basil leaves
10 dill sprigs
3 cups (750 ml) vegetable stock
¼ cup (25 g) finely grated parmesan
2 tablespoons finely grated lemon zest

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

chicken

Combine the dijon and lemon juice. Set aside.

Heat the olive oil in a large deep frying pan over medium–high heat. Pan-fry the onion for 5 minutes, until soft, then add the artichokes, olives and capers and cook until the edges have a golden brown crust, around 5 minutes. Add the garlic and sauté for 2 minutes.

Pour in the wine and boil, stirring, to deglaze the pan, or until the wine has mostly evaporated. Add the butter and stir well.

Add the rigatoni and herbs. Pour the mustard/lemon juice mix and the stock on top of the pasta.

Cover with a lid and simmer on the stove for 25 minutes, until cooked and beginning to crisp on the edge. The pasta should be al dente and still bubbling.

Stir through the parmesan and lemon zest before serving.





Supergreens Gnudi

Crispy, soft, plump, chunky, rough dumplings – I think we can all relate. Send (G)nudis stat.

If you are undone by the sin* of conveniently prepared frozen spinach, then you could always de-spine, cook, squeeze and chop fresh if you like. You'll need approximately 75 kg (165 lb) of fresh leaves to yield 2 cups once wilted (estimating the weight of cooked-down leafy greens from a fresh bunch is pointless).

Serves 4–6

500 g (1 lb 2 oz) frozen spinach, kale or any other leafy green
500 g (1 lb 2 oz) fresh ricotta (the deli kind in a basket because it's drier)
4 eggs, lightly whisked
1 cup (100 g) finely grated parmesan
pinch of ground nutmeg
1 cup (150 g) plain (all-purpose) flour
semolina, for sprinkling
¼ cup (50 g) buckwheat
veg oil, for frying
1½ tablespoons extra virgin olive oil
2 tablespoons salted butter
1 garlic clove, finely chopped
1 teaspoon chilli flakes
30 g (1 oz) rocket (arugula)
2 tablespoons lemon juice

100 g (3½ oz) halloumi, grated
2 tablespoons finely grated lemon zest

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

plates

Thaw, squeeze and chop the greens in a food processor or with a knife. The blitzing level is up to you. The leafier bits are harder to roll, but rude, nude and rustic is what's so great about these gnudi, so I blitz for a bit, remove half and purée the rest.

Reunite the spinach in a bowl and add in the ricotta, eggs, parmesan, nutmeg and flour. Mix well to combine.

You can add herbs, garlic or zest to the dumplings but I like to boss my dinner about not the other way around. Keep it simple and you can whip this out of the freezer anytime. Pick your flavours then.

Prep a tray or plastic container with baking paper so you can layer these. Have a small bowl of semolina for sprinkling at the ready.

Using two tablespoons, one to scoop and one to scrape, shape the dough into little dumplings and dollop them onto the tray.**

Sprinkle a bit of semolina over them as you go to prevent them sticking to each other.***

Fry the buckwheat in 1 cm (½ inch) veg oil in a small saucepan over high heat. They will get crispy and some will puff like mini popcorn in less than 10 seconds. Scoop these buckinis out onto paper towel and set aside.

You can cook (fresh or frozen) gnudi just as you would gnocchi, in plenty of simmering salted water, scooping them out as they float

and tossing with your fave sauce, but my preference is to cook them like potstickers. Choose a non-stick frying pan that can hold as many serves as you'd like to make in a single layer – usually about 20 would be the most! Heat 1½ tablespoons olive oil over medium heat and place the gnudi in a single layer with a bit of space between each one.

As they begin to sizzle, add some water so that it comes halfway up the side of the dumplings. Cover the pan with a lid and allow it to simmer for 5–8 minutes. Listen for a change in fry sound from watery bubble to oily sizzle. Gently toss and loosen the gnudi and push to the side. Add the butter and, when it foams, add the garlic, chilli and rocket. Toss the whole lot for a few minutes, until the garlic softens slightly, then add in the lemon juice for a final stir through.

Cover in halloumi, lemon zest and buckinis before serving.

* Not at all a sin: frozen spinach is highly nutritious and delicious!

** If you have neither skill nor patience for quenelling, then you could pipe the dumplings onto the tray using a snap- lock bag with the corner snipped off.

*** To freeze gnudi, arrange the freezer so you can slide the entire tray in, then after 4 hours you can move them into a snap-lock bag.





Vegemite Cacio e Pepe

Start by calling shotty on NOT cleaning up after this dinner.

Cacio (in my mind) is not an ingredient ... it's a situation. Catchy, sticky cheese will coat the pan, forks, tongs, spoons, bowls – it's a f*cking nightmare.

My hack: just soak everything overnight in cold water then, when that doesn't work, simply throw all the dishes out (plus everything you've attempted to clean them with). Nonetheless, this pasta is worth every drop of elbow grease.

Serves 4

¾ cup (185 g) softened salted butter

¼ cup (40 g) Vegemite*

500 g (1 lb 2 oz) bucatini

2 garlic cloves, finely chopped

2 tablespoons freshly ground black pepper

2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil

1½ cups (150 g) grated pecorino

1½ cups (150 g) grated grana padano

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

linguine instead of bucatini if you plan on eating this on a first date

In a standmixer fitted with the paddle attachment, mix the butter and Vegemite until well combined.**

Cook the pasta in a large saucepan of heavily salted water with a timer set to 2 minutes before al dente (as the packet directs).

Meanwhile, in a large heavy-based non-stick frying pan, fry the garlic and pepper in olive oil over medium heat until fragrant, about 4 minutes.

Add about $\frac{1}{4}$ cup (60 g) of the Vegemite butter and swirl it around in the resulting insane froth until the smell makes your mouth water.

Add 1 cup (250 ml) of pasta water to the pan and simmer for 1 minute.

Tong the pasta straight over from the cloudy boiling water into the buttery pan.

Reduce the heat to low and add the grated cheeses in $\frac{1}{2}$ cup (50 g) increments, tossing it around with tongs. This is not a big tall toss, more a shimmy, shake, fold and stir.

Add another scoop of pasta water if you like – the stirring-water-butter-cheese-pasta-gluten makes the sauce in this one. It's the riz-oh-toe effect, yeah?

Remove the pan from the heat and make sure it's all as glossy, slippery and silky as something worn to the Met Gala. Add more water if you need to.

Serve immediately. This one benefits from that artful tonged swirl we all aspire to – but that's just for presentation. If you enjoy this dish as much as I do, it doesn't matter how it flops from the pan to the bowl to the mouth, as long as it doesn't hit your chin while hot.

* If Vegemite is unavailable or you are ultimately opposed to this ingredient, sub it out for Marmite or even miso for that umami punch.

** Srsly, make a second batch and continue beating until the butter is creamed. Chuck it in a jar for camping or at-home toast – now you can have ‘people’ make you toast without the ratio being f*cked up.





Zucchini Carbonara

To cream or not to cream – actually it's not a question.

The creamy texture of this dish is created with egg yolk, cheese, pasta water and a very attentive level of stirring, swirling and tossing at the right time.

You cannot walk away from this dish. It's like an attention-demanding 4-year-old attempting something completely unspectacular ... if you avert your eyes for even a second then the result will be a claggy, unemulsified mess. And as most of us with kids will attest, if your child is unemulsified, well, you just have to start again.

Serves 4

1 leek, white part only, julienned
2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil
1 garlic clove, coarsely chopped
¼ cup (60 g) salted butter
2 large zucchini (courgettes), julienned
10 basil leaves, large ones sliced, small kept whole
1 egg
2 egg yolks
2 cups (200 g) finely grated parmesan
500 g (1 lb 2 oz) spaghetti
fine salt and freshly ground black pepper, to taste

In a large frying pan over medium heat, sauté the leek for 3 minutes in olive oil, until it begins to darken and crisp up.

Add the garlic and butter and cook for a further 2 minutes.

Finally add the zucchini and basil and toss through for 1 minute. This step is to soften the zucchini, not necessarily cook it.

Remove the pan from the heat.

Meanwhile, combine the egg, yolks and grated cheese in a large serving bowl. Mix well.

Cook the pasta in a large saucepan of heavily salted water to al dente.

Ladle a few tablespoons of pasta water into the egg and parmesan mixture to temper it, then top with the sautéed veg.

Tong the steaming hot pasta straight over from the cloudy boiling water to the serving bowl.* Toss it through the mixture quickly for at least 1 minute to combine it all. Season as needed.

The eggs will begin to set into a creamy texture, and the parmesan will melt and become a deliciously perfect host to tendrils of spaghetti, zucchini and leek.

* If you'd rather drain than tong your spaghetti into the bowl, then make sure to reserve 1 cup (250 ml) of pasta water before doing so. This is possibly the most important ingredient in any pasta dish, and slowly we are understanding the concept, but it still has to be stressed every time.





Sweet Corn Pillows

Sometimes the fancy just happens and you find yourself dining.

Often when flavours meet, the exchange exemplifies a perfect mutualism: Corn + Miso = 2gether 4eva (with butter as a lubricant).

Serves 6–8 (5–6 pillows each)

¼ cup (50 g) corn kernels, drained if from a tin

125 g (4½ oz) tinned creamed corn

235 g (8½ oz) fresh ricotta

1 teaspoon finely grated lime zest

¼ teaspoon paprika

¼ teaspoon garlic powder

¼ teaspoon white pepper

1 tablespoon finely snipped chives

1 egg white, whisked until foamy (not stiff)

40 round gow gee wrappers

DESIRABLE SAUCE

2½ tablespoons white miso paste

½ cup (125 ml) white wine

⅔ cup (160 g) cold salted butter, cubed

1 long red chilli, seeds removed, finely diced

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

lots of parmy and linen napkins

Combine both the corns, the ricotta, lime zest, paprika, garlic powder, pepper and chives in a bowl and mix well. Fold the egg white through gently.

Lightly flour a large tray where you can rest your dumplings as you make them.

Using a brush and water, lightly wet one side of a gow gee wrapper. Place a tablespoon of corn mixture in the centre of each wrapper, leaving a 1 cm (½ inch) edge. Place another wrapper over the top and seal all around with your fingers, pushing out as many air pockets as possible – you want the dumpling/ravioli/pillows to remain full once cooked and not deflated and saggy ... don't get distracted.* Set the pillows aside on the floured tray until ready to cook.**

For the desirable sauce, whisk together the miso paste and white wine in a large frying pan over medium heat until combined and beginning to bubble, around 2 minutes. Add in the cold butter and continue to whisk so that it emulsifies as it melts. Sprinkle with the chilli. Set aside and keep warm.

When you are ready, poach the pillows in plenty of salted simmering water for 5 minutes. Scoop the pillows out with a slotted spoon, place them directly into the pan of desirable sauce and gently swish around. Add a scoop of pasta water if the sauce needs loosening.

This last saucy bit is best done in batches of two serves, but you can be bold and ignore me and I am sure it will be absolutely fine.

* Oh! Insert a fancy step here! If this is a 'dinner party/extra moment' then you should absolutely make the filling mound neat and tidy by pressing a shot glass over the top, then use a 10 cm (4 inch) cookie cutter to trim the edges to perfection à la 90s perfect food intention.

** These dumplings are ideal frozen and whipped out straight into boiling water. You can freeze them for a few months in an airtight container.





Snipped Noodles in Vodka Sauce

Pasta and dancing? No one knew about gluten then.

It's far-fetched to include a homemade pasta dough recipe for a Monday night, but a) you'll rejoice at knowing this super slack and utterly satisfying shape-making technique, and b) you can just sub it out for some perky little favourite shape on Monday, and have this beauty up your sleeve for showing off on the weekend with friends and/or enemies.

Serves 4

parmesan, for sprinkling

NOODLE DOUGH

2 cups (300 g) tipo 00 flour

1 teaspoon fine salt

$\frac{2}{3}$ cup (170 ml) warm water

3 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil

semolina, for dusting

SAUCE

650 g (1 lb 7 oz) tomatoes, coarsely chopped

1 leek, white and pale green parts only, sliced into 1 cm ($\frac{1}{2}$ inch) thick rounds

3 tablespoons fresh oregano leaves

1 teaspoon sea salt flakes, plus extra for sprinkling

1 teaspoon freshly ground black pepper

2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil

½ cup (125 ml) vodka

⅓ cup (80 ml) thick (double) cream

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

martinis, of course

For the noodle dough, place the flour and salt in the bowl of a standmixer fitted with the dough hook and set the speed to low. Add the water and oil in a slow, steady stream, mixing until a ball forms, around 1–2 minutes. Increase to medium speed and mix for 4–5 minutes, or until the dough is soft and elastic. Wrap in plastic wrap and rest for 20 minutes (pasta is lucky with the amount of enforced resting it goes through!).

This is the fun/precarious bit. Holding the rested ball over a semolina-dusted surface, begin snipping small slivers off the ball with scissors. You will gain momentum. Just remember to adjust your fingers away from the snipping zone as you do. Little eye shapes will fall to the bench and they will have an organic rib or curl along their edge, which makes for the perfect sauce boat.

If you realise your snipping has been somewhat irregular, just snip the larger ones in half. There's no rule to how big they should be – you can make them tiny if you like! I have made 1.5 cm (⅝ inch) ones for this recipe. Cover them with a cloth until ready to use or freeze them for anticipated post-club dining.

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced.

For the sauce, massage the tomatoes, leek, oregano, salt and pepper with the oil in a bowl. Spread out in a flameproof baking dish and roast for 25 minutes.

Transfer the tomato mixture to a large jug or bowl and blend with a stick blender until it becomes a smooth purée. Push this mix through a sieve so it's extra fine. (I understand this is excessive. This step is possibly more for those who discotheque. You can, of course, opt for the tracksuit version and not sieve at all.)

You should have about 2 cups (500 ml) of sauce, which is about what you would get in a bottle of bought passata (this is an ultimate shortcut hint for you!).

Place the baking dish over high heat, pour in the vodka and boil, stirring to deglaze (but not for too long – this is one time you don't want the booze burning completely off). Add the tomato purée and bring it to a simmer. Stir through the cream and remove the dish from the heat.

Bring a big pot of salted water to a rapid boil and add the pasta. Once the pasta floats to the surface (about 2 minutes), use a slotted spoon to scoop the pasta from the boiling water and place straight into the vodka sauce.

Add a scoop of pasta water and toss well before covering in an 80s discotheque level of snowy parmesan.





Ribbons in Crackling Oil

Content warning: birth stories and boiling oil.

When my last baby was slow to arrive, I tried a bunch of stuff to move things along. Jumping on a trampoline and eating crackling oil noodles were my favourite, but both seemed to comfort her as much as me. Also like me, when she's ready to roll, she has very little patience. Thankfully we made it to the hospital with about 8 minutes to spare.

Crackling oil is also called 'boiling oil' (it just feels a little terrifying put like that as we don't want to actually boil it). You want your oil hot enough so that when it's poured on herbs, spices, etc., it immediately starts to crackle, bubble and froth.

Serves 4

250 g (9 oz) fresh lasagne sheets
2 teaspoons szechuan peppercorns
2 teaspoons chilli flakes
2 tablespoons finely grated fresh ginger
4 garlic cloves, finely chopped
1 teaspoon Chinese five-spice
1 tablespoon sesame seeds
1 tablespoon dark soy sauce
1 tablespoon soy sauce
1 teaspoon black vinegar
½ teaspoon fine salt
2 teaspoons sesame oil

2 spring onions (scallions), white parts minced, green tops thinly sliced and set aside

1 cup (250 ml) peanut oil

1 bunch Chinese water spinach,* cut into 5 cm (2 inch) lengths

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

shaved celery and celery tops

Cut the fresh lasagne sheets into ribbons – the thickness is up to you, I'm into super-fat 3 cm (1 ¼ inch) ribbons. It's fun. But 1–1.5 cm (½–5⁄8 inch) thick is great. (Instead of sheets, you can use really fat pappardelle, or the frilly-edged noodles you can sometimes find in Asian supermarkets.)

Roughly grind the szechuan peppercorns and chilli flakes in a mortar and pestle and transfer to a heatproof serving bowl. Add the ginger, garlic, Chinese five-spice, sesame seeds, dark soy sauce, soy sauce, black vinegar, salt, sesame oil and the white part of the spring onions.

Heat the peanut oil in a large heavy-based saucepan over medium heat until it reaches shimmering point (it can begin to smoke but not excessively).

Meanwhile, bring lots of salted water to the boil in a large pot. Cook the lasagne ribbons according to packet directions until 1 minute before al dente, then add the Chinese water spinach and spring onion tops and cook for 1 minute more.

Carefully remove the shimmering oil from the heat and immediately pour it over the aromatics in the bowl. Add the well-drained pasta and stir everything together well.

Serve immediately.

* Chinese water spinach is a favourite but very seasonal green where I live. Swap out for bok choy or Chinese broccoli (gai lan) – regular broccoli is great too!





Cheese & Tomato Lasagne

This is an incredibly successful lasagne. Like, corporate-box successful.

Tangy, cheesy, carby, saucy = vibe. The combination of tomatoes, fresh and tangy and thick and sweet, is what makes this dish exciting.

Serves 6–8

BIG BATCH BESHY

4 quantities Baby Beshy ([here](#))

$\frac{3}{4}$ cup (105 g) grated mozzarella

$\frac{1}{2}$ –1 cup (50–100 g) grated cheddar

SAUCE

5–6 tomatoes, coarsely chopped

6 garlic cloves, smashed

$\frac{1}{4}$ cup (7 g) oregano leaves, tightly packed, chopped

2 tablespoons red wine vinegar

1 teaspoon white (granulated) sugar

1 teaspoon fine salt, plus a pinch extra

1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil, plus extra for drizzling

700 g (1 lb 9 oz) tomato passata (puréed tomatoes)

3 stalks basil

freshly ground black pepper, to taste

250 g (9 oz) fresh lasagne sheets, which I will be blanching,
regardless of pack instructions

110 g (3¾ oz) buffalo mozzarella ball, sliced into 6–7 rounds (as many as you can manage, actually)

½ cup (30 g) panko breadcrumbs*

¼ cup (25 g) finely grated parmesan

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

green salad at the ready

Make a big batch of beshy and add the cheeses, stirring over medium heat until you have a smooth sauce, around 5 minutes.

I mean, you could stop there. Just fondue your evening away, naked.

Although, that kind of carry-on should at least be reserved for Thursday.

In a mixing bowl, toss the tomatoes with two-thirds of the smashed garlic, half the oregano, the red wine vinegar, sugar and salt (think SUPER tangy). Set this aside to macerate for 10 minutes or so.

In a medium saucepan over medium heat, sauté the remaining garlic with a pinch of salt and 1 tablespoon of olive oil for 2 minutes, until golden. Add the passata, the remaining oregano and the whole basil stalks and season with freshly ground black pepper. Simmer for 10 minutes, until it becomes lava-like and rich. Set aside to cool.

Meanwhile, blanch the lasagne sheets and set aside in cool water to stop them sticking.

Remove the basil stalks from the sauce, then pour the sauce over the macerating tomatoes and toss well.

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced.

Take a 30 x 7 cm (12 x 2¾ inch) round ovenproof dish and slap 2 tablespoons of tomato sauce and a drizzle of olive oil on the bottom. Then layer: pasta, toms, beshy, pasta, toms, beshy, pasta etc. – finish with pasta and beshy. Top with fat slices of buffalo mozzarella, a sprinkling of panko crumbs and grated parmy.

Bake for 30 minutes, then remove it from the oven and let it sit for a while before eating so you don't liquefy from the inside out as a result of the searing tomato and cheese heat.

Please try this. It is so, so delicious.

* I use KookAKrumb panko to avoid palm oil!





Baked Pumpkin Gnocchi

My 'double down' on cheese instinct is pretty intense.

It was during the creation of this particular dish that I pondered my cheese-consumption levels.

While this book is vegetarian and relies on a bounty of beautiful vegetables, I can't and happily don't claim that it's light on anything really – flavour especially.

As it turns out, the cheese ratio is very well balanced with all the lemon, garlic and fresh things.

Of course you could omit the cheese, but then that is, perhaps, another story ...

Serves 4

800 g (1 lb 12 oz) kent pumpkin (squash), peeled and cut into 4 cm (1½ inch) chunks

4 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil, plus extra for drizzling

1 egg yolk

½ cup (50 g) finely grated parmesan

pinch of ground nutmeg

fine salt and freshly ground black pepper, to season

1½ cups (220 g) plain (all-purpose) flour

260 g (9¼ oz) tomato passata (puréed tomatoes)

2 tablespoons single (pure) cream

2 tablespoons white wine

40 sage leaves

150 g (5½ oz) soft blue cheese, coarsely chopped

150 g (5½ oz) mozzarella, coarsely chopped

SALAD

2 teaspoons honey

2 tablespoons red wine vinegar

2 small pears, thinly sliced

3 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil

120 g (4¼ oz) rocket (arugula)

sea salt flakes and freshly ground black pepper, to taste

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

parmy on the salad

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced.

Toss the chopped pumpkin with 2 tablespoons olive oil and place on a baking tray lined with baking paper. Bake for 40 minutes, until lightly browned on the edges and soft.

Mash the cooled pumpkin in a large mixing bowl. Add the egg yolk, parmy and nutmeg and stir with a fork until just combined. Season, then add 1 cup (150 g) of flour, gradually adding more and stirring until the dough is just not sticky. Don't over-stir: you don't want to activate the flour. The dough should remain soft.

Turn the dough out onto a lightly floured surface and knead gently.

Divide the dough into 6–8 balls, then roll each one into a 1.5 cm (⅝ inch) thick log. Cut each log into 1 cm (½ inch) sections so you have little puffy pillow rectangles.*

Grease a tray with 1 tablespoon of the olive oil and place it next to your stovetop, ready to catch the gnocchi. Bring a large saucepan of salted water to a rapid simmer. Poach about 20 gnocchi at a time. Remove the gnocchi with a slotted spoon when they float to the top – around 1 minute – and place on the oiled tray.

In the base of a large baking dish, place 1 tablespoon olive oil, the passata, cream, white wine and half the sage leaves and mix together. Nestle the gnocchi in, then top with the remaining sage and cheeses.

Drizzle with olive oil and place in the oven until golden and bubbling, about 20 minutes.

Meanwhile, in a salad bowl, combine the honey and red wine vinegar and toss the pear in the mixture until it's coated. Just before serving, add the olive oil, rocket and parmesan. Season with S+P and toss well.

* If you make more than you need, freeze the leftovers for another time. They'll keep for a few months in an airtight container. Throw frozen gnocchi straight into boiling water and cook as above.





Vegan Pad Thai

Actually the vegan is optional, as are the eggs in this recipe.

Don't freak. But it's vegan without cheese. Like, for reals vegan. Until I add the optional eggs. Please adapt by ignoring them.

Also, if you haven't crumbled tofu yet you MUST try it – it's soft, bouncy and basically a vessel for whatever flavour you want!

Serves 4

500 g (1 lb 2 oz) firm tofu, crumbled

3 eggs, lightly whisked (optional – obviously must be removed for vegans)

175 g (6 oz) oyster mushrooms, sliced

1 bunch garlic chives, cut into 5 cm (2 inch) strips (or 1 red/brown onion, finely sliced)

1 baby wombok or ½ big wombok, shredded

200 g (7 oz) rice noodles, soaked in cold water for 1 hour

1 cup (115 g) bean sprouts, hairy ends picked off

1 cup (30 g) coriander (cilantro) leaves

⅓ cup (50 g) chopped toasted peanuts

1 lime, cut into wedges

PAD THAI SAUCE

2 tablespoons tamarind paste

2 tablespoons white miso paste

2 tablespoons soy sauce

4 tablespoons soft brown sugar

1 tablespoon sesame oil

PAD THAI PASTE

½ cup (125 ml) peanut oil

1 tablespoon fine salt

1 lemongrass stem, the first 10–15 cm (4–6 inches) only, roughly chopped

1 makrut lime leaf, chopped

1 spring onion (scallion), white and green parts, chopped

1 cm (½ inch) knob of ginger, peeled and chopped

1 garlic clove, chopped

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

eggs – just get a marker and cross them out if they are that offensive

In a small bowl, stir the tamarind, miso, soy, brown sugar and sesame oil until smooth. This will be the pad Thai sauce.

Then, using a food processor or stick blender, blend the peanut oil (reserving 2 tablespoons for greasing the pan when frying batches of veg), salt, lemongrass, lime leaf, spring onion, ginger and garlic to make the pad Thai paste.

Crumble and fry the tofu with the paste in a wok or very large frying pan over medium–high heat until crispy, around 10 minutes. Set it aside.

Look, sorry vegans – truly. The eggs are optional. But if you are opting to use them – now is the time. Use the same pan as you did the tofu in – just add a lick of peanut oil and then pour in the egg. Swirl the egg pancake over medium heat until just set, about 2

minutes. Remove from the pan, roll up the egg pancake and roughly chop. Set aside also.

Pan-fry the mushrooms in the reserved peanut oil over high heat until the edges are golden brown, around 5 minutes, then add the garlic chives and fry for a further 1 minute.

Add the shredded wombok, noodles and half the sauce to the pan. Carefully toss together.

Add back in the tofu and egg (if using). Toss well.

Serve in a large bowl with the remaining sauce drizzled over the top and lots of bean sprouts, coriander leaves, chopped peanuts and lime wedges.

This is gooooooooood!





Lady & The Tramp

The origin story for this is both G & M rated.

Poor man's bolognese, puttanesca sauce and peasant's pasta: three incredible flavours and textures created in Italy during extremely hard and fast times.

Each of these recipes has its own history but what they all have in common is that they are made from basic, cheap pantry ingredients.

The name Lady and the Tramp hints at the origin story of puttanesca – and the fact that it is so delightfully slurpable, you will be hoping to end a single mouthful with an accidental kiss, just like in the Disney classic.

Serves 4

3 tablespoons Bready Pesto from [here](#)

2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil, for frying

PICI DOUGH*

2 cups (300 g) tipo 00 flour

$\frac{2}{3}$ cup (170 ml) warm water

3 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil

KALAMATA SALSA

$\frac{1}{2}$ cup (75 g) pitted kalamata olives, coarsely chopped

2 tablespoons baby capers, coarsely chopped

$\frac{1}{4}$ cup (5 g) parsley leaves, coarsely chopped

2 tablespoons finely grated lemon zest

1 tablespoon red wine vinegar

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

a lover to suck the other end of your noodle

To make the picci dough, combine the flour, warm water and olive oil in a standmixer fitted with the dough hook on medium speed for 2 minutes, or until the dough has come together. Turn out onto a lightly floured surface and knead for 4–5 minutes, until smooth. Cover in plastic wrap and rest for 30 minutes.

Make the Bready Pesto from [here](#) and set aside.

To make the kalamata salsa, combine the olives, capers and parsley in a small bowl with the lemon zest and red wine vinegar. Set aside also.

Cut small sections of the pasta dough at a time and roll them into long thin strands on a very lightly floured surface. (It actually helps if there's not too much flour on the benchtop when you are rolling.) The beauty of this pasta is it is irregular: thicker in some bits, thinner in others. This is a perfect pasta to get your kids to help with.

Place the rolled pasta onto a lightly floured tray and cover with a tea towel until ready to cook.

The next bit comes together relatively quickly, with fresh pasta and a flash-in-the-pan style sauce. It's a good idea to have everything ready to go before anything goes in the pan.

The pasta should be cooked in a large pot of heavily salted boiling water, and will only take 30 seconds to 1 minute.

Meanwhile, in a large deep frying pan, heat 2 tablespoons of olive oil over medium–high heat. Add the bready pesto and heat it through until aromatic, 1 minute or so. Use tongs to add the pasta straight from the boiling water into the pan with the pesto and toss to coat. Add about $\frac{1}{2}$ cup (125 ml) of pasta water to loosen the sauce and toss to combine.

Serve immediately topped with the kalamata salsa.

* Replace the pici dough with store-bought spaghetti and premake the pesto & salsa and you're 10 minutes from door to dinner glory!





Shortstop Bowls

A rolling boil. Heavily salted. A flash in the pan. A blitz of flavours. A stir of textures. A shower of parmy. And a scrunch of pepper.

Very fast. Very easy. Very delicious. Weeknight pasta hacks for snack attacks.

MEMO! Always keep a scoop of pasta water, always drizzle with olive oil.

Serves 4

Angel Hair & Tomato Sunshine

- 5 large ripe tomatoes
- 1 garlic clove, smashed
- 1 shallot, finely chopped
- 1 teaspoon sea salt flakes

1 teaspoon white (granulated) sugar
¼ cup (7 g) loosely packed basil leaves, chopped
1 tablespoon red wine vinegar
¼ cup (60 ml) extra virgin olive oil
500 g (1 lb 2 oz) angel hair pasta
¼ cup (25 g) finely grated parmesan

Cut the toms in half and grate the flesh into a bowl. Macerate with all that other good stuff: garlic, shallot, salt, sugar, basil, red wine vinegar and olive oil.

Cook the pasta, then toss through the toms and tons of cheese.

Burnt Broc Mac 'n' Cheese

4 cups (240 g) broccoli florets
2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil
500 g (1 lb 2 oz) macaroni
¼ cup (60 g) salted butter, cubed
2 cups (200 g) grated cheddar
1 cup (230 g) cream cheese, cubed
1 teaspoon fine salt

Preheat the oven to 220°C (425°F) fan-forced. Toss the broccoli in oil and bake it on a baking paper-lined baking tray for 15 minutes.

Cook and drain the macaroni.

Melt the butter in the empty pasta pot, add the cheddar, cream cheese, pasta, salt and broccoli and stir well.

Herby Chunk Pesto

1 cup (140 g) frozen or fresh peas
1 cup (155 g) frozen broad beans
1 garlic clove, coarsely chopped
¼ cup (5 g) mint leaves
¼ cup (15 g) dill
¼ cup (5 g) parsley leaves
½ cup (50 g) finely grated parmesan
¼ cup (60 ml) extra virgin olive oil
500 g (1 lb 2 oz) horseshoe pasta (or any short pasta shape)
½ cup (100 g) goat's curd
1 pinch of chilli flakes (optional)

Place the thawed peas and beans in a small bowl with the garlic, herbs, parmesan and oil. Use a stick blender or food processor to blitz the mixture until the desired texture is achieved.

Cook the pasta, then stir through the pesto with a bit of the pasta water. Top with goat's curd (and chilli if you want).



Toned-down Tuesdays

I like my Tuesdays with a little less effort but still a lot of impact.

Take whatever straps you wore to be ‘official’ off for the day – ties, bras, belts, helmets, mascara all included – pour yourself a long glass of tea – long island or herbal – and let’s do big bulky flavours with a pretty laid-back attitude.

The concept here is: avoid the stovetop altogether or cut down on pan count.

Take some time to answer the ‘socks’ question (see [here](#)).

I don’t know about you, but for me, Tuesday often presents me with about as much energy as a gumboot full of water. The weekend was a century ago and an infinity ahead. Today seems like the day everything is overdue. Let it win. Forfeiting is my new power move.



Ultra Ratta Tarte Tatin

Kinda ratatouille without the sophisticated stacking.

Ultra. Ratta. Tarte. Tatin.

Sounds exactly like an 80s frat or sorority house.

Although there is no hazing on this guy, the beauty of the layering is that you don't need to stress about the size of the veg all matching so you can create that perfect layered effect of overlapping circles.

Serves 4

2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil

1 zucchini (courgette), cut into 5 mm (¼ inch) rounds

1 brown onion, cut into thin rings

1 eggplant (aubergine), cut into 1 cm (½ inch) rounds

2 tomatoes, cut into 5 mm (¼ inch) rounds

fine salt and freshly ground black pepper, to season

230 g (8½ oz) fresh ricotta (the deli kind in a basket)

½ cup (50 g) grated cheddar

2 tablespoons finely grated lemon zest

1 garlic clove, smashed

¼ cup (60 g) basil pesto (store-bought is fine)

2 sheets ready-made frozen puff pastry, cut into 30 cm (12 inch) rounds

small handful of basil leaves, to sprinkle on top

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

obedience & basil leaves

Preheat the oven to 180°C (350°F) fan-forced. Grease a 28 cm (11 ¼ inch) non-stick ovenproof frying pan with 1 tablespoon of the olive oil.

Layer the zucchini in the pan first, then the onion, eggplant and tomatoes – seasoning each layer with S+P as you go.

Drizzle with another tablespoon of olive oil and bake for 20 minutes. Remove the pan from the oven and add 2 tablespoons water, then return it to the oven for a further 10 minutes.

Remove from the oven and allow to cool slightly in the pan, around 10 minutes.

Increase the oven temperature to 250°C (480°F) fan-forced.

Combine the ricotta, cheddar, lemon zest, garlic and pesto in a medium bowl.

Spoon the ricotta mixture on top of the tomatoes, leaving a 2 cm (¾ inch) bare edge around the circumference to tuck the pastry into.

Place both the pastry sheets on top of the cheese and tuck in at the sides. This will give you an extra crispy layered puff. If you can get your hands on some home-made or really thick puff, then you'll only need one layer.

Pop the pan back in the oven and bake for 15–20 minutes, watching carefully for puffy perfect crispness. Rotate the pan if there is a hotspot and any areas are getting too dark.

This next step is pretty daring: let the pan cool slightly to avoid anything too hot and too dangerous, then flip the pan straight onto your serving plate.

You can decorate with a few flicky little basil leaves.

Cut into wedges to serve.





Bombay Wish Potatoes

I've never been to Mumbai but I've been to me.

This baby's namesake is making me wish I was in Mumbai – but now that I've said it out loud it may not come true.

Crispy flatties, chewy potatoes and an intensely flavoured classic Indian green chutney: this dish is kind of like an inside-out rustic dosa or a deconstructed aloo paratha. Which I am FINE with.

It's an incredible medley of flavours and textures that makes for a truly enjoyable eating experience.

Serves 4 as a snack or side

1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil

FLATTIES

1⅔ cups (250 g) wholemeal (whole-wheat) self-raising flour, plus a little extra for rolling

1 cup (260 g) Greek-style yoghurt

1 teaspoon fine salt

2 teaspoons extra virgin olive oil

¼ cup (30 g) chopped spring onion (scallion), white and green parts

POTATOES

¼ cup (60 ml) ghee, melted

1 red onion, thinly sliced

2 garlic cloves, smashed

30 curry leaves

½ teaspoon turmeric powder
1 teaspoon brown mustard seeds
1 teaspoon white mustard seeds
2 teaspoons curry powder
½ teaspoon fine salt
1 big head broccoli, trimmed and cut into florets
1 kg (2 lb 4 oz) potatoes, cut into 1 x 3 cm (½ x 1¼ inch) chunks,
skins on

CHUTNEY

2 cups (60 g) coriander (cilantro) leaves
1 cup (20 g) mint leaves
1 tablespoon finely grated fresh ginger
3 garlic cloves
2 teaspoons cumin powder
1 teaspoon fine salt
1 teaspoon white (granulated) sugar
1 tablespoon lime juice

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

yoghurt, coriander and lime and rosé

Preheat the oven to 220°C (425°F). Line a baking tray with baking paper.

Place all the flatty dough ingredients in the bowl of a standmixer fitted with the dough hook and mix on medium speed until well combined. Turn down to low and continue mixing for 10 minutes. Set aside covered in a warm place for an hour to rest. It may rise a bit but that's not essential so don't worry – sometimes the wholemeal weighs it (and everything) down.

For the potatoes, place the ghee, onion, garlic, curry leaves and spices into a large bowl and mix to combine.* Add in the broccoli and potato and mix well. Scatter on the baking tray and bake for 25 minutes, or until the potatoes are crispy on the edges and soft in the middle.

Meanwhile, for the chutney, simply blend all the ingredients plus 2 tablespoons of water in a food processor until the mixture is emulsified and smooth. The quantity is more than you will need but it's so delicious you will be happy for leftovers! Store leftover chutney in a jar in the fridge for up to 1 week or freeze for later days.

Roll out handfuls of flattish dough on a lightly floured surface and pan-fry in a non-stick frying pan with the olive oil over medium heat. They should take around 3 minutes each side and be golden and slightly charred when done. Keep warm until serving.

Serve everything together so each person can build their own plate of perfection.

* Use a spoon or kitchen gloves so you don't stain yourself yellow.





Honey Soy Cauli

When cauliflower is not being 'rice' for paleos, it can be 'chicken' for vegos.

The sticky, chewy business of baking rice with flavours is with us to stay, my friends.

It's a classic lazy approach disguised as a big flavour move. (It's actually both!) And so satisfying, because it's basically set and forget.

Cauliflowers are the greatest sauce-trappers, too.

Serves 4

¼ cup (70 g) white miso paste
2 garlic cloves, crushed
¼ cup (60 ml) honey
2 tablespoons soy sauce
2 tablespoons rice vinegar
2 teaspoons sesame oil
2 spring onions (scallions), finely chopped, whites and greens separated
8 cm piece of ginger, peeled and julienned
1 large cauliflower, cut into 8 wedges*
3 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil
2 cups (440 g) white rice
½ teaspoon Chinese five-spice
½ teaspoon fine salt

1 teaspoon sesame seeds

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

blanched greens and Chilli Crisp from [here](#)

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced.

Blend the miso, garlic, honey, soy, rice vinegar, sesame oil, spring onions (white parts only) and a quarter of the ginger in a food processor until smooth.

Toss the cauliflower through this mix, making sure to coat it really well.

In a large roasting tray big enough to fit the cauliflower in a single layer, combine the olive oil, rice, remaining ginger, Chinese five-spice and salt.

Cover with 3 cups (750 ml) of water and gently shake the pan to level out the rice.

Place the cauliflower into the water, then cover tightly with foil.

Bake for 20 minutes, then uncover and bake for a further 25 minutes, basting with any remaining marinade for the final 5 minutes.

Serve with sesame seeds and the green parts of the spring onions.

* Cauliflower can take a while to roast. If you're short on time, blanch (4 minutes), steam (10 minutes) or microwave (4 minutes) the pieces prior to tossing them in the sauce.





Pizza Rice

Oh hey there, covergirl. All the flavours of a vegetarian supreme baked into crispy, chewy rice.

Trust me, rice can feel like pizza. I am completely about this dish – it has it all. Great flavour, chewy textures and a one-pot situation so proud it's basically gloating.

There's pretty much nothing better.

Serves 4

½ red onion, thinly sliced
3 garlic cloves, thinly sliced
⅓ cup (80 ml) extra virgin olive oil, plus extra for drizzling
4 button mushrooms, thinly sliced
2 teaspoons dried oregano
½ cup (80 g) pitted black Spanish olives, thinly sliced
1–2 roasted marinated red capsicums (peppers), thinly sliced
2 marinated long-stem artichokes (or 4 short-stem), halved
1 teaspoon fine salt
¼ cup (60 g) salted butter
2 cups (440 g) arborio rice
200 g (7 oz) tomato passata (puréed tomatoes)
1 punnet cherry tomatoes or 2 small trusses of baby truss tomatoes
fine salt, to season
¾ cup (105 g) sliced mozzarella

1 burrata, torn

½ cup (50 g) finely grated parmesan, for sprinkling

50 g (1¾ oz) rocket (arugula)

small handful of basil leaves

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

chilli flakes

Preheat the oven to 180°C (350°F) fan-forced.

In a large ovenproof frying pan, sauté the onion and garlic in the olive oil over medium–high heat for 2 minutes, until starting to soften. Add the mushrooms, oregano, olives, capsicum, artichoke and 1 teaspoon of salt and fry for a further 1 minute. Add the butter and arborio rice, reduce the heat to medium and stir well to coat the rice in the butter and pan flavours.

Add the passata and about 600 ml (21 fl oz) of water.

Top with cherry tomatoes (or baby truss). Drizzle with 1 tablespoon olive oil and sprinkle with salt to season.

Place the pan in the oven. After 25 minutes, remove the pan from the oven and top with sliced mozzarella and a drizzle of olive oil. Return the pan to the oven to cook for a further 10 minutes, until the cheese is melted and bubbling.

Top with torn burrata, parmesan, rocket and basil when serving.





90s Scissor Slice

The anti-prove pizza is a lack-of-patience best friend.

In the 90s, these were floppy, oily & super thin metre-long pizzas. They could be scissor-cut to order from the counter in 15cm (6 inch) sections, skimmed with cheese and sparingly placed but delicious toppings.

The 90s food m.o. was ‘height equals flavour’. These were Calvin Klein-esque by comparison – until you ate five.

Makes two 30 x 40 cm (12 x 16 inch) pizzas

1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil
2 teaspoons semolina, for dusting
125 g (4½ oz) mozzarella
130 g (4½ oz) tomato passata (puréed tomatoes)
1 handful baby rocket leaves

MUSHROOM TOPPING

2 cups (180 g) sliced mushrooms (field, Swiss and button are all great – if you want cheap authenticity then just do the button)
1 garlic clove, smashed
2 tablespoons white wine vinegar
1 teaspoon fine salt
¼ cup (60 ml) extra virgin olive oil
½ cup (30 g) finely chopped curly parsley

PIZZA DOUGH

3 cups (450 g) plain (all-purpose) flour

1 teaspoon instant yeast
¾ cup (185 ml) lukewarm water
2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil
1 teaspoon fine salt
¼ teaspoon white (granulated) sugar

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

chilli flakes & cigarettes

Combine the mushroom topping ingredients and allow to marinate for half an hour. Resist eating as is.

Preheat the oven to 240°C (475°F) fan-forced. Oil your two largest baking trays and dust them with semolina.

Grate the mozz and set aside.*

Combine the dough ingredients until smooth and elastic (by hand or standmixer). Don't let it rise! (Key component of the 'less time is better value' motto for recipes around here.)

Divide the dough in half and roll out two thin rectangles to fit the trays.

Divide the passata between the two pizzas and brush right to the edges (yes!). Divide the mozz between both and top with evenly scattered 'shrooms.

(If this were another book I'd 100% add anchovies here but don't worry, I'm not even going to mention it.)

Bake until bubbling on top and the crust is cooked, around 15 minutes. Top each pizza with the rocket leaves.

* Hot tip: freeze the mozzarella for 5 minutes before grating to make it less like grating a silicone breast implant (guessing here).





Nachos Mess

Being beautiful and a sloppy bog is possible.

I realise the reason I don't often want to eat nachos is that I get full while cooking, but that doesn't stop the desire for this scoopable snack situation. So damn good.

Serves 4

500 g (1 lb 2 oz) corn chips

1 corn cob, kernels removed, covered with boiling water for 5 minutes, then drained

1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil, for drizzling

NACHO SAUCE

½ brown onion, finely diced

1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil

3 garlic cloves, smashed

1 celery stalk, finely chopped

2 tablespoons Mexican Seasoning from [here](#)

1 tablespoon chipotle in adobo

400 g (14 oz) tinned black beans

400 g (14 oz) tinned refried beans

1 tablespoon tomato paste (concentrated purée)

SMOKED CHEESE SAUCE

2 tablespoons salted butter

1½ tablespoons plain (all-purpose) flour

2 cups (500 ml) milk

3 cups (300 g) grated smoked cheddar

250 g (9 oz) tinned creamed corn

SALSA

2 roma tomatoes, seeds removed, flesh diced

1 jalapeño, thinly sliced

1 small red onion, finely diced

large handful coriander (cilantro) leaves, chopped

sea salt flakes and freshly ground black pepper, to taste

DRIZZLE

1 cup (245 g) sour cream

2 tablespoons lime juice

1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil

1 tablespoon hot water

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

in my house $\frac{3}{5}$ people hate avos, so I only add them when feeling spiteful – but this would go so well with a good guac

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced.

First, make the nacho sauce. Sweat the onion over medium heat in a large frying pan with olive oil for 5 minutes. Add the garlic, celery and spice mix and fry for a further 5 minutes. Add the chipotle, black beans (don't drain), the refried beans and tomato paste. Sauté for 10 minutes, then add $\frac{1}{2}$ cup (125 ml) of water and simmer until reduced – a further 10 minutes. Set aside.

For the cheese sauce, in a medium saucepan over medium heat, melt the butter, then stir in the flour to form a smooth golden paste. Cook for 2 minutes, then add the milk and whisk until smooth.

Add the smoked cheese and creamed corn and cook until thick and the cheese has melted, around 8 minutes. Set this aside.

For the salsa, toss together the tomatoes, jalapeño, red onion and coriander leaves in a small bowl. Season with S+P.

In the base of a 30 x 40 cm (12 x 16 inch) ovenproof dish, place alternating spoonfuls of the nacho and cheese sauces, using about half of each. Nestle corn chips vertically into this, then fill the gaps with the remaining nacho and cheese sauce.

Scatter the corn kernels about and then drizzle the whole thing with olive oil.

Bake for 15 minutes, until the chips are toasted and the filling is hot.

Meanwhile, combine the sour cream, lime juice, olive oil and hot water in a bowl and mix well.

Straight out of the oven, dribble the salsa and sour cream mixture on top. Eat from the tray.





Only Sides

All the bits and pieces for a perfect roast dinner – hold the hero, thanks.

Quite frankly, there is very little room in the oven (or time or energy) for meat in this recipe anyway.

It's the OnlyFans version of a big roast: it's OnlySides.

Serves 4

2 kg (4 lb 8 oz) unwashed potatoes, peeled and quartered
2 parsnips, peeled and halved lengthways
2 apples, halved across the middle
1 tablespoon lemon juice
90 ml (3 fl oz) honey
4 carrots, cut diagonally into 5 cm (2 inch) chunks
1 brown onion
250 g (9 oz) green beans, tops removed
1 cup (130 g) frozen baby peas
2 tablespoons rice bran oil
⅓ cup (90 g) salted butter
¼ cup (60 ml) milk
fine salt and freshly ground black pepper, to taste
½ bunch thyme sprigs
¼ kent pumpkin (squash), skin on and seeds removed, cut into 3
cm (1 ¼ inch) wedges
1 head garlic, root end cut off, skin left on

4 rosemary sprigs

1 cup (250 ml) gravy* from [here](#)

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

wholegrain mustard

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced.

Soak half the potatoes in cold water to remove some of the starch while you prepare the other veg.

Put the parsnip and apple in a bowl with 1 cup (250 ml) of water, lemon juice and 1 tablespoon of the honey.

To peel or not to peel carrots? That is the question. Either way is great, but your enthusiasm will help you decide.

Cut the onion into 1 cm (½ inch) rings with the skin on (be careful, it's slippery!), then just remove the outer ring and voila! It is peeled.

Place the beans and peas in a heatproof bowl ready for blanching.

Now that your veggies are prepped, it's a time game – everything has its own needs.

Dry the soaking spuds, then toss them in 1 tablespoon of the rice bran oil, place them on a large shallow-sided tray and roast them for 20 minutes.

Boil the remaining potatoes in plenty of salted water until soft – 20 minutes – then drain in a colander. Place the pot back on the stove on medium heat with half of the butter and the milk. Once the butter is melted add the spuds back in and mash well. Season to

taste, cover and keep warm until serving (you may need to reheat with a bit more milk and butter later).

Melt the remaining butter and honey together in a small saucepan. Line a second tray with baking paper and place the parsnips, onion rings, apples and thyme on the tray. Cover with honey butter and 1 tablespoon of the lemon water. Toss well. Season with salt and pepper. Position the apples face up.

Toss the carrots and pumpkin in the remaining rice bran oil.

Turn the oven down to 180°C (350°F) fan-forced and place the tray of parsnips and so on in the oven. At the same time add the carrots, pumpkin, garlic (cut side down) and rosemary to the potato tray.

Roast for a further 30 minutes, checking and turning the veg (turn the apples face down) after 15 minutes.

Meanwhile, blanch the beans and peas by pouring freshly boiled water over them and letting them sit for 5 minutes. Drain and season with salt and butter to taste.

Heat the gravy and reheat the mash if necessary before serving.

* Make the gravy ahead of time and freeze. Defrost in the fridge overnight and reheat on a whim (in a small saucepan over medium heat, stirring, for 10 minutes).





Stacked Eggplant Parm

A lava-like tray of heaven.

When someone tags #squadgoals, your mind might flit to model-esque ‘you can’t sit with us’ types. Me? I think of fat-belly beauties: the Venus of Willendorf, mozzarella and eggplant.

I’m going to ask you to use two pans in this recipe, but I promise it’s low-key cooking. Low key and lazy and resulting in soft, sweet eggplant, rich and tangy toms, molten golden cheese and chewy potato gems.

That’s hot.

Serves 4

2 eggplants (aubergine)
2 teaspoons sea salt flakes
2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil
260 g (9¼ oz) tomato passata (puréed tomatoes)
400 g (14 oz) tinned cherry tomatoes
3 garlic cloves, crushed
¾ cup (45 g) panko breadcrumbs
¼ cup (25 g) grated parmesan
1 tablespoon dried oregano
1 tablespoon finely grated lemon zest
1 brown onion, sliced
100 g (3½ oz) fresh buffalo mozzarella in water, sliced
100 g (3½ oz) mozzarella, sliced

GNOCCHI

1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil

500 g (1 lb 2 oz) frozen potato gnocchi

OPTIONAL

chilli if you're into it

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced.

Slice the eggplants in half lengthways and score with slits 1 cm (½ inch) apart diagonally across the face. Season with half of the salt.

Brush a baking dish with half of the olive oil and place the eggplants cut-side down onto the dish.

Bake for 15 minutes, until the skin has begun to wrinkle and the flesh is soft.

Meanwhile, combine the passata, cherry tomatoes, 200 ml (7 fl oz) water, half the garlic and all the remaining salt in a bowl.

In a separate bowl, combine the panko, parmesan, remaining garlic, oregano and lemon zest. Set aside.

Remove the eggplants from the dish and set aside.

Brush the remaining oil into the dish then place the sliced onion around the dish. Top with the passata mixture then nestle the eggplants back in, this time cut-side up.

Return to the oven for 15 minutes, until the tomatoes begin to bubble around the edges.

Remove the dish from the oven.

Sprinkle the eggplant evenly with the panko crumb mixture and top with the sliced cheeses, alternating between them.

Scoop a little bit of the tomato mixture up onto the cheese, then return the dish to the oven for 10 minutes, until golden and bubbling.

Meanwhile, cook the gnocchi.

Heat the oil over medium–high heat in a large non-stick frying pan with a lid.

Place the still frozen gnocchi in a single layer into the pan. Add 2 tablespoons of water and cover.

Cook for 10 minutes, until golden brown on the outside and fluffy on the inside: like perfect little chewy potato gems.

Serve the eggplant with a spoonful of gnocchi and plenty of sauce scooped from the tray.





Personality Potatoes

Spud, tater, chip, crisp, mash, fries, roasties, gratin.
Soft, fluffy, crunchy, crispy, gooey, creamy, golden,
smooth, chewy.

I mean, when are they NOT great?
Eat these whenever you like.

Serves 4–6 as a side

Sticky

- 1 kg (2 lb 4 oz) red spuds, skins on, cut into chunks
- 1 garlic clove, smashed
- 2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil
- 2 cups (500 ml) vegetable stock
- 1 teaspoon paprika

¼ cup (60 g) salted butter, sliced

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced.

In an ovenproof frying pan over medium heat sauté the spuds and garlic in olive oil for 5 minutes, until the garlic begins to go golden.

Add the stock and paprika and reduce the heat to a simmer for 20 minutes.

Remove from the heat, place butter on top and bake in the oven for a further 20 minutes, until golden brown and all the liquid has evaporated.

Loaded

1 kg (2 lb 4 oz) yellow-flesh variety spuds, peeled and halved

½ cup (100 g) frozen spinach, thawed

1 zucchini (courgette), grated

2 tablespoons single (pure) cream

⅓ cup (90 g) salted butter, chopped

1 cup (125 g) grated mozzarella

fine salt and freshly ground black pepper, to taste

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced.

Boil the potatoes in plenty of salted water until soft, around 20–25 minutes. Drain and place back in the pot. Add the spinach and zucchini and roughly mash with the cream.

Add the butter and mozzarella and stir through. Taste and season well with S+P as desired. Place in a greased ovenproof dish and

bake until it's crispy on top and the cheese has melted, around 20 minutes.

Crispy

- 1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil**
- 1 kg (2 lb 4 oz) cocktail spuds, halved**
- 1 head garlic, cut in half with skin left on**
- 1 teaspoon fine salt**
- 2 tablespoons rice bran oil**
- 1 tablespoon polenta**
- 1 cup (100 g) finely grated parmesan**

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced. Lightly grease a baking tray with olive oil.

Place the spuds, garlic and salt in a pot of cold water and bring to the boil. Boil for 15 minutes.

Drain and place the spuds back into the pot on low heat to dry. Add the rice bran oil and cover, then shake the pot vigorously.

Tip everything onto the baking tray and squash the spuds flat slightly with a spatula.

Sprinkle with polenta and parmesan.

Roast for 30 minutes, until crisp and golden brown.



Saucy Wet Wednesdays

Sooooooooooooop.

This is possibly my favourite chapter: noodle soup, thick soup, creamy or brothy, loaded with veg, summer soup, breakfast soup, winter soup, midnight soup ... soup has no time-zone or season. There is barely a day that soup is not a welcome addition to my life.

But maybe I like it most because you have to concentrate while you eat it. You forage for chunks of veg, scoop and swirl creamy toppings, catch crispy bits and navigate the journey from bowl to face with care.

Soup is the best! You'll also find general wet bowl food here.

#S4L (Soup4Life)



Pea Lettuce

Cup-a-soup branding couldn't be MORE on point with how this soup should be eaten.

When my Aunt Sal first told me about this recipe I thought she was nuts.

Cooked lettuce. Blerk.

But it sounded simple enough and appealed to my dreams of one day living like I mean it: wearing velour and sipping soup from a martini glass.

So I made it. And I liked it.

Serves 4

1 leek

2 sheets ready-made frozen shortcrust pastry

1½ cups (150 g) grated cheddar

¼ cup (15 g) finely snipped chives

2 garlic cloves, chopped

¼ cup (60 g) salted butter

½ cup (10 g) flat-leaf parsley leaves

1 large iceberg (or any other) lettuce, coarsely chopped

6 cups (800 g) frozen baby peas

1.5 litres (6 cups) vegetable stock

fine salt and freshly ground black pepper, to taste

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

icebergs of sour cream

Preheat the oven to 180°C (350°F) fan-forced. Line a baking tray with baking paper.

Jump forward to the leek for a second. To really rinse the leek, trim the tough green ends off and discard, then make a slice from the top of the leek well down past the point where the leaves turn white. Rotate the leek and repeat the cut on the other side. Feather the leaves out and place top down in a jug of water. The ends will open up and grit should fall out. Let the leek soak while you make cute crackers.

Lay one sheet of shortcrust on baking paper. Sprinkle the cheddar and chives on top, then place the second pastry sheet on top of that. Cover this with baking paper and press down evenly (but not too heavily).

Remove the top layer of baking paper and cut the pastry into ridiculously adorable shapes with a cookie cutter. I made the moon phases.

Bake until golden, around 15 minutes. The crackers will keep stored in an airtight container at room temperature for a few days.

Back to that leek – drain and roughly chop.

In a large stockpot, over low heat, sweat the leek and garlic in the butter with the lid on until soft and sweet. This will take around 15 minutes but check and stir occasionally so nothing burns.

Add the parsley, lettuce, peas and stock. Bring to simmering point. Let it simmer for 15 minutes with the lid ajar, until everything is wilted and cooked.

Using a stick blender, purée the soup to the desired chunkiness. I like mine smooth-ish. Season with salt and pepper and serve with the cute crackers.





Potato Bread Soup

Potato and wafer should have a portmanteau like potafer.
Or we can just call it a raw crisp.

We can blame another matriarch in my family – my godmother Kyrsty – for this one.

She brought it to me once when I had the flu – just a regular flu; an elevated cold, shall we say.

Again, the concept seemed weird (see lettuce soup [here](#)), but actually – salty, garlicky, chilli broth, with 2 x carbs AND peppery rocket? It just works. Google ‘potato bread soup’ and all you’ll find are lumpy anaemic pots of glug that instantly make you feel as if you’ll forever talk like you do actually have tonsillitis. This is NOT that.

Serves 4

4 cups stale bread, torn into chunks

½ cup (125 ml) extra virgin olive oil

fine salt, to season

6 garlic cloves, sliced

1–2 long red chillies, finely sliced

2 litres (8 cups) vegetable stock

280 g (10 oz) potatoes, sliced into 3 mm (⅛ inch) wafers

sea salt flakes, to taste

120 g (4½ oz) baby rocket (arugula)

2 teaspoons chilli oil

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

you certainly don't need a cold to enjoy this

Preheat the oven to 180°C (350°F) fan-forced. Line a baking tray with baking paper.

In a bowl, toss the bread chunks in 2 tablespoons of the olive oil and season with salt.

Bake on the tray until golden, turning once, around 15 minutes all up. Allow to cool (you can store in an airtight container at room temperature for up to a week).

Heat the remaining olive oil over high heat in a stockpot. Add the garlic and chilli and fry these until they start to go a lovely dark golden colour and smell strong and bossy, around 4 minutes. Do NOT abandon. You really want that golden flavour, but not burnt.

Straight away add the stock and bring it to a boil.

Turn the heat to medium, add the potato wafers and cook until tender, around 5 minutes.

Season well.

To serve, ladle the soup into bowls, top each with a handful* of croutons, add a handful* of rocket and splash with chilli oil.

* Handfuls, in this case, depend entirely on you. You can base it on your actual hand or your hunger.





Mushroom & Miso Congee

You need to understand texture and condiments to love congee.

Congee is a condiment carrier and an activity. It's a suspension system. Thick enough to hold a layering of delightful ingredients, but thin enough to warrant spoon-eating. Brown and white rice become the soup, with slippery delicious 'shrooms and snappy little bubbles on the top. Seasoning is essential. Congee is traditionally very basic, usually just cooked with water, but because my family doesn't condiment very well, I am adding a bunch of flavour to the base.

Try any mushroom you'd like in the fresh department. I am using fresh baby king brown – prince browns maybe.

Serves 4

CONGEE

5 dried shiitake mushrooms

1 cup (250 ml) boiling water

2.5 cm (1 inch) knob of ginger, peeled and julienned

2 garlic cloves

1 celery stalk, chopped

3 spring onions (scallions), white parts chopped, green tops thinly sliced and set aside for topping

1 cup (30 g) loosely packed coriander (cilantro) leaves, stems and roots reserved and washed

¼ cup (60 ml) peanut oil

1 tablespoon sesame oil
1 tablespoon white miso paste
½ cup (110 g) short-grain brown rice
½ cup (110 g) short-grain white rice
fine salt and freshly ground black pepper, to taste
75 g (2½ oz) mushrooms, sliced (I used baby king browns)

SPICY BUBBLES

1 teaspoon Chinese five-spice
½ teaspoon chilli powder
1 teaspoon garlic powder
2 teaspoons crispy fried shallots, crushed
½ teaspoon fine salt
1 cup (30 g) rice bubbles
vegetable oil spray
2 cups (100 g) firmly packed baby spinach leaves

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

bamboo shoots and chilli oil; a boiled egg would be fun too

Steep the dried shiitake in the boiling water until cool.

Use a stick blender or food processor to blend the ginger, garlic, celery, the white parts of the spring onion, the stems and roots of the coriander and the peanut oil to form a chunky paste.

Fry the paste over medium heat in a large stockpot, stirring, until it becomes aromatic, around 5 minutes.

Add in the sesame oil and miso and mix well for 2 minutes, until aromatic. Add the brown and white rice and combine.

Drain the shiitake water into the stockpot, then slice the mushrooms and reserve. Add 10 cups (2.5 litres) water and bring to a simmer.

Reduce the heat to low and cook gently, stirring often, for 1–2 hours with the lid ajar, until the rice has completely broken down and become porridge-like. You may need to add more liquid. Taste as you go but season cautiously until the end – then go nuts! Add the mushrooms about half an hour before done or at serving time.

To make the spicy bubbles, combine the Chinese five-spice, chilli powder, garlic powder, fried shallots and salt in a small bowl and mix well. Place the rice bubbles in a large bowl and spray with oil. Toss well and spray again. Sprinkle the spice mix onto the rice bubbles and continue to toss.

Add the spinach, if using, to the congee 5 minutes before serving, to wilt in the pot. Or – if you like it fresher – just pop the leaves in the bowls before serving and ladle congee on top.

Serve with spicy bubbles, bamboo shoots and chilli oil if using, the tops of the spring onions and the coriander leaves.





Fennel Ragu on Polenta

Embrace the sloppy wetness of this delight.

This dish is an absolute showstopper, full of delicious sticky braised sweet vegetables sitting on a delightfully creamy bed of polenta with a sprinkling of snappy gremolata and extra parmesan on top.

It's fancy enough to serve to guests with proper cutlery and napkins (and even candles), but it's also comforting enough to eat straight from a bowl on your lap in front of the cold blue light of the telly.

Serves 4

RAGU

¼ cup (60 ml) extra virgin olive oil
2 red onions, cut into 1 cm (½ inch) wedges
1 brown onion, cut into 1 cm (½ inch) wedges
2 fennel bulbs, cut into 3 cm (1 ¼ inch) wedges, tops cut off and fronds retained for gremolata
3 garlic cloves, smashed
2 capsicums (peppers), cut into 5 cm (2 inch) slices
1 teaspoon fennel seeds
2 fresh oregano stems
1 teaspoon fine salt
½ teaspoon white (granulated) sugar
2 tablespoons malt vinegar
400 g (14 oz) tinned cherry tomatoes

POLENTA

6 cups (1.5 litres) chicken-style stock

1 cup (190 g) polenta

1 cup (100 g) finely grated parmesan, plus extra to serve

¼ cup (60 g) salted butter

GREMOLATA

¼ cup (15 g) finely chopped curly parsley

1 tablespoon finely grated lemon zest

1 garlic clove, smashed

1 tablespoon fennel fronds, finely chopped

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

a crusty baguette for final mopping

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced.

In a heavy-based ovenproof dish that has a lid, heat the olive oil over medium heat and sauté the onions for 5 minutes. Once the onions have had a moment to relax, add in the fennel, garlic, capsicum, fennel seeds, oregano (whole stems), salt and sugar and toss well over the heat.

Pour in the vinegar and toss again. Relocate the dish to the oven and bake with the lid off for 25 minutes.

Remove the dish from the oven, add in the cherry tomatoes, then rinse the tin with ¾ cup (200 ml) of water and pour that in also.

Place the lid on and put the dish back in the oven to bake for another 25 minutes.

Meanwhile, in a large saucepan bring the stock and 2 cups (500 ml) of water to the boil. Whisk in the polenta, pouring it in a steady stream. Keep whisking for 1½–2 minutes so nothing gets stuck on the bottom and there are no lumps. These first minutes are essential to getting very smooth, deliciously creamy polenta. Turn down the heat to medium–low and continue to cook for 25–30 minutes, whisking occasionally. If it seems dry add some more liquid.

To make the gremolata, simply add the ingredients to a little jar or bowl and mix well.

Five minutes before serving, whisk the grated parmesan and butter into the polenta, and keep whisking until smooth and glossy.

Spoon the polenta into a large serving bowl. The polenta will begin to set slightly as it cools.

Top with the steaming sweet braised ragu and sprinkle with gremolata and, of course, extra parmesan.





Summer Mini

Summer soup. I know. Do you need to sit down?

I've started putting peas in almost every pesto I make at home – it just seems to be a great addition of veg.

This is called a summer mini because it's green and punchy, full of vibrant summer flings, but of course it's really great in winter too. The point of this soup is to remind you that soup has no season and you should eat it anytime.

Serves 4

1 brown onion, finely diced
2 celery stalks, finely chopped
3 garlic cloves, finely chopped
2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil, plus extra for drizzling
½ cup (110 g) marinated artichokes, coarsely chopped
1 zucchini (courgette), sliced thinly into rounds
2 teaspoons finely chopped fresh oregano leaves
1 small head of broccoli, cut into florets*
4 cups (1 litre) chicken-style stock
10 leaves cavolo nero (tuscan kale), tough ribs discarded, leaves and tender ribs kept whole
1¼ cups (60 g) firmly packed baby spinach leaves
2 tablespoons finely grated parmesan

PESTO

2 tablespoons fresh oregano leaves

1 garlic clove, smashed
½ cup (50 g) finely grated parmesan
2 tablespoons finely grated lemon zest
2 tablespoons pine nuts, lightly toasted and cooled
1 tablespoon finely chopped dill sprigs
1 tablespoon finely chopped flat-leaf parsley
10 basil leaves, torn
1 tablespoon finely chopped rosemary leaves
1 cup (130 g) frozen baby peas, thawed
½ cup (125 ml) extra virgin olive oil
1 teaspoon sea salt flakes
freshly ground black pepper, to taste

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

warm summer temps

Roughly blitz all the ingredients for the pesto in a food processor or with a stick blender until you have a rough and chunky consistency. Set aside.

In a large heavy-based saucepan over medium heat, sweat the onion, celery and garlic in olive oil until softened, about 10 minutes. Add the artichokes, zucchini, oregano and the broccoli, increase the heat and fry for a further 2 minutes.

Add the stock and bring to a simmer with the lid ajar. Everything should be tender in about 5 minutes.

Add the cavolo nero and spinach and simmer until wilted, around 2 minutes.

Serve topped with pesto, a drizzle of olive oil and parmy.

* Hot tip for cutting broccoli. Hold it upside down over the tray or saucepan you are cooking in and trim the florets off. You may need to cut some in half, and you should skin and julienne the stalk bits too, but doing it this way will result in way less broccoli sand, which is a substantial enough excuse to never use the brassica again.





Quick & Curried

Forget dressing for success, lunch for luxury instead.

Soup is a really strong take-to-work lunch game. For starters, a jar of soup is deceptively filling, but bringing other jars filled with stuff to bulk out your soup OR add flavour is immensely impressive.

It just screams mindfulness and prowess.

Aside from becoming noticeably cooler – eating jar food – you will actually save money by having leftovers for lunch. I know, what a concept! Aaand, if you select your jars correctly, you could even pass your lunch off as something you bought from a super bougie soup/juice cleanse joint.

Clearly this is not me – my jars just say: ‘She eats lots of jam.’

This soup is a complete throw together – one worth getting the hang of and putting on when you need.

Serves 4

2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil
1 red onion, chopped
2 cm ($\frac{3}{4}$ inch) knob of ginger, peeled and grated
4 garlic cloves, chopped
20 curry leaves
2 tablespoons curry powder
2 x 400 g (14 oz) tinned chickpeas, drained
2 carrots, sliced into 1 cm ($\frac{1}{2}$ inch) rounds
2 x 400 g (14 oz) tinned crushed tomatoes

6 cups (1.5 litres) vegetable stock

150 g (5½ oz) frozen spinach

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

Greek yoghurt, crispy fried shallots, chilli flakes and a squeeze of lime would be nice

Heat the oil in a large heavy-based saucepan over medium heat.

Add the red onion and sauté for a bit, around 5 minutes.

Add the ginger, garlic, curry leaves and curry powder and sauté for a further 2 minutes.

It should smell great right about now.

Add the drained chickpeas, the carrots (don't even bother to peel – but this is up to you), the crushed toms and the stock. Simmer for 30 minutes with the lid ajar.

Add the frozen spinach, or any green leaves you like, and cook for another 10 minutes or so.

Bulk it out with steamed rice or add any number of accessories from the list above!





Sorrel Spinach Soup

Creamy mash IN a bowl of thick soup is a double delight – and it appeals to me far more than having cake and eating it too.

I am neither French nor Polish – but this sorrel soup heralds from both countries and I was lucky enough to be fed it as a kid.

Although sorrel can be pretty difficult to find in the shops, it grows like a weed if left alone. Get matey with your produce dude or buy some seeds. It is lemony and ultimately amazing.

Sorrel can be swapped out for spinach, but you'll lose the tang of this soup, which is what you come back for. Sorrel also turns murky brown when cooked, but the spinach stays bright, which is nice.

Serves 4

600 g (1 lb 5 oz) potatoes, peeled and cubed

100 g (3½ oz) salted butter

½ cup (130 g) natural yoghurt

1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil

1 small brown onion, finely diced

1 small carrot, finely chopped

2 garlic cloves, finely chopped

1 celery stalk, finely chopped

1 bay leaf

4 cups (1 litre) vegetable stock

6 cups (270 g) firmly packed baby spinach leaves

1 bunch sorrel
1 tablespoon plain (all-purpose) flour
¼ cup (65 g) sour cream

TOPPINGS

40 g (1½ oz) cold salted butter, cut into 4 portions
freshly ground black pepper, to serve
2 tablespoons dill sprigs

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

poached egg

Boil the potatoes in plenty of salted water until soft – 20 minutes – then mash until smooth with 2 tablespoons of the butter and the yoghurt. Set aside and keep warm.

In a large saucepan over medium heat, melt the remaining butter with the olive oil and then sauté the onion, carrot, garlic, celery and bay leaf for about 15 minutes, until golden.

Add in the vegetable stock and simmer for 15 minutes with the lid ajar.

Add the spinach and sorrel and cook until just wilted, around 2 minutes.

Remove the bay leaf and blend the soup with a stick blender until very smooth. You can put the bay leaf back in after blending if you would like to flavour the soup a bit more.

In a small bowl, combine the flour and sour cream until they form a smooth paste. Add a few tablespoons of soup to the paste and mix well. Drop this paste back into the soup and stir through.

Serve the soup with a big dollop of mashed potato topped with a portion of butter, plenty of pepper and dill sprigs to garnish.

The soup is also the perfect partner to a poached egg.





Mulligatawny & a Flatty

This can be the skinny fat soup.

Mulligatawny is like a slightly sweeter, slurpier dhal. It's perfect for cooler evenings when you need something a little bit more substantial. It's rich and creamy without being too heavy.

Serves 4

1 large brown onion, finely diced
1 carrot, finely diced
2 celery stalks, finely diced
2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil
5 cm (2 inch) knob of ginger, peeled and grated
3 garlic cloves, smashed
2 teaspoons curry powder
2 teaspoons turmeric powder
1 teaspoon garam masala
1 small sweet potato, peeled and diced
½ cauliflower, core removed, cut into florets
1 green apple, peeled and grated
1 cup (205 g) red lentils
1 tablespoon vegetable stock powder
drizzle of coconut milk, to serve

FLATTIES

2 cups (300 g) self-raising flour
1 cup (260 g) Greek-style yoghurt
1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil

1 teaspoon fine salt

¼ teaspoon white (granulated) sugar

**1 teaspoon each of cumin seeds, nigella seeds, caraway seeds,
sesame seeds**

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

lime & coriander

In a heavy-based saucepan over medium–low heat sauté the onion, carrot and celery in olive oil until golden and soft, around 15 minutes.

Add the ginger and garlic and sauté for a further 2 minutes.

Add the curry powder, turmeric and garam masala and stir. Add the sweet potato, cauliflower, apple, lentils, stock and 8 cups (2 litres) water and stir well.

Bring the soup to a boil, then turn the heat down to medium and simmer, with the lid ajar, for 30 minutes or until soft.

To make the flatties, in a large bowl combine the flour, yoghurt, olive oil, salt and sugar until a smooth dough has formed. This can be done with a standmixer fitted with a dough hook or a hand fitted with fingers.

If using a standmixer, combine the ingredients for 2–3 minutes on medium speed, then knead for another 7–8 minutes. If working by hand, mix the dough in the bowl for 4–6 minutes then move it to a lightly floured surface to knead for 5–6 minutes, until smooth and elastic (minimal kneading here as it can overwork the dough).

Lightly oil a large bowl and place the dough in it. Dust the top with some flour before covering the bowl with plastic wrap (the flour will stop the dough sticking to the plastic wrap if it rises that high). Set aside in a warm place to rest for about an hour.

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced. Line two baking trays with baking paper.

When you are ready to eat, turn the sticky dough out onto a floured surface and divide it into eight pieces. Smoosh each piece out with your fingertips to make a 12 cm (4½ inch) diameter round. Sprinkle with seeds, then place on the trays and bake for 10 minutes, or until golden and puffy.*

Top each bowl of mulligatawny with a big drizzle of coconut milk and serve with the freshly baked flatties on the side.

* These are always best cooked fresh; however, you can freeze the dough. Divide the flattened portions with baking paper to stop them from sticking to each other, then place them in an airtight container or bag and freeze. Thaw before cooking.





Spring Goddess Risotto

Even if you don't like the people, you'd turn up for this one.

This is the kind of food I need to be eating when my kids are treating me to a rendition of a song they've never learned to sing or playing a tune on an instrument they haven't been taught.

The harmonies in the bowl are perfect and the rice al dente. Creamy, fresh, delicious, tangy – al limone/cacio e pepe vibes.

Serves 6

GREEN GODDESS SAUCE

50 g (1¾ oz) salted butter

1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil

1 small onion, diced

3 garlic cloves, chopped

4 cups (180 g) firmly packed baby spinach, rinsed but not dried off too much

2 zucchini (courgettes), grated

⅔ cup (20 g) loosely packed basil leaves

1 tablespoon fresh oregano leaves

RISOTTO

8 cups (2 litres) veg stock

1 lemon, peel cut into four 5 cm (2 inch) strips, juice squeezed, plus extra lemon for zesting

1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil

2 cups (440 g) arborio rice

1 tablespoon dijon mustard

1 bunch asparagus, ends trimmed, cut diagonally into 1 cm (½ inch) pieces

½ cup (80 g) baby peas

40 g (1½ oz) salted butter

1 cup (100 g) finely grated parmesan

TOPPINGS

90 g (3 oz) d'affinois,* cut into 12 slices

small handful of fresh baby herbs

freshly ground black pepper

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

nothing to be added, nothing to be removed

To make the goddess part of this recipe, in a medium saucepan over medium heat melt the butter and olive oil. Add the onion and garlic and sauté for 5 minutes, until it starts to smell wonderful.

Add the baby spinach, grated zucchini, basil and oregano and stir until it wilts – this should take a further 3 minutes. Turn off the heat. The water that comes out of the spinach should be enough to give this mixture a bit of liquid. Allow it to cool slightly, then purée in a small food processor or with a stick blender. Set aside this insanely incredible sauce until ready to use.

Now, bring the stock to simmering in a covered saucepan then turn it off. This is the liquid you will add to the risotto by the ladleful.

In a large heavy-based saucepan over medium heat, sauté the lemon peel in 1 tablespoon of olive oil for 2 minutes. Add the rice

and stir well to coat in oil, reduce the heat to low and begin adding the hot stock $\frac{1}{2}$ cup (125 ml) at a time, stirring after each addition.

The constant stirring is essential for creamy risotto. Continue adding stock only as the last amount is absorbed.

Before you add the last amount of liquid, stir in 2 tablespoons of the lemon juice, and the dijon, asparagus and peas, then the butter and the parmesan. The final splash of liquid will help bring everything together.

The rice should be al dente and collapse flat in its own wetness. You can add water if it requires a bit more cooking, but it will continue to cook once it's removed from the heat.

Serve immediately with a swirl of the green sauce and a slice or two of d'affinois. Add a flourish of fresh baby herbs, a big fat scrunch of pepper and a flick of lemon zest.

Any left-over green goddess can be kept in the fridge for a week in an airtight container.

* You can use anything your heart desires here, but I suggest you find a cheese that wants to be both cream and butter. Fancy, but without any willpower.





Thick & Delicious

We all have that one friend.

A velvety chowder so smooth I'd consider wearing it.

Thick & Delicious is full of corn, potato, leek and that maniac of a vegetable: celeriac. It's such a prehistoric looking thing! Falls firmly into the pile of 'Who the f*ck decided to eat this first?!' It's witchy ugly, but so sweet and delicious.

Adding the stripped corn cobs will give you the best corny flavour, so keep them simmering with everything else until the last moment, then get rid of them.

Serves 4

1 leek

1 brown onion, chopped

2 celery stalks, chopped

3 garlic cloves, chopped

2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil

400 g (14 oz) potatoes, peeled and cut into 4 cm cubes

1 celeriac, peeled and cut into 4 cm cubes

2 corn cobs, kernels removed and cobs reserved (husks and silks discarded)

4 cups (1 litre) vegetable stock

1 cup (250 ml) single (pure) cream

¼ cup (15 g) finely snipped chives

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

a splash of extra cream

After you've washed your leek (see [here](#)), cut 10 cm off the green end and julienne it. Pat dry and set aside. Cut the remaining leek into 1 cm (½ inch) rounds.

In a large saucepan over low heat, sauté the onion, celery, leek rounds and garlic in half the olive oil for 10 minutes with the lid on.

Add in the potato, celeriac and corn cobs (no, not the kernels yet!) and cover with the stock. Simmer with the lid ajar until the veg has softened, around 25 minutes.

Remove the corn cobs, add in half of the kernels and cook for a further 5 minutes.

Purée the soup with a stick blender until smooth.

Add the remaining corn kernels and the cream and simmer for 5 minutes.

Meanwhile, in a shallow non-stick frying pan, heat the remaining olive oil and fry the julienned leeks until golden brown and beginning to crisp, around 5 minutes. Place on paper towel to drain.

Eat this thick and delicious situation with a little flurry of leek crisps and a caviar of chives.





Canned Bread Soup

Involves holding bread, and also scooping bread.

This soup relies on stale bread and a few tins of stuff from the pantry plus, of course, that most irritating of all vegetables to store: kale. However, you can switch this out for anything robust and leafy – even cabbage if you like.

This one is a chunky hot salad, let's be honest.

Serves 4

2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil, plus extra for drizzling

1 brown onion, finely chopped

4 garlic cloves, thinly sliced, plus 4 more cut in half to rub on the bread

½ teaspoon chilli flakes

handful flat-leaf parsley, finely chopped

400 g (14 oz) tinned cannellini beans, drained

½ bunch kale, tough spines removed, chopped

400 g (14 oz) tinned crushed tomatoes

2 tablespoons chicken-style stock powder

parmesan rind

8 slices sourdough bread

½ cup (50 g) finely grated parmesan

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

more an optional action – reserve that aquafaba (the liquid from the cannellini beans) for your vegan mates

Heat the olive oil in a large heavy-based saucepan over medium heat. Add the onion and cook for 2 minutes, then add the sliced garlic, chilli flakes and parsley. Saut  , stirring, for 2–3 minutes.

Add the cannellini beans, kale and crushed tomatoes, stir, then reduce the heat to low.

Pour in 3 cups (750 ml) of water and stir in the stock powder. (I absolutely always wing this amount – especially as the salt level in stock powders can vary greatly, so follow the packet directions or do as I do: and don't!)

Next up is the magic umami step: throw in the parmesan rind then simmer for 20 minutes with the lid ajar.

Meanwhile, toast the sourdough. As soon as it pops, rub each slice with a chunk of cut garlic and sprinkle with parmy.

Add a piece of toast to the bottom of each serving bowl and cover with soup.

Drizzle with olive oil and serve with all the remaining toast.





Mapo Eggplant

Clearly not a soup, but classic wet-bowl territory.

This comfort food is so lip-zingy you'll feel completely bee-stung. Spicy szechuan sticky sauce – usually seen carrying pork mince – becomes the slip and slide for tofu, which is piled high onto charred, chewy roast eggplant.

This one falls squarely into the 'I can't hear you hate on eggplant or tofu' basket. If you don't want this purely because of the concept, then you may skip forward.

Serves 4

2 eggplants (aubergines)
1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil
2 teaspoons sea salt flakes
2 cups (370 g) steamed white rice

MAPO SAUCE

½ cup (125 ml) peanut oil
1½ tablespoons szechuan peppercorns
3 tablespoons finely grated fresh ginger
3 tablespoons grated garlic
1 bird's eye chilli, thinly sliced*
600 g (1 lb 5 oz) semi-firm tofu, crumbled
1 tablespoon shaoxing rice wine
2½ tablespoons toban djan (spicy bean sauce)
1½ tablespoons dark soy sauce

1 tablespoon crispy chilli oil
1 dried Chinese mushroom, ground to a powder
2 tablespoons soft brown sugar
2 teaspoons cornflour (cornstarch) mixed to a paste with 1
tablespoon cold water
⅔ cup (170 ml) chicken-style stock

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

finely chopped spring onions (scallions)

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced.

Cut the eggplants in half lengthways. Use a knife to create a 1 cm (½ inch) wide crosshatch pattern on the eggplants' faces – make sure to keep the skin intact to act as a seal for liquids and juices.

Oil and salt** the eggplants and place them face down on a non-stick baking tray. Bake for 15 minutes.

Meanwhile, make the mapo sauce. Heat the peanut oil in a large, deep frying pan over medium heat, add the szechuan peppercorns, ginger, garlic and bird's eye chilli and stir. Everything should soften and smell intensely after 3 minutes.

Add in the tofu and cook until just beginning to brown, around 5 minutes. Be careful not to over-stir, especially if the tofu is soft, or it will take on a jelly consistency.

Turn the heat up and pour in the shaoxing rice wine, stirring to deglaze the pan for around 3 minutes.

Stir in 2 tablespoons of toban djan, 2 teaspoons of dark soy sauce, the crispy chilli oil, the dried mushroom and 1 tablespoon of the

brown sugar and combine well.

Add the cornflour paste and stock to the pan and lower the heat. Stir gently and allow the sauce to thicken, around 5 minutes.

In a small bowl, combine the remaining 2 teaspoons of toban djan, the remaining 1 tablespoon dark soy sauce and the remaining 1 tablespoon brown sugar and mix well.

When the eggplants are done, flip them onto their backs and brush them with this mixture. Turn the oven to the grill setting and return the eggplant to the oven to crisp for a further 5 minutes.

Serve on steamed rice with a big scoop of zinging mapo sauce ladled on top and lots of spring onions (optional).

* The addition of bird's eye chilli takes this dish from sweet hum to holy mofo. It's a decision you need to make for yourself, plus chillies can be so unpredictably hot or not – so maybe toss a coin to decide.

** The salt is for flavour, not to reduce bitterness. Bitterness has been conveniently bred out of eggplant, so trust me, you don't need to extract it.





Minute Noodles

Noods should be the initiation into any cult. How you do it is up to you.

Thick and creamy, thin and soft, fat and slippery.

Serves 2, because you can really get into trouble if you share noods with more.

Spicy satay

1 tablespoon red curry paste

½ cup (125 ml) coconut cream

2 tablespoons peanut butter

4 cups (1 litre) chicken-style stock

½ lime

2 x 75 g (2½ oz) packets of 2-minute noodles

300 g (10½ oz) tinned corn, drained, or 1 corn cob, kernels only

1 bok choy, julienned

6-minute boiled egg, peeled and cut in half lengthways
chilli oil, for topping

Sauté the red curry paste in a heavy-based saucepan over medium heat until fragrant, 1–2 minutes. Add the coconut cream and peanut butter and whisk until smooth.

Add the stock and the juice from the lime. Simmer for 2 minutes.

Add the noodles and corn kernels and simmer for 2 minutes more.

Place the bok choy into two bowls and ladle the soup/noodles over each to blanch. Top with half an egg each and some chilli oil.

Grate soup

1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil, plus extra for drizzling

1 brown onion, grated

1 carrot, grated

1 celery stalk, grated

3 garlic cloves, grated

1 potato, grated

1 tomato, grated

1 zucchini (courgette), grated

4 cups (1 litre) vegetable stock

50 g (¾ oz) angel hair pasta, broken into 4 cm (1½ inch) pieces

¼ cup (5 g) chopped flat-leaf parsley

fine salt and freshly ground black pepper, to taste

Heat the olive oil in a heavy-based saucepan over medium heat and sauté the onion, carrot, celery and garlic for 2 minutes.

Add the remaining veg and cook for a further 2 minutes.

Add the stock and bring to the boil. Reduce the heat and simmer for 5 minutes, or until the veg has softened.

Add the pasta and cook for a further 2 minutes. Stir through the parsley, season well and drizzle with extra virgin olive oil.

Golden pho

200 g (7 oz) dry rice noodles

4 cups (1 litre) beef-style stock

1 cm (½ inch) knob of ginger, peeled and grated

½ teaspoon turmeric powder

¼ teaspoon cinnamon

3 star anise

½ white onion, thinly sliced

¼ cup (7 g) Thai basil leaves

½ cup (10 g) Vietnamese mint leaves

½ cup (15 g) coriander (cilantro) leaves

2 lemon wedges

Pour boiling water over the rice noodles and let them soften. Set aside.

Bring the stock, ginger, turmeric, cinnamon, star anise and half the sliced white onion to the boil in a saucepan over medium–high heat.

Use tongs to place the noodles into two bowls. Top with the remaining sliced onion and pour the steaming broth on top. Add the

herbs and a wedge of lemon.



Carbs-filled-with-things Thursdays

This is the loaded chapter. The place where we shove a handful of delicious stuff in a carb. From fluffy buns and crispy grated spuds, to flavour pastes folded into pastry and lovely things squashed into dough.

This is the place to turn to when you need more than just a weeny leaf or two. This is the bopper where all the big girls play.

This isn't carb loading; it's loading a carb.



Full Metal Jackets

But make them peaceful.

Start strong with the power of a jacket potato wrapped in foil, but with all the peace and love of a hippy child.

Disco jewels made with Greek salad ingredients straight from the Mediterranean blue zone confirm that this dish will help you live forever – I recommend fact-checking this, but it feels right to promote this recipe as the fountain of youth.

Serves 6

6 large brushed potatoes
butter and extra virgin olive oil, to serve

CURD DRESSING

$\frac{2}{3}$ cup (150 g) goat's curd
 $\frac{1}{2}$ cup (125 g) sour cream
 $\frac{1}{2}$ teaspoon finely snipped chives
 $\frac{1}{2}$ teaspoon finely chopped dill
 $\frac{1}{2}$ teaspoon finely grated lemon zest
 $\frac{1}{4}$ teaspoon garlic powder

SALSA

$\frac{1}{3}$ cup (60 g) pitted kalamata olives, finely chopped
1 cup (200 g) chopped tomatoes, seeds removed from large ones
 $\frac{1}{4}$ red onion, finely diced
2 Lebanese (short) cucumbers, seeds removed,* finely diced
 $\frac{1}{4}$ cup (60 ml) extra virgin olive oil

1 tablespoon white vinegar

1 teaspoon sea salt flakes

1 teaspoon dried oregano

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

chilli seems unnecessarily aggressive but go for it

Preheat the oven to 230°C (450°F) fan-forced.

Wash and scrub the potatoes and pat dry. Wrap each spud in foil and place them on a baking tray. Bake for 1 hour 10 minutes.

Meanwhile, using hand-held electric beaters, beat the goat's curd and sour cream on medium speed until smooth and fluffy, around 2 minutes. Add the chives, dill, lemon zest and garlic powder and beat on high for 2 minutes. This dressing can be made ahead and stored in the fridge for 2 days in an airtight container.

To make the salsa, combine the olives, tomato, red onion and cucumber in a small bowl and dress with the olive oil and white vinegar. Season with salt and dried oregano.

Once the potatoes are cooked and soft to the squeeze from a pair of tongs, remove the foil and place them on a serving platter.

Slice the potatoes lengthways, but not all the way through. Give them a gentle squeeze to push the flesh upwards towards the opening.

Top each potato with a big swipe of butter and then a dollop of curd dressing and splash the salsa all about. Drizzle with extra virgin olive oil and serve as is.

* Try as I might, I can never smoothly scrape cucumber seeds out of the centre. Maybe I need to get my spoons sharpened. I just cut a 5 mm ($\frac{1}{4}$ inch) thick slice off one side of the cucumber, lay it flat and do the same on each side, rotating it until the flesh is trimmed and the seeds remain. Throw the seeds into a carafe of water for ultimate hydration – yes, we are now advancing into true health care.





Kimchi Rice Cakes

Okonomiyaki translates to ‘what you want’ and ‘grilled’, which could really be the name of so many things in my life.

These are ridiculously cute traditional Japanese pancakes.

They’re also one of the funniest things I’ve ever made in a waffle machine.

You can mash in almost any veg or protein (hurray for leftovers!) for these pancakes, but here I’ve switched out flour for rice – which for some will be pleasing due to the lack of gluten. (Although considering the places you actually find gluten these days, don’t assume the rest of the pancake is gluten free.)

Makes around 14 cakes

RICE CAKES

1½ cups (275 g) cooked rice (whatever type you like)

½ cup (80 g) kimchi, finely diced

2 cups (150 g) shredded cabbage – I used wombok but you can use green

½ cup (50 g) grated cheddar

2 eggs

1 spring onion (scallion), white and green parts, finely diced

1 teaspoon sea salt flakes

2 teaspoons finely grated lime zest

rice bran oil spray

1½ tablespoons sesame seeds

OKONOMIYAKI SAUCE

2 tablespoons tomato sauce (ketchup)

1 tablespoon dark soy sauce

1 tablespoon maple syrup

TOPPINGS

kewpie mayo, for drizzling

finely shredded nori

pickled ginger

snipped chives

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

you can add ‘what you want’ to this – that’s the point

In a large bowl, mix together the rice, kimchi, cabbage, cheddar, eggs, spring onion, salt and lime until well combined.

There are two ways to go here. Either spray a frying pan lightly with rice bran oil and heat over medium–high heat, or heat a sandwich press or waffle machine until hot and then spray it lightly with rice bran oil. If you do this in a sandwich press or waffle machine, you will get double-sided cooking, meaning it will cook a lot faster – but both techniques will work.

Using a ¼ cup (60 ml) measure, scoop the mixture onto the hotplate or into the pan. Sprinkle the top with a few sesame seeds. Lower the lid if using a machine (if you want your cake to be slightly thicker, don’t press down too hard with the lid of the sandwich press).

Cook for approximately 5 minutes – or 5 minutes each side if using a frying pan – until golden brown and beginning to crisp.

As the cakes are cooking, make the sauce by mixing together the tomato sauce, dark soy sauce and maple syrup.

Place the cooked cakes onto a tray lined with baking paper and keep warm until serving.

To create a classic okonomiyaki pattern, squeeze mayonnaise and okonomiyaki sauce in alternating lines, then use a toothpick to swipe through the contrasting colours first one way, and then the other, creating a zigzag pattern.

Serve the pancakes with extra mayo and okonomiyaki sauce, nori, pickled ginger and chives.





Muffuletta Pie

The stacked pie that's too good to be true.

This pie has ALL the things: two pestos, a tapenade, grilled veg, two cheeses – all baked into the glory of golden flaky pastry. Sold? Same.

Serves 6

2 sheets (400 g) ready-made frozen shortcrust pastry
2 sheets (400 g) ready-made frozen puff pastry
2 tablespoons Bready Pesto from [here](#), but without the breadcrumbs
6 slices grilled, marinated sweet potato*
1 cup (45 g) firmly packed baby spinach leaves
160 g (5¾ oz) provolone, thinly sliced
3 slices grilled, marinated eggplant (aubergine)*
2 tablespoons basil pesto (store-bought is fine)
125 g (4½ oz) buffalo mozzarella, thinly sliced
3 marinated artichokes, coarsely chopped*
1 tablespoon fresh oregano leaves
2 whole grilled, marinated capsicums (peppers), cut open at the edges to flatten*
8 slices grilled, marinated zucchini (courgette)*
1 tablespoon olive tapenade
2 teaspoons dijon mustard
1 egg, lightly beaten with 1 tablespoon of water

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

there's no garnish, this one already has everything

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced. Line a round pizza tray with baking paper.

Here's where I repeat things I saw on TikTok – I hope I explain it properly! This is how to turn two square pastry sheets into one giant round.

Roll each pastry sheet into a long cigar. Then roll the two cigars of shortcrust pastry into a large snail spiral. You can then use a rolling pin to roll this out into a 33 cm (13 inch) round. Place this on the pizza tray.

Repeat the process with the puff pastry sheets, and set aside to use as the lid when ready.

Layer the ingredients onto the shortcrust base one at a time, separating wet with cheese and salad. This is how I stacked from BOTTOM to TOP, leaving a 4 cm (1½ inch) edge: bready pesto + sweet potato + half the baby spinach + a third of the provolone + eggplant + basil pesto + buffalo mozzarella + artichokes + fresh oregano + capsicum + remaining baby spinach + another third of the provolone + zucchini + tapenade + the remaining provolone.

Spread dijon on the underside of the pie lid.

Brush the edge of the pie base with the egg wash, reserving some for the top.

Cover the pie with the puff pastry lid and gently push out any air bubbles.

Trim the pastry so you are dealing with a neat-ish edge, then pinch and crimp the pastry the whole way around. Brush the top with the remaining egg wash.

TikTok trick #2. Rather than score the puff pastry, we are trussing it!

Tie cooking string underneath the pizza tray and up over the pie firmly. Repeat this another two to four times, depending on what size you would like to mark your pie slices at (3 strings = 6 slices).

Place in the oven and bake for 30 minutes, until puffed and golden brown.

Remove the string and allow the pie to cool slightly before cutting and serving.

* If you can't find these at a deli counter, then simply slice the raw veg into 5–7 mm (2–2¾ inch) thick slices. Roast in a preheated 200°C (400°F) fan-forced oven on a baking tray lined with baking paper for 20 minutes. Season well and set aside to cool. Drizzle with oil and red wine vinegar. The veg will keep for a week stored in an airtight container in the fridge.





Alfredo 'Shroom Soufra

If this is bad fashun then I'm OK with that.

I'm not actually sure when the 90s called and demanded to be part of this book, but they certainly did and got waaay past security. In those days, cream and carbs were abundant, and the rich regret that follows eight mouthfuls of fettuccine alfredo was always forgotten when you were handed a menu.

A soufra is a very new experience for me, and I appreciate that this adaptation may not be doing the original as much justice as it should. But if I can somehow consume steamed pastry along with some crispy flaky bits and a rich custard of eggs, cream and milk, plus some madly aromatic fungi, then you have me, regrets and all.

Serves 6 with a salad

DUXELLES*

350 g (12 oz) mixed fresh mushrooms, coarsely chopped

¼ cup (30 g) shallots, thinly sliced

2 garlic cloves, finely chopped

1 tablespoon thyme leaves

⅓ cup (80 ml) vermouth or dry white wine

1 teaspoon fine salt

1½ tablespoons single (pure) cream

SOUFRA

1 x 375 g (13 oz) box filo pastry (18 sheets; the type kept in the fridge, not the freezer)

¼ cup (60 g) salted butter, melted
1 cup (250 ml) single (pure) cream
5 eggs
1 cup (250 ml) milk
1 cup (100 g) finely grated parmesan, plus extra for sprinkling
1 tablespoon each of finely snipped chives and finely chopped flat-leaf parsley leaves

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

salad

Combine the mushrooms, shallots, garlic, thyme and vermouth in a frying pan over medium heat and cover for 15 minutes to wet fry. Remove the lid and continue to cook for 10 minutes, or until the mushrooms are soft and the liquid has evaporated.

Let the mushroom mixture cool before placing into a food processor with the salt and blending until finely chopped. Add the cream and blend until smooth.

When you are ready to assemble, make sure your filo pastry and mushroom mixture is at room temperature. Preheat the oven to 180°C (350°F) fan-forced. Lightly grease a shallow 20 x 31 cm (8 x 12½ inch) ovenproof dish – no deeper than 3 cm (1¼ inches).

This is the tricky bit – take a good look at the little photo there, it will help you. Lay one sheet of filo pastry on top of some baking paper.** Spread/brush some of the duxelles on the sheet. Place a second layer of filo pastry on top. Beginning at the short end of the pastry, gather the ends in a scrunching concertina*** fashion until it is a tight rectangular parcel. Place this closed concertina of pastry into

the dish, snuggled up against one end. Repeat this process, tucking the scrunched pastry parcels into the dish as you go, until you have used all of the sheets of pastry. Adjust the parcels in the pan so they are evenly placed by spreading apart or pushing together as necessary.

Brush the top of the pastry with lots of lovely melted butter.

Bake for 15 minutes, or until the pastry is beginning to turn golden.

Meanwhile, whisk together the cream, eggs, milk and parmesan in a bowl.

Remove the dish from the oven and slowly pour the cream mixture into and around the crevices of the pastry. Allow time for the mixture to settle in place before adding more and filling up every little spot. Place the dish back in the oven for 20 minutes, or until just set.

Sprinkle generously with chives, parsley and extra parmesan.

Serve while still warm with a fresh salad.

* Duxelles is to puréed mushies as passata is to puréed toms ... the fancy word.

** Keep the remaining filo pastry moist by covering with a slightly damp cloth.

*** The concertina scrunching does not need to be perfect.





Scrap Burgers

Ultimate burger test: does juice run down to your elbow?

<tick>

Shut the front door – no, no seriously. You’ll need to fire up the BBQ for this baby and you don’t want the couch to smell funny.

But also – Shut. The. Front. Door! This is one nasty (in a good way) VEGAN patty.

Plus, it uses up all the kids in the crisper who were never asked to dance this week. And as our ‘hero before Thor’ would say, ‘Nobody puts baby in the corner.’

Yes, you can change the veg – you just need about 500–550 g (1 lb 3 oz) of hearty discard. Think cauli, ’shrooms, parsnip, beans, sweet potato ... etc.

Makes 8 patties

400 g (14 oz) tinned chickpeas including the liquid (aquafaba)

1 teaspoon garlic powder

1 teaspoon onion powder

1 tablespoon dried oregano

1 tablespoon finely chopped flat-leaf parsley leaves

2 teaspoons beef-style stock powder

1 teaspoon paprika

200 g (7 oz) broccoli

1–2 beetroot, peeled

2 carrots

225 g (8 oz) halloumi, grated
¼ cup (35 g) plain (all-purpose) flour
4 tablespoons panko breadcrumbs
canola oil, for frying

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

**toasted bread rolls, sliced cheese, mustard, shredded lettuce,
pickles, sliced tomato, charred onions, BBQ/tom sauce**

In a food processor, blend the chickpeas – liquid and all – with the garlic and onion powders, oregano, parsley, stock powder and paprika until chunky/smooth. Place into a large mixing bowl.

Chop the vegetables into manageable pieces of about 3–4 cm (1¼–1½ inches) and place in a food processor, a few cups at a time, to blitz until they are chopped quite fine.

Add the blitzed veg to the chickpea mix along with the grated halloumi, flour and panko crumbs and stir well to combine. The mix should resemble a mushy, thick paste, one you can form into patties of about ⅓ cup each.

Cook on an oiled preheated BBQ flat grill plate or in an oiled frying pan for about 5 minutes on each side. The burgers will become crisp and brown. Be careful as you flip to ensure they don't break up.

Enjoy them as you would a burger, rissole, meatball – do as you wish. It's nearly Friday after all.





Beet Falafel

Alert: you need to start this one the day before, but future you will kiss you for it.

This is a recipe that gives twice. Do the dirty work now and give your future self a night off when you can rip these falafels straight from the freezer into the pan.

Serves 6 (and the same again in the freezer)

1½ cups (295 g) dried chickpeas (you can't use tinned here because they are too mushy)

1½ cups (295 g) split fava beans

2 cups (520 g) Greek-style yoghurt

1 carrot, coarsely chopped

1 celery stalk, roughly chopped

1 brown onion, coarsely chopped

2 beetroot, quartered with skins on

2 garlic cloves, smashed

1 teaspoon ground coriander

1 tablespoon ground cumin

2 tablespoons sea salt flakes

vegetable oil, for shallow frying

pita pockets

½ cup (80 g) cornichons or pickles, sliced or chopped

1 small salad onion, thinly sliced

PARSLEY SALAD

1 cup (20 g) flat-leaf parsley, leaves only

1 teaspoon sumac

1 teaspoon sea salt flakes

1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil

2 tablespoons red wine vinegar

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

chilli sauce

OK, let's get all that overnight palaver done.

Place the chickpeas and fava beans in a large bowl and fill with water. Cover with a plate to stop cats/gnats bathing in it and leave overnight. The pulses will double in size.

Then we need to reverse the concept for the labne. Place a small strainer* over a bowl and line with three sheets of paper towel or, if you have it, muslin.

Pop the yoghurt in and allow it to drain/dry out overnight. The result is a rich sour cream cheese that can be balled up and stored in oil or rolled in herbs. The longer it drains, the thicker it will get. Please note: the draining contraption has to fit in the fridge so make sure it does before you use a sieve with a 40-foot handle.

The next step is super simple, but you need a food processor.

Blend the carrot, celery, brown onion and beets until finely diced. Add the drained pulses and blend until the mixture is grainy. Blend in the garlic, spices and salt.

Test a falafel by seeing if you can mush a small lump into a patty. It will stain your hands pink – more glamorous than turmeric. Maybe

use spoons. If it holds together, then you can begin frying. If it doesn't, blend a bit more until it does.

Heat vegetable oil in a heavy-based frying pan over medium heat and shallow fry the falafels in batches, turning each falafel once as you cook. They should take about 5 minutes each.

Fry enough for your dinner and store any uncooked falafels in an airtight container in the freezer for up to 3 months.

For the salad, toss the parsley with the sumac, salt, olive oil and vinegar.

Serve the falafels warm on fresh pita with labne, parsley salad, pickles and salad onion.

* A shout out to those 500 g (1 lb 2 oz) ricotta baskets here – not only do they drain labne, but they also hold Lego mid-construction, collect toys from the bath in a single scoop, and are great little vessels to pick and rinse herbs in!





Giant Stuffed Rosti

It should look like you might feel after a dusty day spent sunbaking – golden, crispy, greasy and maybe just a little gooey.

Do I think this is fun to make? Yes!

Is it fun to simply think about? 100% YES!

Will it make you more friends and increase attractiveness? Without question.

Stop mucking about and get serious about life with this giant stuffed rosti.

I don't know how to get you out of all that grating aside from suggesting that you buy an appliance that has a grating attachment – you won't look back; I promise you'll grate everything.

Serves 8 at brunch or as a side

1.5 kg (3 lb 5 oz) potatoes, peeled and grated

1 brown onion, peeled and grated

2 teaspoons fine salt

½ cup (70 g) plain (all-purpose) flour

3 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil

2 garlic cloves, grated

2 zucchini (courgettes), grated

2 cups (250 g) grated mozzarella

1 cup (100 g) grated gruyere
1 teaspoon chilli flakes
1 tablespoon fresh oregano leaves
1 tablespoon lemon zest
2½ tablespoons salted butter
3 tablespoons polenta

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

chutney, but only to slow you down

In a large bowl combine the potatoes, onion and salt. Set aside for 20 minutes, then squeeze out all of the excess moisture. Stir in the flour.

Heat 1 tablespoon of the olive oil in a large ovenproof non-stick pan over medium heat and cook the garlic until golden, about 2 minutes. Remove the garlic and wipe out the pan.

In a separate bowl, mix the zucchini, cheeses, chilli flakes, oregano, lemon zest and fried garlic.

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced.

Return the pan to medium–high heat and add the butter and remaining 2 tablespoons of olive oil. Once the butter is melted and bubbling, sprinkle in 1 tablespoon of polenta.

Place just over half the potato mixture into the pan, being careful not to displace the polenta. The best way to do this is to add little spoonfuls rather than a big splodge, and use a spatula to pat it down into a flat cake.

Distribute the zucchini mixture over the potato, leaving a 1 cm ($\frac{1}{2}$ inch) border. Top with the remaining potato mixture and pat it down. Sprinkle the remaining polenta on top and cook for around 10 minutes.

Place a large plate on top of the frying pan and hold the pan with a tea towel. Now flip the pan upside down so the rosti falls out onto the plate. Then very professionally slide the rosti back into the pan and fry for a further 10 minutes.

Now, place the pan in the oven for 20 minutes. The rosti will be golden, crispy and greasy when done ... and maybe a little gooey if any cheese has escaped.

Allow the rosti to rest for 10 minutes and then flip it out onto a serving platter before cutting into sections.

I realise this recipe calls for a lot of flipping, but once you've done it once you won't look back. And who doesn't love a mad kitchen flip. Enjoy.

Disclaimer: Author does not recommend sunbaking until golden and crispy!





Cuban Arancini

Left-over carbs + canned corn + condiments.

Arancini is usually made with left-over risotto rice, but I don't often make risotto and if I do there's usually not much left over. But left-over steamed rice I often have in abundance, plus it's easy to add an extra container to a takeaway order – a great idea anyway to stash in the freezer for last-minute fry-ups.

All these flavours come together from a memory bank I have of eating Cuban sandwiches and grilled corn in NY. It's a great dinner, and even better with a frozen margarita.

Serves 4

4 cups (740 g) cooked white rice
125 g (4½ oz) tinned creamed corn
300 g (10½ oz) tinned corn kernels, drained
2 spring onions (scallions), white and green parts, finely sliced
2 eggs
½ cup (120 g) kewpie mayo
½ cup (50 g) grated parmesan
¼ cup (40 g) finely diced dill pickles
¼ cup (40 g) finely diced pickled jalapeños
1 garlic clove, crushed
250 g (9 oz) sliced mozzarella (16 slices)
2½ cups (150 g) panko breadcrumbs
olive oil spray

2 cups (500 ml) store-bought ajvar (red capsicum and eggplant sauce) or your favourite salsa

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

coriander, lime and extra chilli

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced.

Line a large baking tray with baking paper.

Blend ¼ cup (45 g) of the rice and all the creamed corn together on high speed in a food processor.

In a large bowl, combine this mixture with all the remaining ingredients except for the mozzarella, panko, oil and ajvar. Using your hands to massage the ingredients together is both a satisfying and thorough way to mix everything well.

Set the mixture aside for 15 minutes so it can rest and the cooked rice can absorb some moisture.

Use a ¼ cup measure to portion out the rice mixture into 16 patties.

Place a slice of cheese into the centre of each patty and mould the rice around it.

Roll each patty in panko crumbs and spray lightly on both sides with the olive oil spray.

Place on the prepared tray and bake in the oven for 20 minutes, until golden and crisp.

Serve with a big dollop of ajvar or your favourite store-bought salsa.





Peri-Peri Popcorn Cauli

Once you start this whole ordeal, there's no stopping or turning back.

This isn't a traditional recipe. I have made it from flavours I've picked up – likely similar to a winemaker with a bad nose remaking something they drank once.

The lemongrass comes from left field but I wouldn't leave it out now because I just love the addition and I reckon you'll like it too.

Also, if you want to make a gateway sauce for kids, remove the bird's eye and add it back in slowly until they can handle it over time.

Serves 6

4 cups (1 litre) vegetable oil for deep frying
2 cups (300 g) plain (all-purpose) flour
3 cups (750 ml) cold soda water
1 cauliflower, cut into marble-sized florets, washed and dried
6 crusty bread rolls
3 tablespoons softened salted butter
200 g (7 oz) cheddar, sliced or grated
1 baby cos lettuce, leaves separated and washed
½ cup (120 g) mayonnaise

PERI-PERI

6 bird's eye chillies
1 cup (270 g) grilled marinated capsicum (pepper), chopped

2 lemongrass stems, white parts only, chopped
¼ cup (7 g) chopped flat-leaf parsley, stems and all
¼ cup (7 g) chopped coriander (cilantro), stems and all
5 garlic cloves, chopped
¼ cup (60 ml) red wine vinegar
1 cup (250 ml) extra virgin olive oil
1 tablespoon sea salt flakes

SEASONING

2 teaspoons garlic powder
2 teaspoons paprika
1 teaspoon fine salt

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

a wire spider (I highly recommend – you'll be amazed how often you use it)

For the peri-peri, use a food processor to blend everything together until smooth.

Transfer to a small saucepan and simmer over medium heat for 15–20 minutes. It shouldn't reduce; however, you do want the fresh things to cook off in the oil and for the solids to separate from the liquids, creating an iridescent oily sauce.

Set aside until ready to use. You can store this sauce in an airtight container in the fridge for a week.

Combine the seasoning ingredients in a small bowl and set aside.

Depending on the size of the large heavy-based saucepan you are using, fill it only ⅓ –½ of the way up with vegetable oil. Oil expands

and froths when you fry and spilling can cause a fire. Just make sure the oil is deep enough for a batch of florets to swim in. Heat the oil to 180–190°C (350–375°F).

Use a large mixing bowl to very loosely combine the flour and the soda. Lumps are fine and will give you crispy fun bits.

Using a wire scoop, dunk a batch of cauliflower into the batter and then into the oil.

It should take about 2 minutes for them to become golden and crisp. Scoop cooked pieces out and place them on a wire rack to drain. Throw on the seasoning as you go.

Once you've made it through the batch cooking, preheat the oven grill.

Cut open the bread rolls, butter liberally (yes, here we are again), layer with cheese slices and grill until bubbling, 1–2 minutes.

Fill with crispy lettuce, a swipe of mayo, a huge drizzle of peri-peri and a scoop of crunchy cauli. Dribble on more sauce and mayo, crunch it all together and chomp on in.

I owe my 16-year-old beach body to daily swims and these good Portuguese Bondi burgers.





Calzleme

Gozleme + Calzone = Calzleme

This recipe is a piece-together of a couple of favourites and sees cheese and spinach – gozleme standards – shaped like calzone.

But most importantly: what do calzone and gozleme have in common? My love. Oh, and flatty dough.

Serves 4

DOUGH

2¼ cups (335 g) self-raising flour

1 cup (260 g) Greek-style yoghurt

1 teaspoon fine salt

1 teaspoon extra virgin olive oil, plus extra for oiling the bowl

FILLING

120 g (4¼ oz) thawed and squeezed spinach, from a 250 g/9 oz packet of frozen spinach

3 marinated long-stem artichokes, chopped

1 small garlic clove, smashed

pinch of chilli flakes

2 teaspoons extra virgin olive oil, plus extra for brushing the calzleme

1 teaspoon white wine vinegar

fine salt and freshly ground black pepper, to taste

150 g (5½ oz) fresh ricotta

⅔ cup (100 g) feta

**½ cup (65 g) grated mozzarella, plus ¼ cup (35 g) more to sprinkle
on top of the spinach**

1 lemon, zest finely grated, cut into wedges to serve

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

**A BBQ; it must have a flat plate and a lid. Grill on medium heat with
the lid closed for 10–15 minutes, turning the calzleme once.**

In the bowl of a standmixer fitted with the dough hook, place 2 cups (300 g) of the flour, the yoghurt and salt and mix on medium speed for 2–3 minutes. Add 1 teaspoon of olive oil and keep mixing, adding more flour if needed, 1 tablespoon at a time, until a soft, elastic dough forms. Shape the dough into a ball and oil a large bowl. Place the dough into the bowl, cover and leave in a warm place to rest for 30 minutes.

Meanwhile, for the filling, combine the spinach, artichokes, garlic, chilli flakes, 2 teaspoons olive oil and white wine vinegar in a bowl and season.

In another bowl, combine the ricotta, feta, ½ cup (65 g) of the mozzarella and the lemon zest.

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced. Line two baking trays with baking paper.

Place the rested dough ball on a piece of baking paper and cut it into quarters.

Take one piece of dough and dust it with the remaining ¼ cup (35 g) of flour. Roll it out to around 15 x 25 cm (6 x 10 inches). You're going to put filling ingredients on one half of the dough, leaving the

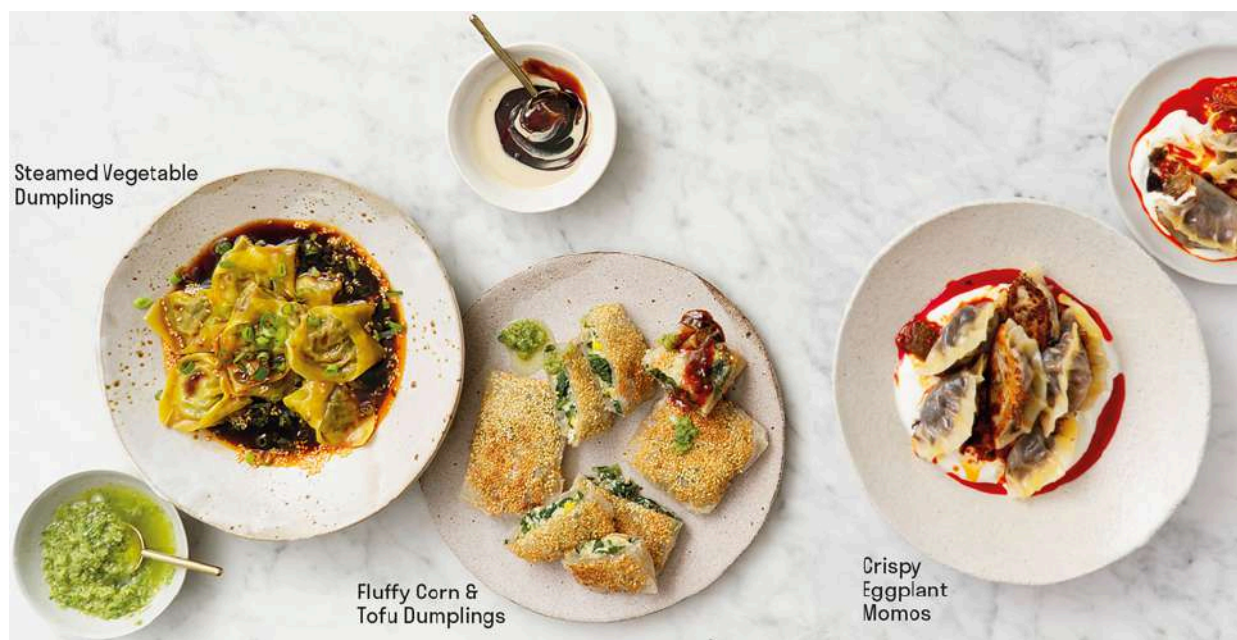
other half bare. Spread a quarter of the cheese mixture over half of the dough, leaving a 1 cm ($\frac{1}{2}$ inch) border. Top with a quarter of the spinach mixture. Sprinkle a little of the extra mozzarella on top of the spinach then fold the dough over the filled side. Press and pinch to seal the edges, removing air bubbles as you go.

Repeat with the remaining three dough pieces and cheese and spinach mixtures.

Brush both sides of the calzeme with olive oil and place them on the trays. Bake for 20 minutes, swapping oven positions at 10 minutes to ensure they cook evenly. The calzeme will be golden brown, puffy and crisp when ready.

Slice and serve with lemon wedges.





Dumplings

Basically a nood's best friend, but cool enough to stand alone, these perfect little pockets of punchy flavour deserve their own sauce but, of course, sharing those is the best bit.

The concept of eating dumplings has evolved from 'snack' to 'meal' because, like most tiny things, they are great – and one or two is never enough.

Serves 4

Steamed Vegetable Dumplings

Makes 30

125 g (4½ oz) mushrooms (any variety you like), finely diced
1 teaspoon finely grated ginger
2 spring onions (scallions), white and green parts, chopped
1 garlic clove, smashed
1 tablespoon peanut oil
fine salt and freshly ground black pepper, to taste
1 celery stalk, finely diced
1 bok choy, finely diced
½ cup (80 g) water chestnuts, chopped
½ cup (125 g) bamboo shoots, chopped
2 teaspoons mushroom oyster sauce
½ teaspoon sesame oil
2 teaspoons cornflour (cornstarch)
1 pack square wonton wrappers
1 carrot, sliced thinly on the diagonal
2 tablespoons soy sauce
1 teaspoon rice vinegar
1 teaspoon chilli oil
1 teaspoon sesame seeds, toasted

Over high heat in a large non-stick pan, sauté the mushrooms, ginger, spring onion and garlic for 5 minutes in peanut oil. Season well with S+P.

Add the celery, bok choy, water chestnuts, bamboo shoots, mushroom oyster sauce and sesame oil. Toss well to combine then remove the pan from the heat. This is not about cooking the veg, but tossing everything well and releasing some flavour with a little warmth. The veg also speeds up the cooling process.

Once cool, stir through the cornflour.

Place a teaspoon of mix in the centre of a wrapper, wet the edges with water and seal well by pressing together. Repeat with the remaining mix and wrappers.

Steam over boiling water, with each dumpling sitting on a carrot slice to prevent sticking, for around 20 minutes.

Combine the soy sauce, vinegar, chilli oil and sesame seeds to create a dipping sauce.

Fluffy Corn & Tofu Dumplings

Makes 8

300 g (10½ oz) firm tofu

125 g (4½ oz) tinned creamed corn

⅔ cup (135 g) tinned corn kernels, drained

2 tablespoons garlic chives, finely snipped

1 celery stalk, finely diced

1½ teaspoons fine salt

¼ teaspoon Chinese five-spice

1 teaspoon finely grated ginger

1 egg white, whisked until fluffy

1 tablespoon cornflour (cornstarch)

16 x 20 cm (8 inch) round rice paper sheets

⅓ cup (40 g) sesame seeds

145 ml (4¾ fl oz) peanut oil

3 spring onions (scallions), white and green parts, chopped

10 cm (4 inch) knob of ginger extra, peeled and grated

1 teaspoon sesame oil

2 tablespoons mushroom oyster sauce

2 tablespoons tahini

In a large mixing bowl break up the tofu with a whisk, then fold in the creamed corn, corn kernels, garlic chives, celery, 1 teaspoon of the salt, the Chinese five-spice and the 1 teaspoon grated ginger. Once combined, add the egg white and cornflour.

On a 30 x 40 cm (12 x 16 inch) tray lined with baking paper, smooth the mixture out into a rectangle around 1 cm ($\frac{1}{2}$ inch) thick. Place it into the freezer for 30 minutes. Remove from the freezer and cut it into 8 cm ($3\frac{1}{4}$ inch) squares.

Soften one sheet of rice paper at a time (follow the packet directions) and place a square of mixture in the centre. Fold over the edges to enclose. Do a double layer of the wrapping, flipping the square over to seal the open side.

Sprinkle the sesame seeds onto a plate. Press the dumplings into the sesame seeds.

Fry the dumplings in 1 tablespoon of the peanut oil over medium heat, turning once, until crisp on both sides – around 4 minutes a side.

Place the spring onion, ginger and remaining $\frac{1}{2}$ teaspoon of salt in a small bowl. Heat the remaining peanut oil and the sesame oil in a small pan, then pour it on top of the spring onion and ginger for a dipping sauce.

Combine the mushroom oyster sauce and tahini in a small bowl for a sweet sesame dipping sauce.

Crispy Eggplant Momos

Makes 30

½ brown onion, finely diced
3 tablespoons peanut oil
2 garlic cloves, smashed
1 eggplant (aubergine), cut into 1 cm (½ inch) cubes
½ teaspoon szechuan peppercorns
2 tablespoons rogan josh curry paste
1½ tablespoons black vinegar
1 teaspoon soft brown sugar
1 pack round gow gee wrappers
1 cup (260 g) Greek-style yoghurt
2 tablespoons achar pickles

Over high heat in a large non-stick frying pan, sauté the onion for 5 minutes in 2 tablespoons of the peanut oil. Add the garlic and eggplant and cook for a further 5 minutes. Reduce the heat to medium. Stir through the szechuan and curry paste and cook until fragrant and everything is softening, around 10 minutes.

Remove from the heat and add the vinegar and sugar. Stir well and allow to cool.

Place a teaspoon of the mixture in the centre of a wrapper, wet the edges and seal well by pressing together. Repeat with the

remaining wrappers and mixture.

Place a single layer (8–10) of dumplings in a large non-stick frying pan with the remaining 1 tablespoon peanut oil on medium heat. Fry for 5 minutes, then add 1 cup (250 ml) of water and cover with a lid. Simmer for 10 minutes, or until the momos are cooked through and the liquid has been absorbed.

Serve on yoghurt and achar.



Phat Snack Fridays

Throw-it-together munchies that morph and grow depending on the number of guests (invited or not).

The criteria for this chapter are: 1. Use it up and 2. Make it irresistible.

There's a lot of 'using up' done on Friday at our house, when we seek out the forgotten ambitions that have been left in the veg drawer to flop. I don't particularly love hindsight – my response is to embrace what wasn't and turn it into what will be. Making it irresistible and easy entails fun flavours, silly ideas, lots of dipping, everything hand-held and, if all else fails, fry it.

Also, all of these recipes are designed to be shared snacks – halfway between carrot sticks and a roast dinner in terms of filling.



Disco Fries

Vodka sodas might not make you any friends, but this gravy will.

Aka poutine, which I don't love as a word, but as with anything with heritage, we should definitely learn the truth, appreciate it and accept it. However, 'Disco Fries' sounds fun, and helps authorise their consumption after hours.

I am not sure what kind of fries and gravy dancer you are, but for me – half crisp, half wet sog is a delightful concept. I like gravy levels to be high enough to warrant the question, 'Is it ... soup?'

My advice is to make this gravy, freeze it and have it ready because – vegetarian or not – when you want chips and gravy with a slap of mozzarella, you don't want any delay.

Serves 4

FRIES

1.8 kg (4 lb) potatoes, washed and cut into 1–1.5 cm (½ inch) sticks, skins on

¼ cup (60 ml) rice bran oil

110 g (3¾ oz) buffalo mozzarella, torn or sliced

GRAVY

120 g (4¼ oz) field mushrooms

2 tablespoons balsamic vinegar

¼ cup (60 ml) extra virgin olive oil

180 g (6 oz) carrots, cut into 3 cm (1¼ inch) chunks

2 brown onions, cut into 3 cm (1¼ inch) chunks
3 celery stalks, cut into 3 cm (1¼ inch) chunks
1 garlic head, cut in half horizontally, skin on
½ bunch thyme sprigs
2 tablespoons rosemary leaves
¼ cup (60 ml) red wine
1 tablespoon dijon mustard
1 tablespoon (2 g) dried porcini mushrooms, soaked in ¼ cup (60 ml) boiling water and allowed to cool
1 tablespoon salted butter
2 tablespoons plain (all-purpose) flour
2 cups (500 ml) beef-style stock
fine salt and freshly ground black pepper, to taste

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

midnight vodka sodas

First up, soak the potatoes in cold water for a few hours to remove starch.

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced.

For the gravy, tear the field mushrooms into rough chunks and throw them in a bowl with the balsamic vinegar and 1 tablespoon of the olive oil. Toss and set aside.

Toss the carrots, onions, celery, garlic and herbs in the remaining olive oil and place in a large ovenproof frying pan or flameproof baking dish with ¼ cup (60 ml) of water.

Roast for 15 minutes, then add the marinated field mushrooms and toss well. Roast for another 15 minutes until the veg are golden and

caramelised.

Remove the pan or dish from the oven and place on the stove over medium–high heat. Deglaze with red wine to release all the sticky good bits.

Increase the oven temperature to 220°C (425°F). Dry the potatoes, toss them in rice bran oil and spread them out on a baking tray or two. Season with a big pinch of salt. Bake for 30 minutes, turning once or twice, until golden brown.

Add the dijon mustard, the soaked porcini (and the liquid) to the pan on the stove, and stir until most of the liquid is absorbed, around 10 minutes. Reduce the heat to medium and add the butter and flour, stirring constantly to form a smooth paste.

Add the stock slowly, and continue to stir until a smooth gravy has formed, then remove from the heat.

Mash the veg with a potato masher, making sure to squish out all the garlic from the head, then strain the gravy into a bowl, catching all the liquid. Push and mash the veg through as much as possible. For a really silky gravy blend the strained liquid until very smooth. Season to taste and keep warm until ready to use.

Serve the chips loaded with gravy and torn mozzarella.





Salt & Battery Floral

Zucchini flower season is short and sweet, so change whatever cooking plans you have when the blooms appear and make this.

Yes, we know how to do Italian-style stuffed zucchini flowers – or it's easy enough to find out – but do you know how to do them Japanese-style?

I didn't, but I do now, and I just don't know how I can go back – knowing me I'll likely go back and forth forever. That's the beauty of food – tiny changes with ingredients and we have a whole new story to inspire us.

I went deep into method cooking and used long wooden chopsticks to manoeuvre the zuke flowers in and out of the batter and oil. The result was a pair of sticks with so many deep fried layers baubling at one end that they looked like spent matches. Did I chew the delicious crispy golden dagwood-ish dough off the ends? Great question. I'm not telling.

Serves 4–6 as a snack

16 zucchini flowers (with the baby zukes attached if you're lucky)
4 cups (1 litre) rice bran or vegetable oil

STUFFING

230 g (8½ oz) fresh ricotta
1 garlic clove, smashed
1 teaspoon white miso paste

1 teaspoon finely grated fresh ginger
2 teaspoons mirin
2 teaspoons finely grated lemon zest
¼ cup (20 g) finely shredded nori

MAYO

½ cup (120 g) kewpie mayo
1 tablespoon wasabi
1 teaspoon lemon juice

BATTER

1¾ cups (260 g) plain (all-purpose) flour
1½ cups (375 ml) soda water
1 teaspoon fine salt

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

shichimi togarashi (Japanese chilli seasoning)

For the stuffing, combine the ricotta, garlic, miso, ginger, mirin, zest and nori in a bowl and stir until well mixed.

The next step, like icing a cake, is a bit fiddly. But unlike an iced cake, the end result is really satisfying. (This is all true unless you REALLY love cake more than fried salty stuff. Divisive statement I know.)

Gently peel open the petals and remove the stamens. You can leave them in, but more room for cheese sounds ideal to me. Spoon in the filling, pressing it in with the back of the spoon. Pros: suitable for laziness; cons: messy, rough.

Alternatively, use a piping bag or snap-lock bag with the corner cut off to pipe the stuffing in. Pros: neat; cons: an extra step as you

look for bags.

Whichever you do, twirl the ends to close the filling in and move on. The filled flowers can sit on a baking tray lined with baking paper until you're ready to fry.

Prep the wasabi mayo by adding the ingredients to a bowl and doing a half mix. I like it unmixed, because you can swipe hard right or left and get different flavours. But again, don't be led by my enthusiasm – mix well if you like.

Now make the batter by combining the flour, soda water and salt in a bowl. Don't overmix this: it's not laziness, it's deliberate. Do what I say here: you want soda bubbles and a few flour pockets to keep the batter light.

Heat the oil in a deep saucepan or wok* over medium–high heat to 190°C (375°F).

Dunk a flower into the batter, then lower it into the pan. It should bubble and begin to turn golden in 2 minutes. Gently turn it with a slotted spoon and cook for a further 2 minutes. Continue cooking in batches you can handle and allow the oil to reheat after a few goes.

Place the flowers on a wire rack to drain before serving.

* A wok is a great frying vessel because you can have the oil semi-deep but you still have room to scoop the contents out easily.





Deep-Pan Aperitivo

This is an anti-finger-sticking situation.

The whole finger pressing into wet squelchy oily dough thing on Instagram/TikTok is sexual – we know that, right? Yes, I'm into it ... but alone. It seems like it should be done in private – like mud wrestling and opening your bank app.

Twice-baking this focaccia is inspired by my good mate Monty, the king of playful aperitivo.

Serves 8 as a snack

3¼ cups (500 g) plain (all-purpose) flour

1 teaspoon instant yeast

1 tablespoon fine salt

2 teaspoons white (granulated) sugar

2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil

1½ cups (375 ml) warm water

400 g (14 oz) tinned crushed tomatoes

390 g (13¾ oz) tomato passata (puréed tomatoes)

TAPENADE

½ cup (80 g) pitted kalamata olives

½ cup (85 g) pitted Sicilian olives

2 garlic cloves, smashed

1 teaspoon dried oregano

3 tablespoons rosemary leaves, chopped

2 teaspoons fine salt

½ cup (125 ml) extra virgin olive oil

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

some kind of bitter spritz

Place the flour, yeast, salt and sugar in the bowl of a standmixer fitted with the dough hook and combine on medium speed. Make a deep well in the centre of the dry ingredients, then add the oil and warm water. Turn the mixer back on to medium and mix for 10–12 minutes, or until the dough is combined and stretchy.

Cover with plastic wrap and allow to prove somewhere warm for 1–1½ hours. Ideal spots: in a switched-off dryer that has just been on for 5 minutes, on a sunny kitchen bench where there is no draught or, if you are fancy enough, in a warming drawer. My editor puts hers under the duvet in her bed with a hot water bottle. Good idea, although I would probably forget it was there until the shocking discovery later that evening.

Meanwhile, place a strainer over a bowl and line it with some paper towel. Tip the crushed toms in and set aside to drain while you wait.

To make the tapenade, combine all the ingredients in a small bowl and roughly blitz with a stick blender until it is a chunky paste. Set aside.

Once the dough has risen, punch it down and flop it out onto a lightly floured surface. Knead for 5 minutes, then stretch it out on the bench so you have a rectangle about 3 cm (1¼ inches) thick.

Spread the tapenade out over the dough, then fold the dough over onto itself. Fold the dough in half another six or so times (you are

folding in the filling here). The chunky, uneven channels of filling make for a really delightful experience when eating this bread. So don't overwork it.

Lightly oil an ovenproof dish or – as I used – a cast-iron frying pan. Place the filled dough into the pan and push it out to the edges. Cover with plastic wrap and allow it to prove again for 30 minutes (it should double in size).

Preheat the oven to 230°C (450°F) fan-forced.

Combine the drained crushed toms with the passata in a bowl (use the drained tomato liquid for something else).

Spoon half of the tomato mixture over the risen dough.

Bake for 15 minutes, then add the remaining tomato mixture. Bake for another 15–20 minutes, until the top is deep red from the tomatoes and the dough is fluffy and spongy.

Allow it to cool, then slice it into crispy-edged fluffy bread strips and enjoy with all your fave snack mates.





Buffalo Jals

Pronounced Hals.

Let's take something delicious, fresh and bright, stuff it with cheese, crumb it and fry it, shall we?

Yes, great idea.

But make it really spicy so we forget and rub our eyes while we work.

Ugh, OK.

No, no, you don't have to do the last bit – it just serves as a warning to either chuck on some dishwashing gloves OR wash your hands 'covid' intensely after you've finished.

The deep-frying scenario begins again. I have a hot tip: buy a camp stove and fry outside. 'Thank you', screams your wardrobe, couch and indoor air quality.

I often suggest a litre of oil but this depends on the pot you intend to fry in. Ideally, you want something deep and sort of wide. You should be able to add enough oil so that the thing you're frying can sink below the oil without hitting the base. But there should also be at least half of the pot edge above the oil so that it doesn't boil over.

Serves 6 as a snack

600 g (1 lb 5 oz) jalapeños

1 cup (230 g) cream cheese

1 cup (100 g) grated smoked cheddar
1 garlic clove, smashed
1 tablespoon chives, finely snipped
½ teaspoon cayenne pepper
¼ cup (35 g) plain (all-purpose) flour
1 egg, lightly whisked with 1 tablespoon water
1 cup (60 g) panko breadcrumbs
4 cups (1 litre) canola oil (or any high heat oil you prefer), for deep frying

BUFFALO SAUCE

2 tablespoons tomato sauce (ketchup)
⅓ cup (80 ml) hot sauce (I use Frank's RedHot)
1½ tablespoons tabasco
1 tablespoon soft brown sugar
¼ cup (60 g) cold salted butter, cubed

BLUE CHEESE DIP

75 g (2½ oz) soft blue cheese
2 tablespoons mayo
¼ cup (70 g) Greek-style yoghurt

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

margaritas seem more essential than optional, but your call

Halve the jalapeños and remove the seeds. Keep the handy stalks attached.

Combine the cream cheese, cheddar, garlic and chives in a bowl, then divide the mixture in half. Spike one half with cayenne pepper – because roulette without real bullets is fun.

Use a teaspoon to smoosh the stuffing mix into the open faces of the jals.

Dip and toss each chilli into the flour, dunk them into the egg wash, then roll them straight into the panko crumbs. Set aside in the fridge until ready to cook.

For the sauce, heat the tomato sauce, hot sauce, tabasco and brown sugar in a saucepan over medium heat, stirring, until the sugar is dissolved. Whisk in the cold butter until the sauce is smooth and silky. This can be stored in the fridge.

For the dip, use a stick blender to blitz the blue cheese, mayo and yoghurt until mostly smooth (some chunks of blue are good) and store in the fridge until ready to use.

Heat the oil to medium–high heat (180–190°C/350–375°F), then lower the jals in to fry until golden brown, around 3 minutes all up, including turning. Carefully scoop them out with a slotted spoon or wire scoop so that the crumb coating isn't broken.

Place on a rack to drain.





A Private Artichoke

It's distressing but also completely pleasing that no one in my household joins me in my obsession with this thistle.

I've devoured artichokes since I was seven. The garlic butter, the oily crumb, the process of pulling the leaves, the final chomping on the heart, the sweetness of everything you taste afterwards. Pure joy.

As much as you want to share such a pleasure, if those around you don't get it then you must find peace with this. I only ever buy two artichokes. It's a gesture, but a gesture I can cover up and eat in its entirety if no one else wants to join me. Find yourself something they hate and love it alone.

The artichokes should be as green as possible. Avoid purple – this indicates the centre is turning to thistle and could probably kill you if consumed.

Also, the best eating of these is done by scraping your bottom teeth along the inner flesh of the petal. F*cking delicious.

Serves 1, maybe 2

artichokes, as many as you'd like

AIOLI

1 cup (235 g) mayonnaise

1 head garlic, cut in half horizontally, skin on, drizzled with oil,
wrapped in foil and baked at 180°C (350°F) fan-forced for 30

minutes

1 tablespoon dijon mustard

1 tablespoon lemon juice

1 tablespoon finely snipped chives or flat-leaf parsley leaves

GARLIC BUTTER

¼ cup (60 g) salted butter

¼ cup (60 ml) extra virgin olive oil

3 garlic cloves, finely chopped

STUFFING

¼ cup (30 g) breadcrumbs

1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil

1 tablespoon finely grated lemon zest

¼ cup (25 g) finely grated parmesan

1 garlic clove, smashed

1 tablespoon finely chopped flat-leaf parsley leaves

1 tablespoon dried oregano

1 tablespoon salted butter

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

everything and nothing

These are my two favourite ways with artichokes. The butter dipping situation is midweek quick and messy; my immediate response to new season globes. The stuffed beauty takes a little longer, but I file that under self-care (aka ‘the rest of you mofos can make your own dinner’).

To prepare the chokes for dipping, there’s no need to trim them, unless you want to tidy them a bit.

Cook the artichokes in rapidly boiling water for 20 minutes, or until one of the tough outer leaves peels off easily with tongs. Remove them from the water and drain upside down in a bowl.

Mix the aioli ingredients together in a bowl until smooth. Store what you don't use (around 4 serves) in a jar in the fridge for a week.

For the garlic butter, melt the butter with the oil and garlic in a small saucepan over medium heat, stirring occasionally until it begins to bubble and the garlic turns golden, around 5 minutes. Remove from the heat and serve warm in a bowl.

Eat the chokes warm, dipping every petal into the sauces.

For the stuffed chokes, preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced. Line a baking tray with baking paper.

Cut the top 2 cm ($\frac{3}{4}$ inch) off the artichokes and pry your way in to scoop out the centre, pulling back leaves as much as you can. Trim the stalk flush with the base of the artichoke so that it sits facing up.

Combine all the stuffing ingredients except the butter in a bowl and set aside.

Boil the artichokes as you did for dipping, then use a spoon to pack every leaf with as much stuffing as possible. Place on the baking tray, top with butter and bake for 15 minutes, or until golden.

Eat warm.





Fried Mini Tacos

I stand with tinned jackfruit.

Having grown up on a farm, it doesn't feel quite right to me to eat something processed before I've eaten the real thing. However, I haven't eaten fresh jackfruit. So, yes, I'm a hypocrite. In the past I've scoffed at jackfruit like a jerk.

BUT, while writing this book, although I didn't crave meat, I did crave new textures. Jackfruit is not a replacement for pulled pork – it's a stand-alone delicious, juicy, fibrous plant (think artichoke hearts!) that doesn't break down too much (looking at you, cauliflower) and is perfect for a ridiculously crispy fried taco with cheese sauce AND spicy avo dressing. Plus, the carnivores at home ate it without question.

Makes 20

1 long green chilli
3 green tomatoes or kumatos
2 stems coriander (cilantro), stems and leaves separated, chopped
pinch of fine salt
1 avocado, peeled and stone removed
1 tablespoon pickled jalapeños
1 tablespoon pickle juice from the jalapeños
2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil
2 tablespoons lime juice
1 spring onion (scallion), roughly chopped
1 green capsicum (pepper), finely diced

1 brown onion, finely diced
2 garlic cloves, smashed
1 teaspoon unsweetened cocoa powder
410 g (14½ oz) tinned young jackfruit, drained and broken up
1 tablespoon Mexican Seasoning from [here](#)
1 tablespoon finely grated lime zest
¼ cup (60 ml) vegetable stock
fine salt and freshly ground black pepper, to season
1 quantity Baby Beshy from [here](#)
2 cups (200 g) grated cheddar
1 tablespoon finely snipped chives
20 Asian pancakes (the type used for peking duck) or mini
tortillas/soft tacos
2 cups (500 ml) vegetable oil for shallow frying

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

extra lime to squeeze on top, and chilli sauce

Burn the green chilli skin over a naked stovetop flame, BBQ or under the grill. You are going for the charred skin flavour!

Using a food processor, blitz the tomatoes, green chilli, half of the chopped coriander stems and a pinch of salt until puréed. Set aside. In the same processor, blend the remaining coriander stems, avo, jalapeños, pickle juice, 1 tablespoon of the olive oil, 1 tablespoon of the lime juice and the spring onion until smooth. Set this aside also.

In a large, deep frying pan, sauté the capsicum and onion in the remaining olive oil over high heat for 5 minutes, or until starting to

char slightly.

Turn the heat down to medium and add the garlic, cocoa, jackfruit and Mexican Seasoning. Sauté for another 2 minutes, then add the blended tomato sauce, remaining lime juice, zest and stock.

Reduce the heat to low, cover and simmer for 10 minutes, then season with salt and pepper. You can make this ahead and store it in the fridge overnight. Bring it to room temperature before frying.

Meanwhile, make the Baby Beshy, then add the cheese, whisking, until it's bubbling and smooth, around 5 minutes. Add the chives and remove from the heat. Keep warm until serving.

Place a couple of tablespoons of jackfruit mix in the centre of each duck pancake (or mini tortilla/soft taco). Bring the sides together and secure with a toothpick to make them 'fry proof', weaving in and out across the top.

Heat the veg oil to 180–190°C (350–375°F) over medium heat in a high-sided frying pan. Pan-fry the filled tacos in batches, carefully turning so they cook for 1–2 minutes on each side. Remove when golden and place on a rack to drain.

Remove the toothpicks and serve scattered with the chopped coriander leaves, with the spicy avo dressing and cheese sauce alongside.





S+P Tofu Cups

Would you like a crispy cold beer with that?

The hot oil smell in this recipe triggers me, taking me back to a time when I was forced to say, ‘Would you like fries with that?’ 183 times a day. But honestly, all this crispy biz is full of fresh veg, and has actual produce crunch, not just fried crunch ... so if we think about it, it’s basically a green smoothie.

Serves 4 as a snack

500 g (1 lb 2 oz) semi-firm tofu

1 tablespoon fine salt

¼ teaspoon Chinese five-spice

2 spring onions (scallions), white parts sliced into 7 cm (2¾ inch) julienne, green tops thinly sliced into rings

1 cos lettuce

1 Lebanese (short) cucumber, cut into 7 cm (2¾ inch) batons

¼ cup (60 ml) hoisin sauce

1 lemon, cut into wedges

¼ cup (30 g) cornflour (cornstarch)

2 cups (500 ml) vegetable oil

2 rice paper rounds (the dry ones used for rolls), broken into eighths

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

Chilli Crisp from [here](#)

Now, for the tofu, have a little foresight (the kind and calm sister to hindsight, who is irritating and mildly patronising). Remove the tofu from its watery pack and place it on a tray lined with a wad of paper towel. Place another wad on top and top that with another tray with a bit of weight on it – no more than 400 g. Set aside for 2–3 hours (you could do this in the morning before work and chuck it in the fridge!). This just helps the airy brick release all the liquid it carries.

OK, let's sort our mise en place.

In a small bowl, combine the salt and Chinese five-spice so it's ready to sprinkle. Place the green spring onion rounds in another dish.

Arrange the washed lettuce, julienned spring onion and cucumber on a platter (or in separate bowls).

Put the hoisin into a reasonably easy vessel to dispense from.

Cut the lemon and have it ready.

Business time.

Cut the tofu into 0.5 x 2 x 4 cm ($\frac{1}{4} \times \frac{3}{4} \times 1\frac{1}{2}$ inch) rectangles and dust in the cornflour. It will likely still have liquid in it making the flour tacky, so do this at the last minute. Place the pieces on baking paper.

Heat the oil in a large, deep non-stick frying pan to 180–190°C (350–375°F).

Fry the rice paper pieces first, in batches of one or two. Each batch will take about 5 seconds, including turning, so be prepared. Use

tongs to turn and place them on a paper towel to drain.

Fry the tofu in the same oil until golden on both sides, around 1 minute. Be careful as the crust may split if left too long.

Drain on paper towel too. I know ... WTF, no rack?! We already have the towel out so I am sticking to the process.

Place on a serving plate while still warm and sprinkle with the Chinese five-spice mix and chopped spring onions and serve.

Eat like this: hand + lettuce + rice crisp + tofu + cuke + spring onions + hoisin + lemon juice. Hand > mouth (avoid fingers).





Sticky Maple Mustard Brussels

Glorious.

Like many a veg, brussels have historically been murdered in a vat of bubbling water, and extracted drowned, limp, grey-ish and closer in consistency to sick than anyone could stomach.

Their beauty can be found here: blistered in dry heat with a sweet marinade and spicy sprinkle, served on a heavenly cloud of tangy, creamy dressing thick enough to swipe through.

Serves 4 as a side

⅓ cup (80 ml) extra virgin olive oil
1 kg (2 lb 4 oz) baby brussels sprouts
1 garlic clove, smashed
¼ cup (70 g) white miso paste
1 tablespoon dijon mustard
3 tablespoons maple syrup
¼ cup (65 g) tahini
1 cup (260 g) Greek-style yoghurt
¼ cup (60 ml) lemon juice
1 tablespoon sesame seeds or Everything Bagel Seasoning from [here](#), to sprinkle

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

ground Korean chilli

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced. Lightly oil a baking tray with 1 tablespoon of the olive oil.

Trim off the base of the brussels and cut them in half. Some leaves will come loose and that's fine – these become crispy and delicious little burnt cinders.

Combine the garlic, miso, mustard, the remaining olive oil and 2 tablespoons of the maple syrup in a large bowl. Add the brussels, including the extra brussels leaves, and toss well.

Scatter onto the baking tray and roast for 20 minutes, until charred and crispy. Let them cool a little while you make the dressing.

Combine the tahini, yoghurt, lemon juice and remaining maple syrup in a medium bowl and mix well.

Dollop this tangy stuff in the centre of a shallow serving bowl or plate. Place the slightly cooled brussels on top of the dressing and sprinkle with sesame seeds or Everything Bagel Seasoning.

This works really well with a fried egg. Or on a bowl of quinoa. If you want to beef it all up, you know, sans beef.





Toffee Cheese & Fancy Crack

If this doesn't set you up for a smugly nonchalant 'Show & Tell', then I am NOT the show pony I claim to be.

Now, I don't quite know who needs to know this recipe compilation, but it is elevated and fancy AF.

The toffee is so 'fab & fun' (literally my mum's fave phrase of all time). You could be a total nut and switch out the grape juice for, you know, other grape juice like port or pinot.

The crackers are so artisanal you may as well splatter a little paint on your hands so you can throw in matter-of-factly that you 'had a little daub in the studio today while the dough was resting ...'

Makes 20 crackers + 1 showy wheel

CRACKERS

3 cups (450 g) plain (all-purpose) flour

2 teaspoons fine salt

½ cup (125 ml) extra virgin olive oil

¼ cup (60 ml) Everything Bagel Seasoning from [here](#)

TOFFEE BRIE

1 cup (220 g) white (granulated) sugar

½ cup (125 ml) grape juice, or 1 cup seedless dark grapes, blended and strained

1 wheel of brie

OPTIONAL

an audience

To make the crackers, combine the flour, salt, olive oil and $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (185 ml) water in a standmixer* fitted with the dough hook, and mix on medium speed until a smooth dough has formed, about 10 minutes.

Wrap in plastic wrap and place in the fridge to rest for 20 minutes.

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced. Line two baking trays with baking paper.

On a lightly floured surface, roll out tablespoon-sized chunks of dough to around 7 x 15 cm ($2\frac{3}{4}$ x 6 inches) and 3 mm ($\frac{1}{8}$ inches) thick.

Lay each cracker on a baking tray and scatter with Everything Bagel Seasoning. Gently press the seasoning in by covering the crackers with baking paper and pressing with your hand.

Bake the crackers for 5 minutes, swapping the tray positions halfway through cooking so that they bake evenly. They will be golden when ready.

Allow to cool before serving.**

For the toffee, in a small saucepan over medium–high heat, combine the sugar and juice then allow it to simmer on low WITHOUT STIRRING for about 15 minutes until it is beginning to darken.

Place the cheese in a heatproof dish or on a baking tray lined with baking paper and pour the toffee in a thin layer on top. The toffee will begin to harden as it cools on the cheese.

Allow it to set before serving.

If you have excess toffee, set some nuts in it on a tray lined with baking paper. You can silence the kids with it (it does seal your teeth together for a spell).

* You can form this dough using your hands in a bowl if you don't have a standmixer.

** You can store the crackers in an airtight container in the pantry for up to 3 months.





Party Pack

After practically deep-frying this whole chapter, it's time to wrap something in pastry.

MINCY PIES

Makes 20

2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil
¼ cup (60 g) salted butter
1 brown onion, finely chopped
3 garlic cloves, finely chopped
400 g (14 oz) each white cup and Swiss brown mushrooms
2 tablespoons plain (all-purpose) flour
⅔ cup (25 g) dried porcini mushrooms, soaked in 1 cup (250 ml)
boiling water
½ cup (60 g) crushed walnuts
1¼ cups (310 ml) beef-style stock
1 teaspoon balsamic vinegar
¼ cup (60 ml) single (pure) cream
5 square sheets ready-made frozen shortcrust pastry
4 square sheets ready-made frozen puff pastry
1 egg, whisked with 1 tablespoon water

Heat the oil and half the butter in a large non-stick saucepan over medium–high heat until bubbling. Sauté the onion for 3 minutes, then add the garlic and fresh mushrooms. Cook for 2 minutes, then reduce the heat to medium and cook for a further 8 minutes,

stirring often. Add the remaining butter and the flour and stir well. Add the porcini, $\frac{1}{4}$ cup (60 ml) of the reserved mushroom water and the walnuts to the pan. Stir to combine well. Slowly add the stock, vinegar and cream, stirring as you do. Cook until thickened, around 10 minutes, then allow to cool. Yields $2\frac{1}{2}$ cups (625 ml) filling.

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced. Grease a standard 12-hole muffin tin (5 cm base x 2.5 cm deep/2 x 1 inch).

Cut out four 11–12 cm ($4\frac{1}{4}$ – $4\frac{1}{2}$ inch) circles of shortcrust pastry per sheet for the pie bases. Cut out 7 cm ($2\frac{3}{4}$ inch) circles of puff pastry for the pie tops. Line the muffin holes with the shortcrust pastry. Fill each hole with 2 tablespoons of the cooled filling. Brush the edges of the bases with egg wash, then top with a puff pastry circle. Press the edges together with a fork. Prick the top and brush with egg wash. Bake until golden and puffy, around 15 minutes.

CHEESEBURGER ROLLS

Makes 40 mini rolls

300 g (10½ oz) sweet potatoes, coarsely chopped

150 g (5½ oz) carrots, coarsely chopped

300 g (10½ oz) potatoes, coarsely chopped

200 g (7 oz) cauliflower, coarsely chopped

1 teaspoon beef-style stock powder

1 teaspoon dried oregano

1 teaspoon tomato paste (concentrated purée)

1 teaspoon Vegemite

$\frac{1}{2}$ cup (30 g) panko breadcrumbs

**1 egg, whisked, plus an extra egg, whisked together with 1
tablespoon water, for glazing**
1 small white onion, finely chopped
½ cup (80 g) finely diced dill pickles
¼ cup (60 g) tomato sauce (ketchup)
1 tablespoon American mustard
4 square sheets ready-made frozen puff pastry
125 g (4½ oz) mozzarella, cut into sticks 5 mm (¼ inch) wide
1 tablespoon sesame seeds

Preheat the oven to 220°C (425°F) fan-forced. Line a baking tray with baking paper.

In a food processor, blend the sweet potato, carrot, potato and cauliflower until finely chopped. Add the stock powder, oregano, tomato paste and Vegemite, and pulse. Place on the baking tray and bake for 15 minutes. Allow to cool, then transfer to a large bowl and stir through the panko, egg, onion, pickles, tom sauce and mustard. Yields 3 cups (750 ml) filling.

Reduce the oven temperature to 200°C (400°F). Line a baking tray with baking paper.

Cut the puff pastry in half so you have two strips 10 cm (4 inch) wide. Brush one long side and both ends with egg wash. Place the filling down the centre of the pastry, leaving a 1 cm (½ inch) edge at the short ends. The filling should be 5 cm (2 inches) wide and 1 cm (½ inch) thick. Place a row of cheese down the centre, then top with more filling. Stretch the pastry up and over the filling and roll it down onto the egg-washed edge. Pinch the short ends of the roll

together to trap the cheese. Brush with egg wash, sprinkle with sesame seeds and score the pastry at 4 cm (1½ inch) intervals (cut and separate the rolls after cooking). Bake for 15 minutes, or until golden.



Massaman Skewers

Ideally you should eat this with your legs dangling in a pool.

Do you need the skewers? No, this dish is baked on a tray in the oven. Do you want the skewers? Yes, it's fun to poke holes in things and the skewers make everything prettier to style.

This recipe makes me truly happy: the sticky delish of the pumpkin sugars, the charry skin (who does not eat this?!), crunchy peanuts, thick saucy satay and, of course, chilli, lime and rice.

I used to jump off the bus after school and grab a container of rice and satay sauce from the Thai joint around the corner from Mum's ceramic studio. It's the perfect snack – you can eat a little or a lot, but never too much.

Makes around 6 skewers

1 teaspoon curry powder
2 teaspoons garlic powder
1 teaspoon fine salt
½ teaspoon crushed makrut lime leaves
2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil
750 g (1 lb 10 oz) kent pumpkin (squash), cut into 3 cm (1¼ inch) wedges, skin on, seeds removed
1 red onion, cut into six wedges
2 cups (370 g) steamed white rice
2 tablespoons toasted salted peanuts, crushed, plus extra for garnish

1 lime, cut into six wedges

SATAY

⅔ cup (215 g) crunchy peanut butter

1 tablespoon white miso paste

1 teaspoon tamarind paste

1 tablespoon honey

¼ teaspoon garlic powder

1 tablespoon soy sauce

⅔ cup (170 ml) hot water

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

chilli flakes, chilli oil, coriander (cilantro), Thai basil

Preheat the oven to 240°C (475°F). Line a baking tray with baking paper.

Combine the curry and garlic powders, salt, lime leaves and oil in a large mixing bowl and toss with the pumpkin.

Thread about four pieces of pumpkin onto a skewer, with a few slices of onions in between each, and place on the tray. Bake for 15 minutes.

Meanwhile, whisk together the satay ingredients in a bowl until well combined. Season with chilli oil swirled through if you like. (Store any excess satay in a jar in the fridge for up to a week.)

When the skewers are done, carefully place on a bed of steamed rice and drizzle with some of the satay, reserving some for people to add at their leisure/discretion. Top with extra crushed peanuts, lime wedges and a sprinkle of chilli flakes if you like.





Storeroom Spreads

Tins, condiments and frozen veg: yes, it's EMERGENCY dips, seriously easy, and bloody good for dipping with veg, slapping on a cracker or smearing in a sambo.

You will need a food processor, or an amazing bicep and a large mortar and pestle. Store dips for up to 4 days in the fridge.

Each makes 1½ cups (375 ml)

Spinach, Feta, Basil

125 g (4 oz) frozen spinach, thawed, excess water gently squeezed out

½ cup (110 g) marinated artichokes, drained

1 spring onion (scallion), roughly chopped

8 basil leaves

115 g (4 oz) fresh ricotta

90 g (3¼ oz) feta

Blend the spinach, artichokes, spring onion and basil until smooth.
Add in the ricotta and feta and pulse until well combined.

White Bean Parmy

400 g (14 oz) tinned white beans, drained

½ cup (50 g) finely grated parmesan

1 tablespoon lemon juice

1 garlic clove, smashed

½ cup (125 ml) extra virgin olive oil

fine salt and freshly ground black pepper, to taste

Blend the beans, parmesan, lemon juice and garlic until smooth.
Add the oil in a slow stream while running the blender. Season well.

Beet, Almond, Horseradish

½ cup (80 g) smoked almonds

450 g (1 lb) tinned beetroot, drained

1 tablespoon horseradish cream

Blend the almonds until finely ground. Add the beets and horseradish. Blend until smooth.



The Bold and the Beautiful Saturday Salads

These salads are big and – dare I say – beefy (without the actual beef).

Hard-hitting flavour combos combine with texture melodies to make your mouth sing – all made with pretty, perky produce.

Easy weekend fare dressed with the perfect lick of sleazy dressing, these salads are perfect by themselves, or as part of a parade – fun, bright, delicious and hearty.

Salad rules:

Never pre-dress a leafy salad. Jar that sauce and dress onsite.

Make it pretty enough to eat. This seems obvious but apparently not.

Think about texture and the party your mouth is about to have.

Some dressings should separate so that you get hits of fat, acid, sugar and salt. Others should be so 'together' that they are a seamless beautiful blop of light texture and perfect flavour.



Potato Brilliance

Accessories are a spud's best friend.

The key to this salad not being a boring boggy basic is that aside from the super spritely ingredients and condiments, you bedazzle it with jewels and sequins, only mixing it at the last moment, if at all.

Serves: it should feed 8, but it's more like 4–6 for me

1.5 kg (3 lb 5 oz) salad potatoes, washed

$\frac{2}{3}$ cup (115 g) baby capers

vegetable oil, for shallow frying

$\frac{1}{4}$ cup (60 ml) aioli

4 young celery stalks with leaves, stalks shaved on a mandoline or very finely sliced, leaves picked

$\frac{1}{2}$ cup (80 g) cornichons, chopped

$\frac{1}{2}$ bunch finely snipped chives

1 lemon, zest finely grated, cut into wedges to serve

1 small salad onion, thinly sliced into rings

1 tablespoon coarsely chopped dill sprigs

extra virgin olive oil, for drizzling

fine salt and a heap of freshly ground black pepper, to taste

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

I hate to say it but speck bacon would really push this over the edge.

Cut the spuds into 1 cm ($\frac{1}{2}$ inch) uneven rounds with skins on. Some may even be wedges. This is fun, which is the order of the day on Saturday, so just do it.

In a large pot of salted water, boil the potatoes until just tender, about 17 minutes. You don't want them to break apart or peel so keep an eye on things. It may be 15 or even 20 minutes for you.

Drain the spuds and allow them to cool and dry.

Meanwhile, drain and pat dry the capers really well. In a small saucepan or frying pan, bring 2 cm ($\frac{3}{4}$ inch) of veg oil to 180°C (350°F) over high heat. Flash-fry the capers for no more than 1 minute so they blossom and become crispy – be careful not to burn them. Place on paper towel to drain.

Now we can layer.

Add about half the aioli to the base of a large serving platter – the aioli will be lifted up through the salad when you toss it.

Scatter the potatoes on the platter and top with celery stalks.

Sprinkle over the cornichons and fried capers, then top with celery leaves, chives, lemon zest, onion rings and dill sprigs.

Now make a little room on the side of the plate for the remaining aioli, and dollop it down.

Drizzle the whole thing with a lot of extra virgin olive oil, season well and add a few lemon wedges.

Toss at serving time to bring up the aioli.





Salad Bash

It's chunky, it's crisp, it's cold, it's salty, it's tangy.

This is one of my favourite salads to make because you get to be bashy.

Also, I get to use one of my favourite tools. My basher.

Dad made this out of a chair leg for me and it is weighted and proportioned so beautifully it makes my heart ache.

This whole salad should be snap cold. Assemble it all then put it in the fridge for an hour. (Hot bashed cucumber just doesn't land that well.)

Serves 4 as a side

1 tablespoon soy sauce

1 tablespoon sesame oil

1 tablespoon rice bran vinegar

2 teaspoons white (granulated) sugar

1 garlic clove, smashed

2 teaspoons finely grated ginger

1 spring onion (scallion), thinly sliced, white and green parts separated

5 stems coriander (cilantro), stems thinly sliced, leaves reserved

5 Lebanese (short) cucumbers, bashed into 3–4 cm (1¼–1½ inch) chunks

⅔ cup (100 g) thawed edamame (no shell)

300 g (10½ oz) silken tofu, cut into 1 cm (½ inch) cubes

1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil

½ teaspoon black sesame seeds

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

shichimi togarashi (Japanese chilli seasoning)

I like to start by dressing my empty salad bowl – a classic French move so that you pull the dressing up through delicate things rather than dumping it on top. It works well here.

The soy sauce, sesame, vinegar, sugar, garlic, ginger, spring onion (white parts only) and coriander stems all go into the salad bowl and are mixed with a fork. Just make sure everyone has been introduced then leave them to their own devices to mingle.

Bash and smash the cukes – or if you want to disobey, then at least cut them randomly enough to make them interesting. The bashing really opens up the taste of the cukes, though, and allows all the great dressing flavour in.

Scatter the cukes into the dressing.

Accessorise with edamame and tofu and top with the rest of the spring onion and the coriander leaves, then lash about the olive oil and sesame seeds as a final bedazzle.

See. Easy.

This would be killer to eat with dumplings ([here](#)) or S+P tofu ([here](#)), or even the crackling noodles ([here](#)). I'd show up to this scenario.





Nicy Cez

Part Niçoise, part Caesar.

This is a salty person Caesar salad. Which I think you should take as a compliment. Why wouldn't you want to be salty?

I accidentally made this GF and also low (maybe even zero) carb.

Serves 4 as a light lunch

1¼ cups (125 g) finely grated parmesan

1 head garlic, cut in half horizontally, skin on, drizzled with oil,
wrapped in foil and baked at 180°C (350°F) fan-forced for 30
minutes

4 cold eggs

1 cos lettuce

¼ cup (60 ml) extra virgin olive oil

1 tablespoon baby capers

250 g (9 oz) green beans*

1 tablespoon lemon juice

1 tablespoon mustard powder

2 tablespoons pitted kalamata olives, chopped

1 cup (235 g) mayo

1 tablespoon finely grated lemon zest

1 tablespoon finely snipped chives

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

baguettes

Preheat the oven to 180°C (350°F) fan-forced.

On a baking tray lined with baking paper, sprinkle 1 cup (100 g) of the parmesan cheese, spreading it evenly across the sheet.

Bake for 7 minutes, or until bubbling and golden. Allow it to cool and get crispy. You can do this ahead of time and store it in an airtight container in the pantry for up to 1 week.

You can also throw the garlic head in with this, then let it cool for later.

Jammy eggs are best for this salad, because jammy!

Use a pin to pierce the fatter end of each egg so they don't crack, then lower each cold egg slowly into boiling water with a slotted spoon. Boil for 6 minutes, then remove and peel under cool running water. Store the eggs bobbing in cool water until ready to use so they don't get flat edges. You can make and store these in water in the fridge the day before.

Trim the lettuce, wash it, and bathe it in a big icy bath for 10 minutes. Drain and store in the fridge until ready to use (this can also be prepped a few days ahead!).

Heat 1 tablespoon of the olive oil over medium–high heat in a frying pan and fry the capers until slightly crispy, around 3 minutes. Drain on paper towel.

Blanch the beans in VERY salty boiling water for 1 minute, then dunk them into icy water. The salt keeps them green; the ice stops them cooking. This is a rather more professional approach than my usual one, which involves dumping the hot water from the eggs on them.

To make the salty, umami rich dressing, place the lemon juice, roast garlic squeezed from the skin, remaining olive oil and parmesan, mustard powder, olives and half the mayo into a high- speed blender and process until smooth.

Loosely mix this with the remaining mayo.

Layer a serving platter with the crisp lettuce, beans, parmy cracker, torn jammy eggs, capers, lemon zest and chives, and serve the dressing alongside.

* I'm going to rebel against topping and tailing. Sometimes I kindly do this, other times I think 'F*ck that, I'm giving people cutlery AND they have teeth, they can deal with the stalks themselves.' Your call.





The Golden Crouton

Eat pretty, dress pretty, think pretty.

It is very dictator-y of me to have a GOLDEN crouton salad that requires yellow, orange and green produce, but honestly – the important thing is that the tomatoes are fresh, ripe and in season.

Also, what kind of maniac has a recipe asking for half a loaf of sourdough?

Hi.

I always seem to have half a stale loaf, but don't let me stop you from getting a fresh loaf.

If I get to it before it turns into a rock, I trim the crusts and tear it up and put it in the freezer. Sometimes I turn it into breadcrumbs. Or you can wash it and blast it in a hot oven for 10 minutes, or until it crisps back up.*

Serves 4–6

half a loaf of sourdough bread

6 tablespoons (120 ml) extra virgin olive oil

fine salt and freshly ground black pepper, to season

4 yellow/orange capsicums (peppers), cut in half, seeds and cores removed

2 brown onions, cut into wedges

2 garlic cloves, smashed with skins on

800 g (1 lb 12 oz) golden and green tomatoes (baby, small, medium and large)

¼ cup (7 g) loosely packed basil leaves

¼ cup (7 g) fresh oregano leaves

¼ cup (60 ml) red wine vinegar

1 large burrata

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

‘stale’ bread

Preheat the oven to 180°C (350°F) fan-forced. Line a baking tray with baking paper.

Tear the sourdough up into 3 cm (1 ¼ inch) chunks. In a bowl, toss the sourdough with 2 tablespoons of the olive oil and season with S+P. Place on the tray and bake until golden, about 6 minutes. Set the croutons aside.

Place the capsicums out-side down on the same baking tray. Place the onions and garlic around the capsicum. Drizzle with 1 tablespoon of the olive oil and sprinkle with some fine salt and freshly ground black pepper.

Bake for 20 minutes, until the edges have started to colour and everything has softened and become juicy. Remove and allow to cool.

Meanwhile, cut the tomatoes in a manner that suits them individually. Big ones thickly sliced, mediums cut into quarters, cherries halved and babies kept whole for pure mouth-bursting pleasure.

Cut the baked capsicums into quarters and squeeze the garlic out of its skin.

Pile the croutons, tomatoes, capsicum, garlic, onion and herbs on a big serving platter and drizzle with 3 tablespoons of the olive oil and the red wine vinegar. Toss it about with your hands (or those funny wooden salad hands if you prefer – tongs are a bit too rough).

Plonk a room-temp burrata somewhere on the salad, pour some ros   and crack into this salad with abandon.

* Inspired by panzanella, which uses stale bread soaked in salad juices, but in this recipe I toast the bread.





Sweet Remy Slaw

Ugly is in the eye of the beholder.

Celeriac is more glorious than potato when it comes to its Before and After story. Bulky, warty, tough and crusty turns into shredded, delicate, pale and tender. I'm not going to divulge which of these I find more attractive because it's personal, although I will say it's probably not what you think.

The remy – remoulade – is the dressing. It's quite traditional, but basically it's a tangy mustardy herby mayo. It often includes hot sauce, but I chose not to include that here.

Serves 4 as a side

DRESSING

**⅔ cup (165 g) mayonnaise
1½ tablespoons finely chopped cornichons
1 teaspoon capers, finely chopped
1 tablespoon lemon juice
1 tablespoon wholegrain mustard
2 teaspoons finely chopped flat-leaf parsley leaves
¼ teaspoon dried tarragon
sea salt flakes, to taste**

THE REST

**¼ green cabbage
2 tablespoons chervil
2 tablespoons honey**

2 cups (500 ml) warm water
1 celeriac
1 green apple
1 tablespoon finely snipped chives
freshly ground black pepper, to taste
extra virgin olive oil, for drizzling

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

roast tarragon and lemon chicken would be absurd with this

Make the remoulade by mixing all the dressing ingredients together well. Store in a jar in the fridge until needed (it will keep for 3 days).

Wash and shred the cabbage and store it in an airtight container lined with paper towel in the fridge.

Rinse and pick the chervil and make the same little paper towel bedding in an airtight container for storing in the fridge.

Stir the honey and warm water together in a bowl until the honey dissolves. Allow it to cool. **HOT TIP:** honey water works better than lemon for preventing browning! And when making something sweet, it's nice not to have too much residual tang.

Get a big mixing bowl ready with three-quarters of the remoulade in the base.

Peel and julienne the celeriac and apple as close to serving time as possible. Dunk them in the honey water for 30 seconds, then pop them straight into the dressing.

Top with the cabbage and toss well. I like to keep some cabbage undressed – it makes a nice contrast to have both fresh snappy and deliciously dripping salad.

Arrange on a platter – if you haven't noticed I am much more prone to using platters than bowls when serving (unless I'm trying to keep something warm or prevent liquid from going everywhere). LOUD AND PROUD.

Decorate with chives, chervil, a crash landing of freshly ground black pepper and a lick of extra virgin olive oil.





Noodle Nut Salad

My version of meditation.

There's a moment in your life when you become aware that you have repeated something so often with mild confidence and calm that you now slip into autopilot when faced with the task. Laundry. Critiquing. Astrology. For me, it's often dinner. This one sends me into a completely blissful trance.

Serves 6

200 g (4 oz) bean thread (glass) noodles

½ cup (15 g) coriander (cilantro) leaves

½ cup (15 g) shiso leaves

1 spring onion (scallion), green parts only, julienned – but I'll explain below

1 green papaya

2 carrots

3 Lebanese (short) cucumbers

1 zucchini (courgette)

¼ white cabbage or small wombok

1 cup (115 g) bean sprouts, hairy ends picked off

½ cup (75 g) salted peanuts, toasted and chopped

SAUCE

½ cup (125 ml) lime juice

½ cup (140 g) crunchy peanut butter

3 teaspoons sesame oil

¼ cup (125 ml) maple syrup

1½ tablespoons soy sauce

¼ cup (60 ml) hot water

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

chilli

Boil a jug of water.

Put the noodles in a heatproof bowl and cover with the boiling water. Leave them to cool. They should be soft and salad-perfect when done.

For the sauce, combine the lime juice, peanut butter, sesame oil, maple syrup and soy sauce in another bowl, then whisk everything together with the hot water.

Pick the coriander and shiso leaves and place in iced water to perk up.

Spring onions are fun to make all curly. The trick here is to cut the green bit into 7 cm (2¾ inch) lengths, then open the tube by cutting down one side. Place it flat on a board and thinly slice with the 'grain' as thin as you can. Place the strips in iced water and they will curl like crazy.

Shredding time.

Go slow, be meticulous, it will be far nicer to eat.*

The papaya will have green flesh and is great in this salad. Papaya has to be julienned fresh, but the carrots, cucumber, zucchini and cabbage can be done a day ahead. Just store them in the fridge in an airtight container lined with damp paper towel.

When you're ready to serve, place the spring onions and herbs on paper towel to dry off. Then, in a large bowl, style, plonk, twist, place and arrange the tendrils of drained noodles, papaya and veg. Top with the herbs, bean shoots, crunchy nuts and, of course, slaps of dressing.

* If it turns out you like this salad, I highly recommend investing in a julienne peeler.





Tofu Larb

Make this ahead, take it to a mate, take it to work.

Quite possibly one of my favourite things in this book. It's larb's time to shine. And shine it does.

It's GREAT.

Serves 2, or 4 in a banquet

2 tablespoons long-grain white rice
450 g (1 lb) firm tofu, drained
1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil
100 g (3½ oz) cherry tomatoes, quartered
1 red shallot, thinly sliced
1 baby cos lettuce, leaves trimmed and rinsed
1 Lebanese (short) cucumber, thinly sliced
1 cup (30 g) Thai basil leaves
1 cup (20 g) mint leaves

GARLIC PASTE

3 garlic cloves, coarsely chopped
1 lemongrass stem, white and green parts, chopped
5 cm (2 inch) knob of ginger, peeled and chopped
2 spring onions (scallions), white and green parts
2 tablespoons peanut oil

DRESSING

½ cup (125 ml) lime juice
2 teaspoons soft brown sugar

1 bird's eye chilli

2 teaspoons fine salt

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

steamed rice

In a large, dry non-stick frying pan (I say large because you'll use it for the tofu later), toast the rice over high heat, tossing regularly, until golden brown. It should take around 5 minutes. Don't let it burn. Set aside to cool, then grind to a fine powder in a mortar and pestle.

For the paste, use a food processor or stick blender to blitz the garlic, lemongrass, ginger and spring onions with the peanut oil until they form a smooth paste.

Break up the tofu with your fingers and mix it with the garlic paste.

Over high heat in the same pan you used for the rice, fry the tofu in olive oil until it is fragrant and golden, around 10 minutes. Set aside to cool to room temp.

For the dressing, in the same food processor you used for the garlic paste – no need to wash it out – purée the lime juice, brown sugar, chilli and salt.

Combine the tofu, tomatoes, shallot and dressing in a bowl and toss well.

Serve with lettuce, cucumber, herbs and a sprinkling of the toasted rice.





French Frills

Petit micro baby ingredients = fancy AF.

Filly skirts of lettuce, tight perky veg, young and flirty herbs, barely dressed in a warm sweet tangy lick of oil and vinegar.

Are you there yet? Me too.

The idea with this one is to use baby/young everything.

And the dressing should be just-above-room-temp warm.

It's fresh but works well with rich stuff (fennel ragu I'm thinking of you) and is so moreish you'll want bread for post-munch swiping.

Serves 4 as a side

2 shallots, thinly sliced

½ cup (125 ml) extra virgin olive oil

1 tablespoon red wine vinegar

1 teaspoon dijon mustard

½ teaspoon freshly ground black pepper

2 bunches asparagus, ends trimmed

250 g (9 oz) green beans*

1 cup (155 g) peas

1 butter lettuce

½ cup (25 g) micro herbs

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

French fries would be appropriate

Fry the shallots in the olive oil in a small saucepan over low heat for 5 minutes. Take the pan off the heat and whisk in the red wine vinegar and dijon to combine. Allow to cool. Season with freshly ground black pepper.

Place the asparagus, beans and peas in a heatproof bowl. Pour boiling water from the kettle over the veg. Let them sit for 2 minutes, then refresh the veg by plunging them into a bowl of icy water.

Separate the lettuce leaves and add to the icy water. When you're ready to serve the salad, dry the veg and leaves off by draining on paper towel.

Halve the asparagus lengthways.

Arrange the salad on a platter, drizzle with the dressing and top with some micro herbs.

* See my stance on topping and tailing [here](#).





Burrito Bowl

DIY fast food fix.

The inspo for this came from a dining establishment in the US – it's a chain, it's fast and, I won't lie, it's good.

Plus, carbs, protein, greens and flavour-loading are all a priority in our house. I'm partial to a bowl, my son is partial to a trough, my others are partial to scoop-feeding and DIYing condiments, so it hits all the right bones and buttons.

Serves 4

1½ cups (330 g) brown rice

1 tablespoon finely chopped coriander (cilantro) stems, plus ½ cup (15 g) leaves, for topping

1 teaspoon fine salt

100 ml (3½ fl oz) extra virgin olive oil

1 brown onion, finely diced

2 tablespoons Mexican Seasoning ([here](#))

3 garlic cloves, smashed

2 x 400 g (14 oz) tins black beans

½ cup (125 ml) vegetable stock

½ iceberg lettuce, shredded

1 cup (100 g) grated cheddar

½ cup (125 g) sour cream

SALSA ROSSO

4 tomatoes, coarsely chopped

¼ cup (60 ml) extra virgin olive oil
1 tablespoon finely grated lime zest
2 tablespoons lime juice
½ cup (15 g) coriander (cilantro) leaves and stems
1 teaspoon fine salt

GUAC

2 avocados, peeled and stones removed
2 tablespoons lime juice
1 tablespoon chopped spring onion (scallion)
½ teaspoon fine salt
2 teaspoons extra virgin olive oil

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

chilli powder and pickled jalapeños

To make the salsa and the guac, blend separately in a food processor, then store in airtight containers in the fridge; they'll both keep overnight. For the guac, press baking paper down onto the top to prevent it browning.

Cook the brown rice according to the packet directions. If there are none, rinse well, then simmer over low heat in 3 cups (750 ml) of water with the lid off until the rice has absorbed the water, around 15–20 minutes. Pop a lid on it, remove from the heat and set aside for 10 minutes to finish cooking. Stir through the coriander stems, salt and ¼ cup (60 ml) of the olive oil. This makes an irresistible snack and, honestly, it's how I fill up while making this. Carb and salt. Thanks.

Meanwhile, fry these delicious beans!

In a large frying pan over medium–high heat, sauté the onion in the remaining 2 tablespoons of olive oil until golden, around 5 minutes. Add the spice mix and the garlic and cook for a further 5 minutes, until really fragrant. Add the beans – including their juice! – and the stock and bring to simmering point. Reduce the heat to low and simmer for 10 minutes. It will thicken slightly, but this is a soupy bean mix, not dry.

Divide the rice, beans, lettuce, guac, salsa, cheese, sour cream and coriander leaves between individual serving bowls.

In my house things get optional after rice and beans, but that's the beauty of making your own bowl of stuff. You will like it.





Peach & Panda Salad

Does not contain panda.

Disclaimer. When my friend Rob told me he had a killer salad – Peach & Panda – I was sold.

It sounded delicious.

Then he corrected me: ‘No – labne, Lucy, labne.’

Hmm alright, I guess that’s OK.

I’ve adapted it slightly and added one of my fave things: quick preserved lemon. I urge you to use this on other occasions too, such as under grilled veg.

Serves 4

1 small lemon

1 teaspoon fine salt

1 teaspoon white (granulated)sugar

4 garlic cloves, peeled and crushed

1 cup (35 g) basil, leaves and tender stalks only

¼ cup (7 g) rosemary leaves or 1½ tablespoons dried rosemary

1 cup (250 ml) extra virgin olive oil

½ cup (150 g) labne (see the Beet Falafel recipe [here](#) to make your own)

2 cups (100 g) baby salad leaves

3 peaches

2 tablespoons red wine vinegar

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

fresh baguettes

Peel the lemon with a peeler (keep about 15 cm/6 inches of the peel). Hopefully the pith is thin; if not, trim as much off as possible. Then slice the lemon as finely as possible. Place the lemon on a platter in a single layer and sprinkle with salt and sugar. Set this aside for 30 minutes. It's a quick preserve.

In a small saucepan over low heat simmer the reserved lemon peel, the garlic, two-thirds of the basil (reserving some for garnish) and the rosemary in the olive oil for 20 minutes. You don't want it to bubble or sizzle, just extract flavour. Set aside to cool. It's a quick confit.

Assemble the salad by dolloping the lemons with labne.

Nestle baby salad leaves and the extra basil leaves everywhere and scatter with torn peaches.*

Dress liberally with the room-temp flavoured oil and the vinegar.

The lemons are tangy, sweet and sour, the leaves crisp and the labne creamy and fun.

A baguette is a worthy accessory to this one. Piling the fluffy bread with big wet mouthfuls is the ideal situation for this beautiful salad.

* The trick to tearing a peach is to half-cut and half-tear it when it has been pried away from the stone somewhat. Too much tear and the peach will be mush; too much cutting and it won't feel as rustic as you'd like. But sometimes cutting is the only option. Listen to your peach. It will tell you one way or another what it can do.





A Seriously Glistening Salad

Unbridled sparkly goodness.

This salad should be glistening and bright in colour. The bright orange and purple should stay separate from the dark little spots of lentils and the glossy ghostly white of the goat's curd. If you over-toss it before serving you will end up with a murky toned pink wash from the beetroot everywhere.

It's a wintry rainbow of caramelised roots, perfect on its own or with a side of heavily buttered baguette, tossed with spaghetti or atop buttery couscous.

Serves 4

1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil
⅓ cup (90 g) salted butter, melted
½ cup (125 ml) honey
600 g (1 lb 5 oz) small carrots (orange, purple, white), scrubbed well, leaves trimmed
½ bunch thyme sprigs
head of garlic, halved across its fat belly with the skin on
2 oranges
5–6 baby beets, scrubbed well, leaves removed
½ cup (125 ml) hot water
fine salt and freshly ground black pepper, to taste
400 g (14 oz) tinned baby lentils, rinsed and drained
⅓ cup (75 g) goat's curd
50 g (1¾ oz) rocket (arugula)

SALAD DRESSING

1 tablespoon dijon mustard

⅓ cup (80 ml) extra virgin olive oil

2 tablespoons orange juice (reserved from the salad)

1 tablespoon red wine vinegar

2 tablespoons snipped chives

fine salt and freshly ground black pepper, to taste

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

other carbs

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced. Lightly oil a 40 x 50 cm (16 x 20 inch) deep baking tray with the extra virgin olive oil.

Combine the butter and the honey in a small mixing bowl.

Cut the carrots in half lengthways – or leave whole if thin – and place on the oiled tray. Add the thyme and garlic. Remove the peel from one of the oranges in strips and add them to the tray. Pour the honey butter mixture over it all and toss well.

Cut the beets in sixths, place them on the tray and turn them over to coat.

Add ½ cup (125 ml) of hot water to the small mixing bowl you used for the honey butter and swirl it around to collect anything left in the bowl. Pour this over the veg.

Season well with a good crack of black pepper and a decent sprinkling of salt. Place the tray in the oven to roast for 20 minutes, or until caramelised.

Meanwhile, trim the remaining pith from the peeled orange and cut the flesh into segments. Juice the remaining orange and set the juice aside for the dressing.

Combine the dressing ingredients and season.

Remove the tray from the oven, add the lentils immediately, then allow it to cool slightly.

Before serving, top with the orange segments, crumbled goat's curd, a scrabble of rocket and the dressing.





Salads v. Sides

If a salad gets a sprinkle of something hot, does it immediately become a side? Well, no, not if it's big ... these salads are pretty, simple and delicious. Words to live by.

Serves 2–4

Asparagus, Parmy, Lemon, Crumb

- 2 bunches asparagus, ends trimmed
- 1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil
- 1 teaspoon fine salt
- ¼ cup (15 g) panko breadcrumbs or stale bread whizzed into crumbs
- 1 garlic clove, smashed
- 2 tablespoons finely grated parmesan

1 tablespoon finely grated lemon zest

Toss the asparagus in the olive oil and salt, then pan-fry over high heat in a medium frying pan (or on the grill/BBQ), tossing regularly until beginning to char, around 5 minutes.

Remove the asparagus and place on a serving plate.

Fry the breadcrumbs and garlic in the same frying pan on high heat until toasted, around 5 minutes.

Remove the pan from the heat and add the parmy and the zest. Mix well, then sprinkle it all over the asparagus and serve.

Radicchio, Blue Cheese, Walnut, Honey

2 cups (90 g) radicchio leaves, torn

60 g (2¼ oz) soft blue cheese, chopped

¼ cup (90 ml) honey

1 tablespoon rosemary leaves, bruised

2 tablespoons walnuts, coarsely chopped

1 tablespoon red wine vinegar

Arrange the radicchio and cheese on a platter.

In a small saucepan over medium heat, warm the honey, rosemary and walnuts until just simmering, around 2 minutes. Add the red wine vinegar and remove from the heat. Drizzle this over the blue cheese and radicchio while still hot.

Beans, Tomato, Feta

1 garlic clove, smashed

500 g (1 lb 2 oz) green beans, topped and tailed and cut in half

400 g (14 oz) tinned crushed tomatoes

½ tin (200 ml) of water

2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil

fine salt and freshly ground black pepper, to taste

50 g (1¾ oz) Greek-style feta, crumbled

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced. Combine all the ingredients except the feta in an ovenproof dish, taste and season. Toss well. Cover tightly with foil or a lid. Bake for 1½ hours. Allow to cool, then sprinkle with the feta. It's also delicious warm.



Sunday Oeufs

Forever known as the day after, the last day on earth, or the day before we begin again.

Is it the beginning of the week or the end?

Just like the answers to those perennial questions, 'Who is the richest person?' or 'Is chocolate actually nice?', it depends on your perspective. No one really knows.

One thing is for certain: exactly like soup, eggs have no hour or season ... they are anytime.



In Hell

One egg each + one for the pan, or the devil in this case.

Is it shakshuka-ish? Yes. Do I prefer the term 'In Hell'? Yes. Purely because it makes me feel like a badass.

Yes, shakshuka is a GREAT word. Loosely meaning 'all mixed up', it's a perfect start to any haphazard day.

I once made a dish with so much capsicum in it that I had a reaction to the capsaicin and ended up with those insanely irritating disco legs that make you want to kick around in your sleep all night. The traditional recipe calls for chilli peppers, cayenne and paprika, so I like to arm myself with sourdough on the side or, in this case, throw in some cooked potatoes to soak things up a bit.

It becomes a little like patatas bravas then, too. I like to fantasy continent-hop while at my kitchen bench, especially when I'm already on my way to Hell.

Serves 4

300 g (10½ oz) potatoes, sliced into chunky shards, skins on

3 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil

1 brown onion, thinly sliced

1 red capsicum (pepper), seeds removed and thinly sliced

3 garlic cloves, thinly sliced

2 whole dried red chillies

1 teaspoon chilli flakes

½ teaspoon turmeric
1 teaspoon paprika
1 teaspoon fine salt
1 teaspoon dried oregano
⅔ cup (170 ml) tinned crushed tomatoes
5 eggs
2 tablespoons aioli
1 tablespoon Chilli Crisp ([here](#))
1 lemon, cut into wedges

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

1 bird's eye chilli, sliced,
and finely chopped parsley

Boil the spuds in salted water until tender, 15 minutes, then drain.

In a large deep frying pan, heat 2 tablespoons of the olive oil over medium heat. Sauté the onion and capsicum for 5 minutes, until the onions are beginning to turn golden. Add the garlic and dried chillies and sauté for a further 2 minutes.

Add in all the remaining spices, salt and oregano and stir until it is well mixed.

Then toss in the potatoes and the remaining 1 tablespoon of olive oil and stir well. Combine the tomatoes and ⅔ cup (170 ml) of water and pour that in too. Simmer for 5 minutes, until it begins to reduce slightly.

Make some little wells with the back of a spoon for the eggs. You can evenly space them for serving or, if you're me, deliberately

cluster them together – because being the devil's advocate is par for the course in this one.

Crack in the eggs and reduce the heat to low. Do not stir once the eggs are in. Allow them to poach for 5–7 minutes, covering for the last 3 minutes.

Serve with aioli, Chilli Crisp oil and bird's eye chilli ... or don't. Definitely add the activity of lemon squeezing to the agenda.





In Heaven

A heavenly scenario that is only as pretty as it looks.

The calm, the coddled, the soft and the gentle. Quiet and creamy, eggs In Heaven are decadent and beautiful. Even more rewarding if you are able to wake at dawn, fresh from rest, pad out to the garden to harvest leaves straight from the rich soil, then skim the cream solids from the top of a wooden pail of thick cow's milk. Meander to the coop to collect the eggs from between warm straw and the fluffy underside of a fat hen, and casually return to the kitchen with the first rays of sunshine hitting your back just as the kettle begins to whistle.

In. Your. Blogging. Dreams.

In our house, this delightful little scenario is subbed out for things like a landmine Lego collection, conflict management (forget resolution), and a general blinking response to all the activity.

But get that pan to the table with a hopefully-still-warm cup of tea, and the escalator to Heaven will appear.

Serves 2

1 leek, white and pale green parts sliced into 5 mm (¼ inch) rounds
4 thyme sprigs
2 garlic cloves, thinly sliced
¼ cup (60 g) salted butter
1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil
1 cup (45 g) firmly packed spinach leaves

¾ cup (185 ml) thick (double) cream
½ cup (50 g) finely grated parmesan
1 tablespoon dijon mustard
¼ teaspoon ground nutmeg
fine salt and freshly ground black pepper, to taste
4 eggs

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

peace

Sweat the leeks with the thyme, garlic, butter and oil for about 10 minutes in a large frying pan with the lid on, over very low heat.

Add the spinach in an even layer on top, and cover the pan again for another 2 minutes, until it has wilted.

In a small bowl, combine the cream, parmesan, dijon and nutmeg and season well with S+P. Make four little egg wells in the spinach, then pour in the cream mixture.

Allow the cream to heat up to steaming, then crack the eggs into the wells.

Cover with a lid for 5 minutes, then remove the lid and continue to cook for a further 3 minutes, until the whites are cooked but the yolks are runny.

Season to taste, and serve with buttered toasted sourdough baguette (which you made fresh this morning at about 4 am, in a wood oven).





Cult Bowl

Mum used to say ‘eat the rainbow’ – she’d melt.

This recipe could be called Buddha Brunch, Rainbow Bright or Golden Sunshine – but cult seems more appropriate because I feel like we’ve all signed up for this situation at least once.

Whether it’s because of the probiotic kraut, the massaged kale, or the nuts, or just because it has the word ‘bowl’ in it as if that’s part of the actual ingredients, you just know it’s going to be a power packet of goodness.

Serves 4

½ butternut pumpkin (squash)

⅓ cup (80 ml) extra virgin olive oil

1 teaspoon fine salt

1 tablespoon shichimi togarashi (Japanese chilli seasoning)

1 bunch kale, tough ribs discarded, leaves and tender ribs coarsely chopped

2 tablespoons lemon juice

1 cup (200 g) quinoa

1 avocado

4 radishes

8 eggs

¼ cup (60 ml) white vinegar

2 cups (320 g) frozen edamame beans, thawed

1 cup cauliflower Curry Pickle from [here](#)

1 cup (250 g) sauerkraut (I used a red one because – rainbow)

4 tablespoons smoked almonds, coarsely chopped
½ cup mixed herbs – dill, flat-leaf parsley, coriander (cilantro), all
picked
1 nori sheet, finely sliced

DRESSING

½ garlic clove, smashed
1 tablespoon honey
1 tablespoon wholegrain mustard
1 tablespoon lemon juice
½ teaspoon fine salt
⅓ cup (80 ml) extra virgin olive oil

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

a cult – if you're unsure, call your dad

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced.

Peel and cube the pumpkin into 1 cm (½ inch) squares and toss in a large bowl with 2 tablespoons of the olive oil, the salt and the togarashi. Place on a baking tray and bake for 20 minutes, until caramelised. Set aside to cool and remember to be #grateful when you go to grab a snack and this is in the fridge.

Place the kale in a bowl, add the remaining olive oil and the lemon juice and massage the leaves until they relax. Yes. You have to do this. Set this aside also.

Cook the quinoa according to the packet directions. Allow it to cool.

Peel the avocado, remove the stone and quarter, then place in a bowl of icy water.

Shave the radish into the avocado bowl so it can curl and crisp up, then dry the wet veg on paper towel.

For the dressing, place the garlic, honey, mustard, lemon juice, salt and olive oil in a jar and shake it, or whisk together if you don't have a jar (note to self: start keeping jars).

Poaching eggs: don't be frightened, just be bold. In a deep non-stick saucepan, bring 4 cups (1 litre) of water and the vinegar to a steady simmer. Crack the eggs into a cup and plop them carefully in one at a time. Use a slotted spoon to gently nudge them away from the base of the pan to prevent them sticking. When the water comes back to a simmer, turn the heat down and allow the eggs to poach for 5 minutes. Remove with a slotted spoon.

Assembly of this is crucial: it's less about flavour (which is guaranteed) and more about aesthetics. And don't let ANYONE tell you it doesn't matter – eating with your eyes is an important part of the process, whether you're zen AF or completely superficial. It's called being present. Nestle each ingredient into small piles into the bowl, so you end up with a giant group hug – which in my opinion is the ONLY appropriate place for one.

This makes the most pretentiously fantastic desk lunch too: just swap out the poached egg for a freshly boiled soft egg (fridge to boiling water @ 6 minutes) and transfer in the shell to work.





Silky Folds Taco

Post-party peacekeeper.

If you have flatmates and you've been lazy about your share of shopping/cleaning/partying, etc., make this for them with a big pot of coffee/chocolate and almost all will be forgiven. I do it for my flatmates* occasionally, so I can vouch for this.

Serves 6 (makes 12)

2 cups (400 g) tinned corn kernels, drained
1 coriander (cilantro) stem, leaves picked and stems finely diced
2 spring onions (scallions), thinly sliced
⅓ cup (80 ml) extra virgin olive oil
10 eggs
2 tablespoons milk
1 avocado
1 lime
pinch of fine salt
1 tablespoon green habanero sauce (or any chilli sauce), or to taste
12 mini tortillas
1 cup (100 g) grated cheddar
2½ tablespoons salted butter
fine salt and freshly ground black pepper, to taste
30 g (1 oz) large leaf rocket (arugula)

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

extra chilli sauce

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced. Line a large baking tray with baking paper.

Fry the corn, coriander stems and spring onion in a large frying pan with 1 tablespoon of the olive oil over medium heat for 5 minutes. Set aside.

Meanwhile, crack the eggs into a bowl, add milk and whisk to combine. Set aside.

Remove the skin and stone from the avocado, finely dice the flesh and place into a bowl. Zest half the lime, juice the same half and add both to the avocado. Cut the remaining half of the lime into wedges and set aside. Season the avo and lime with a pinch of salt, then stir in 2 tablespoons of olive oil and the chilli sauce, to taste. Add the cooled corn to the avocado mixture and combine.

Lay the tortillas out on the tray and sprinkle the grated cheese on top. Place in the oven for 5 minutes, or until the cheese has melted.

Time to cook the eggs. I advise doing this in two batches, but if you can fit it all in one go, do it! Over medium heat in a large non-stick frying pan, add the butter and remaining olive oil. Once the butter is starting to sizzle, add the eggs and fold gently until just set, around 5 minutes.

Top the cheesy tortillas with some of the egg, then the corn and avocado salsa. Season with salt and freshly ground black pepper. Add the coriander leaves and rocket and serve with lime wedges.

* My flatmates are thankless jerks most of the time – they always want me to watch when they learn to do something new, but never pay attention to me for longer than a sentence.

Oddly though, I am so in love with them that I often dream about them, I buy them new undies, and I will query them when they demand money only sometimes.





French Rarebit

Just a cute girly brunch.

It's when French toast and Welsh rarebit become inseparable bffs: sourdough soaked in glorious egg and cream, topped with tangy kraut and Welsh rarebit, then grilled to bubbling perfection.

It's a brunch vibe (or linner), but make it tough and cool.

Serves 5–10 depending on how hardcore you are

4 eggs, plus four extra for fried eggs on top if you want to go
hardcore

2 cups (500 ml) single (pure) cream

2 teaspoons onion powder

2 teaspoons garlic powder

fine salt, to season

1 sourdough loaf (around 10 slices)

⅓ cup (90 g) salted butter

⅔ cup (100 g) plain (all-purpose) flour

6 teaspoons wholegrain mustard

4 teaspoons mustard powder

2 teaspoons cayenne pepper

1¾ cups (435 ml) ale, warmed and set aside

2 cups (200 g) grated cheddar

2 cups (200 g) grated gruyere

2 cups (500 g) sauerkraut or caramelised onions

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

eggs on top

Preheat the oven to 180°C (350°F) fan-forced. Line a baking tray with foil or baking paper.

Whisk the eggs, cream and onion and garlic powders in a dish or shallow bowl that will fit all the slices of bread. Season with salt. Place the bread into the dish and allow it to soak for 10–15 minutes each side.

Meanwhile, melt the butter* in a heavy-based medium saucepan over medium heat until it begins to foam. Add the flour, mustard and spices and stir well to form a paste. Add the warm ale in batches of ¼ cup (60 ml), stirring until smooth after each addition. Add the cheeses and stir until melted through, then set this rarebit mix aside to cool.

Place the soaked bread on the baking tray, carefully drizzling all the remaining eggy cream mixture over the slices to use it up. Bake in the oven until crisp, around 25 minutes. Remove the tray from the oven and preheat the grill/broiler.

Top each piece of bread with kraut or onions, then the rarebit mix, spreading it out as much as possible. Place the tray under a hot grill so that it can bubble and caramelise.

Now, if you want to be hardcore, fry a couple of runny sunny-side-up eggs and put them on top too.

Serve hot. Probably in this case with more beer, because when in Wales, Paris, Rome ...

* If you are cooking this book chapter by chapter then you will have made the Vegemite butter [here](#). This recipe is a GREAT use for any leftovers. Normal butter is fine, but if you need an excuse to make the Vegemite version then this is a good one.





Tommy Crumble & Mustard Scram

This whole thing just screams brunch.

I think ripe tomatoes are my weakness. I am addicted to them. I can have a shopping list with absolutely no mention of tomatoes, and then I will see one, or a punnet, and immediately my cooking plans change. An oxheart can overthrow an entire menu.

Serves 4

700 g (1 lb 9 oz) tomatoes, big and small, lovely and ripe

⅓ cup (80 ml) extra virgin olive oil

2 tablespoons red wine vinegar

2 small garlic cloves, crushed

1 teaspoon white (granulated) sugar

125 g (4½ oz) tomato passata (puréed tomatoes)

1 teaspoon sea salt flakes

CRUMBLE TOPPING

1 cup (70 g) torn stale bread (roughly 1 cm/½ inch chunks)

1 cup (100 g) grated cheddar

½ cup (75 g) plain (all-purpose) flour

1 tablespoon finely chopped thyme leaves

½ cup (120 g) cold salted butter, cubed

EGGS

9 eggs

¼ cup (60 ml) thick (double) cream, cold

1 tablespoon wholegrain mustard

2 tablespoons finely snipped chives

1 tablespoon salted butter

OPTIONAL

bellinis, obvs

Preheat the oven to 220°C (425°F) fan-forced.

Slice the big toms and chop the little ones in half. Place the sliced tomatoes evenly into the bottom of a 23 cm (9 inch) ovenproof dish or frying pan.

Toss the remaining toms in a bowl with the olive oil, red wine vinegar, garlic, sugar, passata and salt. Mix them well. Scatter these tomatoes on top of the sliced toms in the dish.

Place this in the oven to bake for 20 minutes, until bubbling and beginning to caramelise.

Meanwhile, make the crumble topping. Combine the bread, cheddar, flour and thyme in a bowl. Work the butter into the mixture by squishing it in with your fingers. When you get pea-size chunks, stop.

Remove the tomatoes from the oven and dollop the crumble mixture over the top unevenly, leaving a few gaps, then return the dish to the oven to continue cooking for a further 20 minutes, until the top is golden and crisp and the toms are beginning to bubble around the edge.

About 15 minutes before finishing, whisk together the eggs, cream, mustard and half the chives.

Heat the butter in a large non-stick frying pan over medium heat until it begins to foam, about 1 minute. Pour the egg mixture into the pan.

As the eggs begin to catch on the edges of the pan, gently pull them into the centre using a heatproof silicone spatula. Continue stirring the eggs until they have just set, about 5–7 minutes. Remove from the heat.

Top the eggs with the remaining chives and serve hot with the tomato crumble.





Crispy Edge

Appropriate 24/7.

Crispy, sticky, saucy, spicy, gooey, chewy.

This has all the elements of the ideal any-time-of-day meal.

It's a perfect bowl of things and should be made as a priority.

It does involve a spitting oil situation, so don't be brazen or slack about the egg bit.

Serves 2

½ cup (125 ml) vegetable oil

4 garlic cloves, thinly sliced

1 bunch water spinach,* cut into 10 cm (4 inch) pieces, leaves and stems separated

½ teaspoon soft brown sugar

4 spring onions (scallions), thinly sliced, white and green parts separate

2 teaspoons sesame oil

1 teaspoon mushroom oyster sauce

4 eggs

2 cups (370 g) steamed white rice

½ teaspoon finely grated ginger

1 bird's eye chilli, thinly sliced

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

doubanjiang chilli paste

Heat 1 tablespoon of the vegetable oil in a non-stick wok over high heat, then add the garlic and cook, stirring, until golden, 1 minute. Add the stems of the water spinach with the brown sugar and the whites of the spring onion. After 1 minute, add the leafy ends of the spinach and the sesame oil and toss well. Stir in the mushroom oyster sauce and 1 tablespoon of water. Cover to steam for 2 minutes, then toss well and set aside. Keep warm.

Wipe out the wok with some paper towel. Place a large plate at the ready on your benchtop.

Heat the remaining oil over high heat until hot. Add the eggs one at a time, keeping separate if possible. Allow the eggs to fry for 2 minutes, or until the edges are crisping. Remove the eggs and pop them on the plate while you carefully pour out all but 1 tablespoon of oil. Place the eggs back in the wok to continue cooking for 1 minute more, until the whites are cooked and the centres are still runny.

To serve, fill the individual bowls with rice, then add the eggs and water spinach mixture. Top with the ginger, chilli and the remaining spring onion. Add a drizzle of the water spinach sauce.

* Water spinach chit chat: you can swap this out for any deep green stalky side: bok choy, broccolini, English spinach, Chinese broccoli (gai lan) or silverbeet. I lunged at the opportunity to cook water spinach when I saw it available, and quite possibly this entire recipe owes its existence to it. It's fun and vibrant and the stalks are tubular, meaning they fill with flavour. I love the crunch of this veg.





Chilaquiles

Real talk: I'm really not that much of a frittata person.

This is as close as I'll happily get to a frittata – I don't really like brown burnt eggs (she says, a page after telling you to crispy fry them). It begins with the concept of a frittata but delivers a texture combo of crispy corn chip and soft creamy eggs that is just perfect.

This dish makes me happy. Maybe it's because my sister made it for me one morning in LA after I hadn't seen her for too long. Maybe it's because it's so good.

Serves 4

8 eggs

¼ cup (60 ml) milk

1 tablespoon salted butter

2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil

1 white onion, finely chopped

1 tablespoon finely chopped coriander (cilantro) stems, leaves reserved

1 green capsicum (pepper), finely diced

2 garlic cloves, finely chopped

1 teaspoon garlic powder

1 teaspoon onion powder

1 cup (30 g) corn chips

½ cup (50 g) grated cheddar

½ cup (65 g) grated mozzarella

½ cup (30 g) grated smoked cheddar
1 avocado, peeled and stone removed, sliced
2 radishes, cut into matchsticks
¼ teaspoon smoked paprika or cayenne pepper
1 tablespoon jalapeño sauce (or mole)

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

a sister in LA, though it helps

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced.

Whisk the eggs in a lazy fashion in a bowl with the milk.

Melt the butter and olive oil in a large ovenproof frying pan over medium heat until foaming. Add the onion, coriander stems and capsicum and sauté for 3 minutes, until soft. Add the garlic, garlic powder and onion powder and cook for a further 4 minutes.

Pour in the eggs and allow the edges to bubble and begin to set for 1 minute.

Place the pan in the oven for 5 minutes, then remove it to add the corn chips and cheese. Sprinkle the cheeses above and below the corn chips. (Cheese layering – like on pizza – is not a blank-faced dump and run. You need to poke things under and out. Cheese needs to be able to flow and follow its natural stream-like journey.)

Place the pan back in the oven for 5–10 minutes, until the cheese has melted and is bubbling – keep an eye on it so the chips don't burn.

Decorate this protein pancake with the avo, snappy radish, coriander leaves, a shadow of paprika and a dribble of jalapeño

sauce.

2, 4, 6, 8 ... you know the drill.





Eggs Niçoise Breakfast Salad

You could be drinking tea or pinot gris – your call.

If you've ever been confused by the dress code 'smart casual', imagine eating this on a sunny vine-adorned balcony overlooking some kind of vista/plain/ocean. There could be a sweater over the shoulders. It's that vibe. I've also eaten this in a tracksuit and it's been brilliant – so just use it as inspiration, not a demand.

Serves 4 snappy customers

500 g (1 lb 2 oz) baby white potatoes, quartered

200 g (7 oz) green beans, tops removed

1 fennel bulb

1 red onion

6 radishes

1 cos lettuce

1 head garlic, cut in half horizontally with skin left on, cut edges
drizzled with olive oil, plus 4 extra garlic cloves, smashed

¼ cup (60 g) salted butter

100 ml (3½ fl oz) extra virgin olive oil

1 small sourdough loaf

6 cold eggs

¼ cup (40 g) cornichons, chopped

1 tablespoon baby capers

¼ cup (40 g) pitted kalamata olives, sliced

1 teaspoon finely chopped oregano leaves

1½ tablespoons chopped dill sprigs

1 tablespoon basil leaves
1 tablespoon finely snipped chives
2 teaspoons lemon juice
1 tablespoon mayonnaise
1 oxheart tomato, thickly sliced

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

nothing – it's complete

Preheat the oven to 170°C (325°F) fan-forced.

Simmer the spuds in a large saucepan of salted water for 13 minutes, until tender, then add the beans and simmer for 2 minutes more. Drain and set aside to cool.

Meanwhile, trim and shave the fennel, red onion and radishes and place in icy water. They will repay you by being vibrant and bouncy when you serve them. Trim the lettuce and pop the leaves in icy water too.

Join the cut halves of the garlic back together and wrap in foil. Place in the oven and roast for 15 minutes, until soft. Cool, then squeeze the cloves from the skins.

In a small saucepan over medium heat, heat the butter with 2 tablespoons of the olive oil and the remaining 4 garlic cloves for 2 minutes, until bubbling. Set aside.

Line a tray with foil and then baking paper. Slice the bread into eight slices – but don't go all the way through. Place the loaf on the tray and brush or pour the garlic butter between the slices as much as possible. Wrap tightly in the foil and pop in the oven for 20 minutes.

When the garlic bread is done, remove it from the oven but keep it warm. (If you prefer crispier garlic bread, open the top after 20 minutes and allow it to cook for a further 10 minutes.)

Bring enough water to the boil in a saucepan to submerge 6 eggs. Use a pin to pierce the fatter end of each egg, then lower them into the water slowly so they don't crack. Boil for 6 minutes for jammy eggs.* Peel under cold running water and place in a bowl of cold water until ready to serve.

In a small bowl, combine 1 tablespoon of the olive oil, the cornichons, capers, olives, oregano and 2 teaspoons of the dill. Set aside.

In a small blender, process the roasted garlic with the remaining dill, remaining olive oil, basil, chives, lemon juice and mayonnaise until green and vibrant.

Layer and stack the tomato, beans, leaves, curly bouncy veg (dried on paper towel) and potatoes. Throw on a few spoonfuls of the olive mix and a dollop of green mayo.

Serve with hot garlic bread and a penchant for good times.

* Due to altitude this may not be the correct timing for jammy eggs in the south of France!





Green Eggs & Jam Tart

An all-in-one, crispy-edged condiment carrier.

A picnic crowd-pleaser.

You can swap out the cav nero for any other dark leafy green, and mix up the jam too – I have used store-bought onion jam, but tomato or chilli would be equally delicious.

The faint sweetness of the onion jam is perfect with creamy cheesy eggs swirled with vibrant green pesto and robust foliage.

This can be dinner, lunch or breakfast, easily eaten by fork or by hand.

Serves 4

2 sheets ready-made frozen shortcrust pastry

150 g (5½ oz) cavolo nero (tuscan kale)

2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil, plus more for brushing

1 garlic clove, crushed

¼ cup (60 ml) onion jam

8 eggs

1 tablespoon thick (double) cream

1 cup (100 g) grated cheddar

fine salt and freshly ground black pepper

2 tablespoons Scrap Pesto from [here](#)

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

a quick zest of lemon would be great

Thaw the shortcrust.

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced.

Rinse the leafy greens and shake them dry. Trim any tough ribs off the leaves. Younger tender ribs can be left whole, or just trim the base if it is a more tender bunch.

In a large non-stick frying pan, heat 2 tablespoons of olive oil over high heat. Add the garlic and cavolo nero and stir-fry for 1–2 minutes, until the greens have only just begun to char and wilt. Remove from the heat and set aside.

Line a baking dish with baking paper – I have used an oval dish 20 x 35 cm (8 x 14 inches).

Place the two sheets of shortcrust pastry into the dish, overlapping at the centre.

Use your fingers to press the pastry together and seal it along the join.

Spread the onion jam onto the pastry and then top with the wilted garlicky greens.

In a bowl, whisk together the eggs and cream until well combined. Add the cheese and season well.

Pour this mixture on top of the greens. Dot small amounts of pesto onto the egg mixture, then swirl it about gently with the back of a spoon.

Fold and tuck the excess pastry edges around the egg mixture, then brush with the extra olive oil.

Place into the oven to bake for 20 minutes, or until the centre is just set.





Hash & Egg Muffins

Good and greasy washed down with black coffee.

There's nothing wrong with food from fast food chains – especially the homemade version, with better ingredients and a much slower, more pain-in-the-ass process than driving through. I worked at one once. There were a few free upsizes for mates. While I was never provided with a fitting uniform, I stayed long enough to garner some hilarious stories, glean some food science insights and swish the special sauce enough times like a sommelier to grab the tasting notes ... for this very day!

Serves 4

4 eggs

4 English muffins

4 slices American cheese

SAUCE

¾ cup (185 g) mayo

¼ cup (65 g) gherkin relish

1½ teaspoons onion powder

1½ teaspoons garlic powder

½ teaspoon cayenne pepper

4 teaspoons American mustard

2 teaspoons white wine vinegar

HASH

800 g (1 lb 12 oz) potatoes

2 eggs, lightly whisked
2 tablespoons cornflour (cornstarch)
1 teaspoon garlic powder
1 teaspoon paprika
1 teaspoon fine salt
½ cup (125 ml) canola oil

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

instant coffee, but the good kind

Combine all the sauce stuff together. I know ... that's it. I could fluff it out with 'in a bowl' and 'with a spoon' and 'store in a blah blah' – actually, just store in a jar in the fridge for a week. But that's it. Mix. Store. Brains.

For the hash, peel and grate the potatoes, place in a clean tea towel and squeeze out the excess moisture. Then, in a large bowl, combine the spud with the eggs, cornflour, garlic powder, paprika and salt.

Divide into eight portions and shape each into a 10–12 cm (4–4½ inch) round, 1 cm (½ inch) thick. Place them on a tray lined with baking paper and freeze for 20 minutes.

Heat the canola oil in a large frying pan over medium heat, then add the hash in batches and fry for 5 minutes, turning once, until golden on both sides.

Set them aside in a warm place (a commercial hotbox would be ideal).

Lightly grease a large non-stick frying pan and heat over medium heat. Add the eggs one at a time using a greased fancy egg ring for full fast-food immersion (or hack that by using the largest ring of a slice of onion that is cut at least 1 cm/½ inch wide). Cover with a lid and cook until the entire egg is just set. You can do a runny yolk here of course if you wish, it's your T-shirt.

Meanwhile, split and lightly toast the muffins under the grill until lightly golden.

Spread the heel (this is what the fast-food industry calls the bun bum – you're welcome) with sauce. Top with a hash, a slice of cheese, then an egg. Whack the lid on.

I like to wrap mine, take it to the car and drive around the block while eating it for full effect.

Drinks pairing: pulpless orange juice watered down to about two-thirds and consumed out of a paper cup that has a really faint aroma of detergent.





Vietnamese Pancakes (Bánh Xèo)

Flex those wrist muscles, friends.

Another activity piece. Pick a bit of this, chopstick in some of that, grab a few of those, wrap in a leaf, munch. And it's the perfect user-upper of stuff in the fridge: old roast veg, floppy things, or pantry bits like tinned corn.

It's a really fun thing to make for dinner (and doubles as a brunch scenario). You could definitely add chopped jammy eggs and hit people with an iced coffee made with sweetened condensed milk.

I mean, I'd come back, even if you didn't want me to.

Makes 8

2 cups (320 g) rice flour

½ cup (125 ml) coconut cream

1 egg

2 teaspoons turmeric powder

1¼ tablespoons peanut oil

pinch of fine salt

1 cup (20 g) Vietnamese mint leaves

1 cup (20 g) mint leaves

1 cup (20 g) shiso leaves

1 coral lettuce, leaves picked

½ onion, cut into thin rings

¼ pumpkin (squash), peeled and seeds removed, cut into 2 cm (¾ inch) cubes, roasted at 220°C (425°F) fan-forced on a greased

baking tray for 20 minutes
1 cup (115 g) bean sprouts
2 cups (200 g) tinned corn kernels, drained
Basic Pickle, from [here](#)
chilli sauce, to serve
mushroom oyster sauce, to serve
1 lime, cut into eight thin wedges

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

jammy eggs, and iced coffee made with sweetened condensed milk

In a large bowl, combine the rice flour, coconut cream, egg, turmeric powder, 1 tablespoon of the peanut oil, a big pinch of salt and 2½ cups (580 ml) of water. Whisk well, then allow to rest for 30 minutes.

Pick all the herbs and lettuce leaves and let them get super perky by popping them in an ice bath with plenty of water. They need about 15–20 minutes here. Place them on paper towel to dry off a bit before serving.

Pancake-making of any variety is a committed event. This one is no different.

Arrange all the fillings in little vessels near the stove at the ready. This is a game called ‘ultimate mise en place’ and it will change the way you cook.

Heat the remaining 1 teaspoon of peanut oil in a large non-stick frying pan over high heat and add ⅓ cup (80 ml) of pancake batter. Immediately swirl the pan – applying serious wrist-twirling skills – to

stretch the pancake out across the surface. Thin and crispy is what you're aiming for, but a little chunk won't hurt anyone.

While the batter is still wet, add the toppings: raw onion slices, roast pumpkin, bean sprouts and corn – a sprinkle (2 tablespoons) of each.

While the first pancake is cooking, stir the batter in the bowl so it stays thoroughly mixed. The pancake will take around 6 minutes to crisp and brown. Lift one edge to check the doneness and if it looks great then fold it in half and slide it onto a plate.

Onto the next pancake!

Serve with lettuce, herbs, pickles and condiments like chilli sauce and mushroom oyster sauce. Pickle juice is also a great tangy addition, along with a little wedge of lime.





Anytime Eggs

Egg talk.

I use eggs from the fridge. Before boiling, use a pin and pierce the fatter end of each egg, then lower the eggs into the water slowly so they don't crack. Boil for the designated time. If you are peeling, do so under cool running water as it helps lift the membrane and the shell. If you are making ahead and want lovely, round, not flat-sided eggs, then place them in a container of water to bob about in the fridge.

Each recipe serves 2.

Grated Hard Egg Salad

1 tablespoon softened salted butter
4 slices sourdough bread, toasted

2 tablespoons goat's curd
¼ cup (35 g) frozen baby peas, thawed
¼ cup (5 g) mint leaves, chopped
2 teaspoons extra virgin olive oil
2 x 12-minute eggs
1 tablespoon finely grated lemon zest
1 tablespoon mayo
sea salt flakes and freshly ground black pepper, to taste

Apply the butter to the toast. Top this with swipes of goat's curd.

In a small bowl, crush the peas with a fork and mix in the mint and oil to combine.

Spoon this over the goat's curd.

Exciting bit: peel the hard-boiled eggs and grate them on top of each piece of toast from dizzying heights, fluffy and powder-like. Zest the lemon over the eggs.

Drizzle with mayo and add loads of sea salt and freshly ground black pepper.

Asparagus with Curried Gribiche

4 x 8-minute eggs
1 tablespoon capers, coarsely chopped
½ shallot, minced
4 cornichons, coarsely chopped
1 tablespoon dill, coarsely chopped
1 tablespoon flat-leaf parsley leaves, coarsely chopped

1 teaspoon dijon mustard
1 tablespoon lemon juice
1 tablespoon finely grated lemon zest
1 tablespoon white wine vinegar
1 teaspoon curry powder
sea salt flakes and freshly ground black pepper, to taste
1 bunch of asparagus, ends trimmed, blanched and finely chopped
1 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil, plus extra for drizzling
4 slices Polish rye, toasted and buttered
2 tablespoons chervil leaves, chopped

Peel and roughly chop the eggs and place in a bowl. Add the capers, shallot, cornichons, herbs, mustard, lemon juice, zest, vinegar and curry powder. Mix well to combine. Season the gribiche well with sea salt flakes and freshly ground black pepper.

Toss the cooled asparagus with the gribiche and olive oil, then spoon it liberally on top of the buttered toast. Top with chervil and drizzle with extra olive oil.

Angry Eggs 'n' Greasy Bouncers

1 teaspoon sea salt flakes
¼ teaspoon garlic powder
¼ teaspoon cayenne pepper
4 slices white bread
30 g (1 oz) cheddar, grated or cut into four slices
3 tablespoons butter, melted
4 x 6-minute eggs

Combine the salt, garlic powder and cayenne in a small bowl. Set aside.

Top two slices of bread with half the cheese each. Top with the remaining bread slices and brush the tops with half the butter.

Heat a large non-stick frying pan over medium heat and add the sandwiches. Fry for 2 minutes, until golden underneath. Brush the tops with the remaining melted butter. Flip the sandwiches and fry the other sides for 2 minutes, until golden.

Remove the crusts from two sides of each sandwich and then divide into three fat soldiers.

Crack the tops off the eggs and sprinkle them with the spicy salt mix.

Eat immediately.



Sweet Anytime Treats

Here's the thing. I am always quite happy to skip dessert when dining out. I am savoury, salty, saucy, spicy, tangy, umami and hot by nature.

I'll share a crème brûlée or have a bite of gelato, but it's more a full stop than a 'course' for me.

However, when my publisher (who gleefully hosts an annual bake-off at the office) asked for more sweets, I strode towards the challenge with the confidence of a fully made-up drag queen. It was subtle, but the tinge of 'dare' within the request was irresistible.

Most of these recipes have childhood memories attached to them because that's the period in which I fancied sugar the most.

So, I present you with an extra day of sugar and spice and all things nice.

Hope you enjoy it.



Lemon Poppyseed Meringue Cake

This is the serious end of the book, OK.

Poppyseeds are one of the most irritating things to clean up when spilled – it's like they're mildly magnetised and dart around for no apparent reason. Keep a steady hand for this.

Serves 10–12

3 cups (450 g) plain (all-purpose) flour
1 teaspoon baking powder
½ teaspoon bicarbonate (baking) soda
½ teaspoon fine salt
2 tablespoons poppyseeds
1 cup (250 ml) buttermilk, at room temperature
2 tablespoons finely grated lemon zest
2 tablespoons lemon juice
1 cup (250 g) cold salted butter, cubed
2 cups (440 g) caster (superfine) sugar
1 teaspoon vanilla bean paste
3 eggs, at room temperature

MERINGUE TOP

3 egg whites, at room temperature
⅔ cup (150 g) caster (superfine) sugar
1 teaspoon cream of tartar

FILLING

1 cup (230 g) cream cheese, at room temperature

1 cup (120 g) icing (confectioners') sugar, plus extra for dusting
1 tablespoon single (pure) cream
½ cup (125 ml) lemon curd

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

fear

Preheat the oven to 160°C (315°F) fan-forced. Grease and line two 22 cm (8½ inch) springform cake tins with baking paper.

In a large bowl, whisk together the flour, baking powder, bicarb, salt and poppyseeds until well mixed. Set aside. Combine the buttermilk, lemon zest and juice in a separate bowl and set aside.

In a standmixer fitted with the paddle attachment, cream the butter, sugar and vanilla on low for 8 minutes, until pale and creamy. The cold cubed butter gives the sugar longer to dissolve as it is beaten, leaving the texture of the creamed butter quite smooth.

Add the eggs, one at a time, beating well after each addition.

With the speed on low, add a quarter of the flour mixture, then a third of the buttermilk mixture. Repeat this process, mixing well after each addition, finishing with the flour.

Pour half of the batter into each of the tins. Place ONE cake into the oven and cook for 40 minutes (set the other tin of batter aside for now). Test for doneness – a skewer poked into the cake should come out clean. Allow this base cake to cool completely in the tin before turning out.*

Meanwhile, make the meringue top. Wash the bowl of the standmixer, then wipe with paper towel soaked in vinegar to

remove any residual fat (which will sabotage the meringue).

Use the whisk attachment to whisk the egg whites on high until white and foamy, around 5 minutes. Lower the speed to medium-high and, with the motor running, add 1 tablespoon of sugar at a time until it is all used up and the whites are stiff and glossy, around 7 minutes. Add the cream of tartar and whisk until just combined.

Top the reserved tin of batter with swirls of meringue and bake for 1 hour. Check at 30 minutes, and loosely cover with foil if the peaks are beginning to brown too much. Test for doneness, then remove and set aside to cool.

Beat the cream cheese, icing sugar and cream until smooth, around 5 minutes on high. Set aside a quarter of this icing and a quarter of the lemon curd for the topping.

Place the cooled base cake on a plate and evenly spread the remaining icing and lemon curd over. Carefully place the meringue-crowned cake on top. Artfully dollop on the reserved icing and curd, and dust with icing sugar.

* If you like, level the base cake by trimming off the domed top to create an even flat surface for layering with filling.





Sticky Date Brioche

To consume, wear woolly socks and have a crackling fire in the vicinity.

This is the ultimate weekend away dessert for a dozen (16 actually). It has après ski vibes, or in my case, avant, durant AND après.

You could halve this recipe if you weren't needing AS much but let me warn you – it reheats embarrassingly well and is a viable breakfast.

Serves 16

½ cup (125 ml) whisky

12 medjool dates, seeds removed and finely chopped

3 teaspoons instant yeast

4 cups (600 g) plain (all-purpose) flour, plus extra for dusting the cake tin

1 cup (250 ml) lukewarm milk

⅓ cup (90 g) softened salted butter, cubed

½ cup (110 g) firmly packed soft brown sugar

1 teaspoon fine salt

4 egg yolks

2 tablespoons (30 g) melted salted butter, plus extra for greasing the cake tin

1 egg, whisked, for glazing

BUTTERSCOTCH SAUCE

⅓ cup (90 g) salted butter

1½ cups (330 g) firmly packed soft brown sugar

1 cup (250 ml) single (pouring) cream

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

ice cream

Heat the whisky and the dates in a small saucepan with the lid on over medium heat until steaming, then set aside to cool.

In the bowl of a standmixer fitted with the dough hook combine the yeast and flour. With the mixer on low, slowly pour in the lukewarm milk until it's all combined. Next, add the softened butter a little at a time until incorporated into the dough. Add the sugar, salt, whisky and dates, then the egg yolks, one at a time, mixing well after each addition. Continue to mix on low until the texture is smooth and stretchy, around 8 minutes.

Cover the dough with plastic wrap and leave to rise for 2 hours in a warm place; it should double in size.

Grease a 24 x 38 cm (9½ x 15 inch) oval cake tin, 4 cm (1½ inches) deep, with butter and dust with some flour, tapping out any excess.

Knead the dough again for a few minutes then divide it into 16 portions. Roll each portion into a ball and place in the cake tin. Brush each ball generously with melted butter.

Cover with plastic wrap and let the dough rise again for 30 minutes.

Preheat the oven to 180°C (350°F) fan-forced.

After the dough has risen again, press your fingertips into it to create cavities and allow the melted butter to sink in.

Brush the balls of dough with the whisked egg and bake for 30–40 minutes, or until the brioche is golden brown.

When the brioche is almost cooked, make the butterscotch sauce. Place the butter and sugar in a medium saucepan over high heat and stir until melted and paste-like. Gradually add the cream, stirring to combine. Bring to the boil and cook for 6–8 minutes, or until thickened slightly.

While the brioche is still hot, cut it into 16 pieces in the tin.

Slowly pour half the hot butterscotch sauce over the brioche, letting it soak into the cuts.

Place the remaining sauce in a jug to serve alongside the brioche. Ice cream encouraged.





Miso Pine Lime Tarte Tatin

Careening down memory lane with this one.

The pine-lime flavour combo always reminds me of my dad and holidays on the Central Coast of NSW as a kid. Between sunburns, he'd blare Tone Loc and swerve the car up and down the empty cul de sac, us kids squealing in delight while rolling around in the back seat.

It was the 80s. Life was punky, cool and fun (and possibly rather damaging, but that's a conversation for a therapist). Pine lime Splice ice creams were the sweet treats we licked between bouts of misadventure.

Bringing us skidding into the 2020s is the addition of miso, and I, for one, am glad we made it.

Serves 6–8

⅓ cup (90 g) cold salted butter, cubed

¾ cup (165 g) firmly packed soft brown sugar

2 tablespoons lime juice, plus 1 tablespoon finely grated zest

1 tablespoon white miso

1 kg pineapple, sliced into circles 5 mm (¼ inch) thick, then peeled and cored*

½ cup (60 g) toasted macadamias, coarsely chopped

2 square sheets ready-made frozen puff pastry

½ cup (130 g) coconut yoghurt

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

tinned pineapple – you could certainly give this recipe a whack with tinned instead of fresh

In a large (25 cm/10 inch) non-stick ovenproof frying pan over medium heat, melt the butter, sugar, lime juice and miso and bring to a simmer. Add the pineapple in batches and simmer, turning once, until tender (this should take 2–3 minutes in total). Set the slices aside on a tray lined with baking paper and allow to cool. Reserve the syrup.

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced.

Place half of the macadamia nuts in the same ovenproof frying pan, then top with the pineapple rings, overlapping. Pour half the reserved syrup on top, then cover the fruit with both sheets of puff pastry, tucking it in at the sides. Bake until puffed and golden, around 25 minutes.

Use oven mitts or some handy tea towels to flip the hot frying pan onto a serving plate (this can be deftly done by lining up the pan and the plate, grabbing and flipping). Beware: you are playing with hot toffee.

Top with the remaining macadamia nuts and the lime zest. Serve warm with the extra syrup and coconut yoghurt.

* Usually one would peel, slice, then core a pineapple. However, because of this brilliant cookie-cutter hack, it's slice first, then peel and core – resulting in machine-perfect rings. It means you need to locate a set of round cutters – although rustically sliced pineapple would be lovely too.





Mum's Rockmelon Ice

It's the food version of having diamonds on the soles of your shoes.

This one is a reincarnation of my mum's favourite icy delight. Fresh and spritely, it is perfect as is but equally delicious on ice cream or plopped into a glass with some vodka and prosecco for a summer spritz.

Serves 16 as a little ice cup

750 g (1 lb 10 oz) rockmelon (cantaloupe), peeled, deseeded and roughly chopped

1 cup (220 g) caster (superfine) sugar

1¼ cups (310 ml) fresh pink grapefruit juice

1 punnet (125 g) raspberries, frozen*

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

prosecco

Start off by blitzing the rockmelon in a food processor, then strain the purée through a sieve. You should end up with 2 cups (500 ml) of juice.

Dissolve the sugar in the grapefruit juice in a medium saucepan over medium–high heat for 4 minutes. Simmer for 3 minutes to thicken the syrup slightly, then cover and set aside to cool.

Add the rockmelon juice to the cooled syrup and stir to combine.

Pour the mixture into a 20 x 32 cm (8 x 12½ inch) cake tin, 3 cm (1¼ inches) deep.

Cover with foil and place in the freezer overnight.

Use a fork to roughly break and mush up the frozen mixture.

Serve with frozen raspberries.

* Use a punnet of fresh raspberries that you have frozen, not the store-bought frozen ones that get mauled and mushed in the packaging process. Freezing your own fresh berries means they are glistening jubes of perfection. And you'll be able to try them before freezing to make sure they are super sweet.





Berry-Mallow Shortcake

Shortcake. Literally a cake that is short.

I am in neither NWA nor that harder, tougher crowd, CWA, but making this cake makes me feel a bit puffy about myself.

Not only does the 1:1:1:1 mix situation calm me down, but the outcome is pretty spesh.

Now, hold onto your pretty pants, it is/was vegan ... until the marshmallows. But, quite frankly, you could make it without these and I would still love it.

The texture is fluffy, sweet and chewy, like a giant coconut macaroon – not to be confused with a macaron.

Serves 6–8

CAKE BATTER

1 cup (90 g) desiccated coconut, plus a little extra for sprinkling
1 cup (220 g) caster (superfine) sugar
1 cup (250 ml) tinned coconut milk
1 cup (150 g) self-raising flour, sifted

STRAWBERRY TOPPING

9 x strawberries, halved lengthways
7 x pink marshmallows, halved
1 tablespoon strawberry jam, plus more for serving

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

marshmallows

Preheat the oven to 180°C (350°F) fan-forced.

Grease a 22 cm (8½ inch) round cake tin, 7 cm (2¾ inches) deep, and line it with baking paper. I used this super cute heart-shaped tin, which is 21 x 22 cm (8 x 8½ inches), give or take.

In a large bowl, mix the batter ingredients together well. Pour the batter into the tin and spread to the edges.

Place the strawberries cut-side up in a line across the middle of the cake.

Place in the oven and bake for 30 minutes. Remove the cake and place the cut marshmallows on either side of the strawberries. Bake for a further 10 minutes (or just continue cooking if you aren't including the marshies!).

Allow the cake to cool in the tray until the marshmallows have set, around 10 minutes. Turn the cake out onto a large flat plate and then quickly flip it back over onto a wire rack lined with baking paper so that it's the right way up.

Microwave the jam for 30 seconds and then brush the runny jam over the strawberries.

Dust with some more desiccated coconut and serve with additional warmed runny strawberry jam.





Beet Whoopie Pies

I go below the belt when trying to get an ingredient across the line by pairing it with chocolate.

I have this urge to hide loathed ingredients in recipes and feed them to my family, who in turn LOVE it. It really fills my cup, you know, winning that kind of war.

So many of us have grown up being forced to eat things we don't like and threatened with blindness and our arms falling off if we don't. This way I feel like we all win.

The target was my husband and his beet disgust. He ate this with glee.

And while I personally don't think this is the BEST way to enjoy the earthy sweetness of the beautiful betanin-filled root, it does prove a point: everyone/thing can be delicious with the right wingman.

Makes 6 whopping whoopie pies!

BEETROOT JAM

1 large beetroot, leaves trimmed and skin on
¼ cup (55 g) caster (superfine) sugar

FILLING

1 cup (230 g) cream cheese
½ cup (60 g) icing (confectioners') sugar

PIES

½ cup (125 g) cold unsalted butter, coarsely chopped

1 cup (220 g) firmly packed soft brown sugar
1 large cold egg
1½ cups (220 g) plain (all-purpose) flour
½ cup (40 g) unsweetened cocoa powder, sifted
½ teaspoon bicarbonate (baking) soda
pinch of fine salt
1½ cups (225 g) dark chocolate, chopped, and/or choc chips, or a
mix of dark and milk chocolate

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

a dislike for beetroot

To make the beetroot jam, steam the beetroot for 20–30 minutes until tender. It should be easily pierced with a sharp knife when done. Allow it to cool, then peel and blitz in a food processor.

In a small saucepan over medium–high heat, bring ½ cup (125 ml) of the beetroot purée and the caster sugar to the boil, stirring. Reduce the heat to low and simmer for 2–3 minutes, until reduced by half. Remove from the heat and allow to cool. This makes ¼ cup (60 ml) of beetroot jam. Set aside.*

For the filling, in the bowl of a standmixer fitted with the paddle attachment, beat the cream cheese and icing sugar on medium–high for 3 minutes, until smooth. Place this into a piping bag and into the fridge ready to go.

Now the pies. In the standmixer again, cream the butter and sugar on low for 8 minutes, until pale and creamy. Add the egg and beat until just combined. Add the flour, cocoa, bicarb soda, salt and half

of the beetroot jam. Beat on low speed until a soft cookie dough forms, around 5 minutes.

Add the chunks of chocolate and stir well. I did this by hand so the beater didn't break up the chunks too much.

Divide the dough into six pieces, roughly 150 g (5½ oz) each. Divide each piece into two pieces: $\frac{2}{3}$ for the base, $\frac{1}{3}$ for the top.

Use your fingers to mould each base into an 11 cm (4¼ inch) patty. Create a slight indent in the base with a 1 cm (½ inch) rim to hold the cream cheese and jam, then mould each top piece into a slightly smaller, 9.5 cm (3½ inch), lid.

Pipe 1 tablespoon of the cream cheese mixture onto the centre of the bases, then dollop 1 teaspoon of beetroot jam on top. Place the lids on the whoopie pies and squish the sides of the bases up to join together with the lids to completely enclose the cream cheese and jam. You may need to sculpt them a bit to shape them back into cookies.

Place them on a baking tray lined with baking paper and freeze for 20 minutes.

Meanwhile, preheat the oven to 180°C (350°F) fan-forced.

Bake for 20 minutes. Rest for 10 minutes on a wire rack. Break open. Eat. Burn mouth.

* Leftovers can be stored in an airtight container in the fridge for 1 week.





Yogalatte

Best eaten wearing (in)activewear.

Halfway between ranting about not having time to do yoga or go to Pilates my mind merged the two words into the perfect portmanteau – and the yogalatte recipe was born.

It's tangy, sweet and caffeinated. It feels mature enough to have after dinner but fun enough to have during the day.

I actually don't care when you have it, it has three ingredients and is as easy AF (which is the most important thing for me – possibly before flavour when it comes to sweets).

Serves 6

¼ cup (60 ml) espresso coffee

1 cup (125 g) icing (confectioners') sugar

2 cups (520 g) Greek-style yoghurt

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

summer – don't wait for warmth to make this!

Combine the warm espresso and icing sugar in a vessel and mix well. If the espresso is cold, then warm it slightly so everything melts together. Set aside to cool.

Add this mixture to the yoghurt and mix well.

Freeze completely in ice cube trays for a minimum of 4 hours.

Once frozen, process in the food processor until smooth.

Serve immediately.

You could churn this in an ice-cream machine instead, or freeze it like granita to fork-shave.





Borrowed Banana Pancakes

Great to make with kids ... until you add the booze.

My friend Usher does two things really well: wine, and delicious morning-after banana pancakes. He's given me the recipe for both, but I can't be bothered with the wine; the pancakes seem far easier.

And true to form, I have jumped from a stack of pancakes to one big flat pancake, which makes sense for sharing with a cutie. There's no waiting between pancake flipping.

I've also made a luxuriously boozy caramel to pour all over it, which I have been warned is an excessive and wasteful use of Usher's rare batch whisky. So feel free to sub this out for your preferred golden liquor.

Serves 2

2 overripe bananas, mashed, plus 2 small bananas, halved
lengthways

1 egg

¼ cup (35 g) plain (all-purpose) flour

½ cup (70 g) self-raising flour

1 cup (250 ml) milk

50 g (1¾ oz) salted butter

CARAMEL SAUCE

1 cup (220 g) firmly packed soft brown sugar

⅓ cup (80 ml) whisky

¼ cup (60 ml) golden syrup

50 g (1¾ oz) salted butter

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

toasted pecans and Greek-style yoghurt

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced.

Combine the mashed banana, egg, flours and milk in a medium bowl and mix well.

Heat half the butter in a large ovenproof frying pan over medium–low heat.

Once the butter is bubbling, pour all of the batter into the centre of the pan and fry until bubbles form on top. Transfer the pan to the oven for 15 minutes to cook through. It will be golden and sponge-like when done.

Meanwhile, for the caramel sauce, stir the brown sugar, whisky, golden syrup and butter in a small saucepan over medium heat until the sugar has dissolved. Simmer for 2 minutes, then take off the heat and keep warm.

Finally, heat the remaining 25 g (1 oz) of butter in a frying pan over medium heat, add the halved bananas and cook for 2–3 minutes on each side, until golden.

Top the hot pancake with the fried bananas and the warm caramel sauce and serve straight from the frying pan.





Any Berry Lemon Thyme Tart

A pretty fabulous showstopper.

A perfect summer pie with completely interchangeable fruit. Do peach, strawberry, whatever you like, just don't omit the lemon thyme because it makes this dessert really sophisticated – and not even in a smarmy way.

Serves 8

375 g (13 oz) blueberries, fresh or frozen
375 g (13 oz) blackberries, fresh or frozen
½ cup (125 ml) berry jam
juice and finely grated zest of 1 orange
1½ cups (330 g) caster (superfine) sugar
1 teaspoon cinnamon
5 sheets ready-made frozen shortcrust pastry
1 kg (2 lb 4 oz) fresh ricotta
1 teaspoon vanilla bean paste
1 egg, plus an extra egg, whisked together with 1 tablespoon milk,
for glazing
2 teaspoons lemon thyme
1 tablespoon raw sugar

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

cream to serve

Place the berries, jam and orange juice in a bowl to macerate for 20 minutes.

Meanwhile, combine $\frac{1}{2}$ cup (110 g) of the caster sugar and the cinnamon in a small bowl.

Lay the pastry sheets out on your benchtop and sprinkle the cinnamon sugar on top. Carefully fold the corners of each sheet into the middle (see the little photo)*. Stack the folded sheets on top of each other and pat them down to push out any air. Roll the pastry out into a rustic 40 cm (16 inch) circle, around 5 mm ($\frac{1}{4}$ inch) thick.

Place the pastry on a baking tray lined with baking paper and pop in the fridge for 20 minutes.

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced.

Combine the ricotta, vanilla, one egg, orange zest, remaining 1 cup (220 g) caster sugar and the lemon thyme in a large bowl and mix well. Set aside.

Strain the macerated berries over a bowl, reserving both the liquid and the fruit.

Once the pastry has had time to rest and chill, remove it from the fridge and spread the ricotta mixture in the centre, leaving a 5 cm (2 inch) clean edge. The ricotta layer will be around 3 cm ($1\frac{1}{4}$ inches) thick.

Place the drained fruit on top and fold the edges up around the ricotta.

Brush the pastry with egg wash and sprinkle with raw sugar.

Bake for 15 minutes, until golden brown and bubbling.

Allow to cool before cutting.

Serve with a drizzle of the reserved macerating juice.

* Pimping store-bought pastry is a situation I can't get enough of.





Hippyish Pie

Simple pleasures is an understatement. This recipe gives you access to full-blown organic endorphins.

The C on the top of this pie stands for Charlotte, my sister, who helped me work out the mystery of the spices in the pie. As kids, we would sit naked in a galvanised bath in front of the kitchen campfire, warm from flames on one side and chilly from the evening air on the other. We'd eat bowls of this warm pie with cream – it's one of my favourite memories.

Do yourself a favour, make this, run a bath and eat it there.

I've made this with wholemeal flour because that's what Mum did – it kind of felt like punishment as a kid, but now I get it. All consumption, like good deeds, works on a checks and balances system, and I owe my body a lot of wholemeal flour.

Serves 6

1 tablespoon milk, for glazing

½ teaspoon demerara sugar, for sprinkling

FILLING

1 kg (2 lb 4 oz) pumpkin, peeled and seeds removed, chopped into chunks

350 g (12 oz) carrots, chopped into chunks

⅓ cup (65 g) raw sugar

¼ cup (60 ml) lemon juice

1 tablespoon finely grated lemon zest

1 teaspoon golden syrup

1 tablespoon sultanas

½ teaspoon nutmeg

1 teaspoon mixed spice

½ teaspoon cinnamon

PIE PASTRY

1 cup (150 g) wholemeal (whole-wheat) plain flour

1 cup (150 g) self-raising flour

pinch of sea salt flakes

⅔ cup (160 g) cold salted butter, cubed

1 egg

2 tablespoons caster (superfine) sugar

1 teaspoon cinnamon

OPTIONAL INGREDIENTS

nakedness and warmed cream

Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F) fan-forced.

Steam the pumpkin and carrots for 15 minutes, or until tender.

Blend the pumpkin, carrots, sugar, lemon juice and zest in a food processor until smooth. Stir through the golden syrup, sultanas and spices and set aside.

For the pastry, blend all the ingredients in a food processor until the mixture resembles breadcrumbs. Then knead it together on a lightly floured surface to form a pastry dough.

Cut off a quarter of the pastry and set aside.

Roll out three-quarters of the pastry into a circle until it's 5 mm thick, then press into a greased 24 cm (9½ inch) shallow old-school pie tin. You could use a quiche tin if you can't find one like this.

Fill the case with the pumpkin mixture and level it out. Brush the edges with milk.

Roll out the remaining quarter of the pastry and place it on top of the pie. Use the back of a spoon to cut/press the edges to seal. Decorate the pie with the leftover scraps of dough – letters, leaves, roses, whatever you like. When I was a kid this was one of the bits we loved the most – and picking them off to eat them once cooked.

Brush the pie lid all over with more milk and sprinkle with the demerara sugar.

Bake for approximately 1 hour, or until golden.

Allow to cool down to warm before serving. It is crumbly and comforting – embrace it, we've all been like that.





Snack, Crackle & Chew

Three ice-cream toppings – each superb on its own, but when combined you have an instant Snickers-style sundae.

Makes toppings for 4

Pantry Crumble

½ cup (70 g) plain (all-purpose) flour

¼ cup (60 g) firmly packed soft brown sugar

⅓ cup (50 g) nuts and/or seeds*

1 teaspoon finely grated lemon zest
¼ cup (60 g) cold salted butter, cubed
½ cup (15 g) rice bubbles

Preheat the oven to 180°C (350°F) fan-forced and line a baking tray with baking paper.

In a bowl, combine the flour, sugar, mixed nuts and seeds and lemon zest. Add the chopped butter and combine using your fingertips until it resembles breadcrumbs. Stir through the rice bubbles.

Spread out on the baking tray and bake for 10 minutes.

* For this crumble you can use whatever nuts/seeds/muesli scraps you can find in the pantry – it's about the sugar and butter, really.

Choc-top

1 cup (150 g) dark chocolate, chopped
¼ cup (60 ml) coconut oil

First, chuck out that weird chemical topping that you bought from the store.

Combine the chocolate and coconut oil in a glass bowl and microwave for 30 seconds. Stir well and microwave for another 30 seconds.

Peanut Schmeer

$\frac{3}{4}$ cup (215 g) crunchy peanut butter

$\frac{1}{2}$ cup (125 ml) maple syrup

2 tablespoons hot water

Combine all ingredients together. That's it. This is good on rice crackers too. Anywhere really.



L > R: Cucumber & Dill in Basic Pickle; Pickle Curry Cauli Pickle; Young Ginger in Basic Pickle; Baby Beshy; Chilli Crisp



L > R: Scrap Pesto; Bready Pesto made with sun-dried tomato; Coconut Sambal; Mexican Seasoning; Everything Bagel Seasoning

Condiments

This section is just a lecture really. Don't waste anything. Pickle it, blend it or rub it with spice. But it's also a hack page. A few quick notes to remind you that we all get to have a second wind, so hit the ground running when you do.

Basic Pickle

½ cup (125 ml) white vinegar
2 teaspoons caster sugar
1 teaspoon sea salt flakes

ADDITIONS

½-1 teaspoon each star anise, coriander root, mustard seeds, dill, fennel seeds, cumin, etc.

Combine the vinegar, sugar and salt with 1 cup (250 ml) water, then plonk anything into it: ginger, cucumber, carrot, onion – it works for everything. Spice it up with some of the suggested additions.

Curry Pickle

500 g (1 lb 2 oz) vegetables of your choice, trimmed if necessary
¼ cup (125 ml) fine sea salt
1 cup (250 ml) white vinegar
½ cup (110 g) caster sugar

1 dried bay leaf
1 teaspoon mustard seeds
1 tablespoon curry powder
1 teaspoon turmeric powder
1 dried red chilli

Toss the trimmed veg in the salt and set aside.

Simmer the rest of the ingredients and 1 cup (250 ml) water on the stovetop just until the sugar dissolves.

Rinse the salt from the veg and place the veg in a sealable jar.

Pour the pickle juice over the veg while still warm, seal and place in the fridge overnight. Store in the fridge for up to 1 week.

Baby Beshy

25 g (1 oz) salted butter
1½ tablespoons flour
¼ cup (60 ml) milk

Melt the butter, then add the flour and stir to form a golden paste. Whisk in the milk, then stir over low heat until it thickens. Season well. You can add more milk/liquid if you need. Add ½ cup (50 g) cheese of your choice to make a beautifully creamy cheese sauce.

This recipe can be doubled or quadrupled (I seem to use it often!).

Chilli Crisp

¼ cup (20 g) chilli flakes
2 tablespoons sesame seeds
1 teaspoon fine salt
1 teaspoon chicken-style stock powder
2 garlic cloves, crushed
1 cup (250 ml) peanut oil
1 tablespoon crispy fried shallots
1 teaspoon szechuan peppercorns

Combine the chilli flakes, sesame seeds, salt, stock powder and garlic in a heatproof bowl and set aside.

Heat the peanut oil, fried shallots and peppercorns in a medium saucepan over medium–low heat until the mixture simmers. Continue cooking for 2–3 minutes, then carefully pour it over the spice mix, allowing it to crackle. Let it cool, then store in a jar in the fridge for up to 3 weeks.

Scrap Pesto

25 g (1 oz) leafy stuff (carrot tops, spinach, rocket, kale)
25 g (1 oz) soft herbs (basil, parsley, mint, coriander)
5 g (⅛ oz) woody herbs (thyme, rosemary, oregano)
2 tablespoons nuts (almonds, pine nuts, walnuts, hazelnuts, macadamias)
25 g (1 oz) hard cheese (parmy, pecorino, goat)
1 small garlic clove, crushed
2 teaspoons something acidic (lemon juice, red wine vinegar)

⅓–½ cup (80–125 ml) extra virgin olive oil, depending on how loose you like pesto

Blend the ingredients in a food processor until smooth, chunky or loose – however you like it. Store in an airtight container in the fridge for up to 3 days.

Use on pasta, toast, eggs, whatevs.

Bready Pesto

½ cup something chunky (sun-dried toms, olives, artichokes, deli veg, roast veg)

1 garlic clove

½ cup (50 g) hard cheese (parmy, pecorino, goat)

2 teaspoons chilli flakes

1 teaspoon mustard

5 g (⅛ oz) woody herbs (thyme, rosemary, oregano)

2 teaspoons something acidic (lemon juice, red wine vinegar)

½ cup (125 g) extra virgin olive oil

1 cup (110 g) breadcrumbs

Blend everything but the breadcrumbs in a food processor until smooth, chunky or loose – however you like it. Stir through the breadcrumbs then store in an airtight container in the fridge for up to 3 days.

It's good as a crust for baked things and great on pasta.

Coconut Sambal

3 tablespoons crispy fried shallots

3 tablespoons desiccated coconut

1 teaspoon chilli flakes

½ teaspoon ground coriander seeds

1 teaspoon makrut lime leaf, crushed

1 teaspoon sea salt flakes

Combine the ingredients and store in an airtight container for up to 3 weeks.

Add some fresh lime zest on the day of serving (it will turn brown if you add it sooner).

Mexican Seasoning

2 tablespoons dried oregano

2 tablespoons chilli flakes

1½ tablespoons ground cumin

1 tablespoon ground coriander seeds

2 teaspoons ground cinnamon

1 tablespoon garlic powder

1 tablespoon onion powder

Combine and store in an airtight container for 3 weeks.

Everything Bagel Seasoning

⅓ cup (55 g) garlic granules

$\frac{1}{3}$ cup (25 g) dried onion flakes

$\frac{2}{3}$ cup (100 g) white sesame seeds

$\frac{1}{3}$ cup (50 g) black sesame seeds

$\frac{1}{4}$ cup (30 g) fennel seeds

$\frac{1}{4}$ cup (40 g) poppy seeds

Combine and store in an airtight container for up to 3 weeks.



Thank You

I feel incredibly fortunate to have grown up eating produce grown on land that has been cared for for over 50,000 years by the Traditional Owners of Country throughout Australia. Specifically in my life, the Gadigal people of the Darkinjung, Dharug and Eora Nations. I recognise their continuing connection to land, water and culture. Along with paying my respects to their Elders past, present and emerging, I also commit to the continued care of this beautiful land where we all live, work and play.

I'd like to extend my deep appreciation to all First Nations peoples on this planet. Without their traditions of caring for the environment, food culture would be an undeniably dull space.

I am grateful for every new food experience, from the simplest to the most complex. It's these inspirational delights that energise this book from beginning to end.

The Cabin Staff: Jaimee, Katja and Breesa. We cooked and created together, and I could not have achieved this book without them. Aside from their passion for food, the killer quips made every day ridiculously fun.

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Inflight Entertainment: as always, the Instagram community, which cajoles, ridicules and champions food, laughter and play. This community inspires me daily. You guys feel like friends.

And, of course, after a strange journey using travel analogies on this page, we reach our Final Destination: Home! It's where the heart beats, aches, imagines, creates, empties and fills ... daily.

Andy, James, Beau and Winter. Thank you for trying everything even when you weren't in the mood, laughing with/at me/each other and reinforcing my 'crumb + fry it' theory.

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OVEN GUIDE: You may find cooking times vary depending on the oven you are using. For fan-forced ovens, as a general rule, set the oven temperature to 20°C (35°F) lower than indicated in the recipe.

TABLESPOON MEASURES: We have used 20 ml (4 teaspoon) tablespoon measures. If you are using a 15 ml (3 teaspoon) tablespoon add an extra teaspoon of the ingredient for each tablespoon specified.

